THURSDAY
October 22, 2026

INTERNATIONAL EDITION
18 Pages

THE HINDU

www.thehindu.com

INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

Vol. 4 • No. 250

To subscribe, give a missed call at 9828331787 or scan QR code

Chennai » Coimbatore » Bengaluru » Hyderabad » Madurai » Noida » Visakhapatnam » Thiruvananthapuram » Kochi » Vijayawada » Mangaluru » Tiruchirapalli » Kolkata » Hubballi » Mohali » Malappuram » Mumbai » Lucknow » Cuttack » Patna



RISING UNREST

Manipur groups seek President's Rule again

NEWS » PAGE 4



ENERGY AMBITIONS

Rubio visits Reliance refinery

NEWS » PAGE 4



CYBER BREACH

8 web security keys of eMudhra firm leaked

BUSINESS » PAGE 12

TWO CHOKEPOINTS, ONE CRISIS

Saudi Arabia in dire straits

Riyadh faces growing threats to its influence, security, and oil exports

EDITORIAL » PAGE 8



T20I CHALLENGE

India-NZ five-match series from today

SPORT » PAGE 16

INSIDE



Rahul questions the motive behind Epstein-Puri photo

NEW DELHI
Questioning the timing of the release of a photograph of Union Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri with convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday asked who the U.S. was trying to blackmail. » PAGE 5

Nestle India and Zydus Wellness get FSSAI notice

NEW DELHI
The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has issued notices to Nestle India and Zydus Wellness over "misleading claims" in certain products, seeking scientific evidence to support their advertisements. » PAGE 6

Suspected IED blast injures two in Bengaluru

BENGALURU
Two persons were injured in a blast suspected to have been triggered by an improvised explosive device (IED) at an under-construction building in Pulakeshinagar in East Bengaluru, Karnataka, on Tuesday. » PAGE 3

Trade ties on the agenda as Modi meets Polish PM

NEW DELHI
Building trade and defence ties as well as discussing the war in Ukraine will be at the top of the agenda as Poland Prime Minister Donald Tusk meets Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday. The visit will also serve to deepen the India-EU strategic ties, the External Affairs Ministry said. » PAGE 5



Putin agrees to resume dialogue with U.S., Ukraine

ST PETERSBURG
Russian President Vladimir Putin has agreed to resume U.S.-mediated peace talks with Ukraine as soon as next month, the Kremlin said on Wednesday, after the leader held negotiations with U.S. envoy Steve Witkoff. » PAGE 14

Core industrial growth hits historic high of 7.9%

Index of Core Industries in Sept. records highest growth since new data series began in April 2024; coal, refinery products, iron ore drive growth; cement and steel also see robust increase

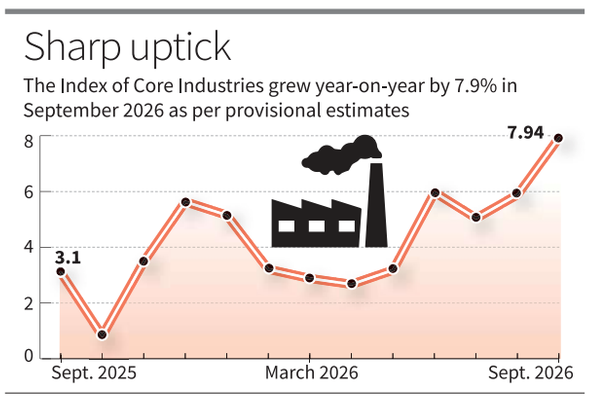
T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

India's core industrial growth accelerated to a historic high of 7.9% in September, driven by a turnaround in the coal sector and increased activity in the refinery products and iron ore sectors.

The latest data on the Index of Core Industries shows that last month's growth was the highest since at least April 2024, which is the earliest month for which the new series has data.

Even though a comparison with the old series is not strictly statistically sound, it does provide some context for the current rate of growth. The growth in September 2026 was the highest in nearly three years when compared with the old series.

Within the index, the coal sector grew 10.7% last month, albeit on a low base as it had contracted 1.1% in September last year. This was still a 13-month high for the sector. Similarly, the refinery products sector saw growth unexpectedly accelerate to 10.3% in September, from 5.6% a month earlier. Even after including this month's unusual growth, however, the sector's average growth for the first half of this financial year stood at just 1%.



The iron ore sector, on the other hand, has seen strong double-digit growth for nearly a year now, and last month carried forward this trend with growth coming in at 18.4%, though this was only a two-month high.

"Coal and iron ore output witnessed a meaningful pickup in their year-on-year growth rates in September 2026 compared to August 2026," Aditi Nayar, chief economist at ICRA, said. "While this was aided by a low base, the sequential uptick in coal was quite strong, amid low stocks at power plants."

The electricity sector also continued to do well, growing 11.4% last month, although this was slightly slower than the 13.1% recorded in August.

Cement, steel sectors

The two construction-related sectors – cement and steel – did well in September. While growth in the steel sector quickened to 4.9%, that in the cement sector came in at a relatively robust 9.8%, albeit slower than in August.

The domestic crude oil sector contracted 1.4% in September, somewhat better than the contraction of 3.6% in the previous month. The natural gas sector contracted 4.6% last month, a little better than the 4.9% contraction it saw in August.

The fertilizer sector contracted 11.7% in September, continuing the trend for a seventh consecutive month.

Back to freedom



Saurav Das, chief spokesperson of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), and Ashutosh Ranka, CJP co-convenor, speak to the media after being released following a hearing before a Special Executive Magistrate, in New Delhi, on Wednesday. REUTERS (REPORT: PAGE 5)

SC stays corruption probe against former Keralam CM Vijayan for seven days

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI



The SC directed the Kerala High Court to hear the appeals filed by former Keralam CM Pinarayi Vijayan against the FIR. FILE PHOTO

The Supreme Court on Wednesday stayed for seven days a State police investigation into a first information report (FIR) registered against former Chief Minister and current Leader of the Opposition in the Keralam Assembly Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter T. Veena, and son-in-law and former Minister P.A. Mohamed Riyas in the ₹2.78-crore CMRL-Exalogic payoff case.

A Special Bench of the top court, comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V. Mohana, convened in the middle of Dasara vacations to hear 82-year-old Mr. Vijayan, who voiced fears of imminent arrest, and his two family members.

The top court set aside an October 15 order of the Kerala High Court Division Bench and directed it to hear the appeals filed by Mr. Vijayan and the other two petitioners against the registration of the corruption FIR. Justice Bagchi reminded the State that no matter how low or high a person was, he was subject to the rule of law and principles of natural justice.

'Will not disturb FIR'

"We will not disturb the FIR, but we will stall the investigation... Further, we are sending this case back to the High Court for adjudication," Justice Bagchi observed.

A Single Judge Bench of the Kerala High Court had directed the State Police to register the FIR under the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988 against the three of them based on information given by a central agency, the Directorate of Enforcement, to the Kerala Police under Section 66(2) of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002.

Mr. Vijayan and the other two co-petitioners, represented variously by senior advocates Siddharth Luthra, N. Hariharan, and advocate Krishna Dev Jagarlamudi, submitted in the top court that they were neither made parties nor heard by the Single Judge Bench before the registration of the FIR was ordered on October 9.

The petitioners were denied leave (permission) to appeal the Single Judge Bench order by a Division Bench on October 15, compelling them to approach the Supreme Court.

The Special Bench did not record any opinions on the validity of a subsequent Enforcement Case Information Report (ECIR) registered against the petitioners. However, the top court gave them liberty to challenge the ECIR before the appropriate forum in accordance with the law.

In the hearing, the State argued that the top court's own 2022 judgment in *Vijay Madanlal Chaudhary versus Union of India* had termed the ED's passing on of information or material regarding an alleged crime under Section 66(2) of the PMLA as a "direction" to the State to register an FIR.

Justice Bagchi said States cannot treat judgments as statutes. The Bench observed that Section 66(2) of the PMLA was not a "mandate", but only an "intimation" of information or material with the ED to another agency. It was solely for the latter agency – the Kerala Police in this case – to decide if "any other law" applied, requiring the lodging of an FIR.

"The PMLA cannot be a 'Super Administrator', mandating everything everywhere. Every executive exercise of power [like the registration of an FIR] cannot be assumed by the PMLA," Justice Bagchi observed.

The judge addressed the ED to not "extend" their statutory powers under the PMLA. While the ED had "full powers" to investigate hawala operators to former Chief Ministers under the PMLA, it would not "meddle in the statutory domains of other entities", Justice Bagchi said.

The judge asked whether the police had even sought prior approval under Section 17A of the 1988 Act from the government for investigating a former Chief Minister.

Justice Bagchi asked whether the State had gone through the new criminal procedure provisions of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS). The judge said unlike Section 156(3) of the repealed Code of Criminal Procedure, Section 175(4) of the BNSS required the Magistrate to formally hear an accused public servant.

The Bench also "corrected" the State's version that the probe under the FIR was "court-ordered". "It is an investigation on the basis of information given by the ED," Justice Bagchi said.

The apex court said all these issues discussed in the courtroom on October 21 must be looked into by the High Court Division Bench while hearing the appeals of the petitioners.

Data breach exposes 3,897 SBI customers' key data on Dark Web

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

The State Bank of India (SBI) on Wednesday informed stock exchanges about an incident involving breach of certain data, five days after it received communications from its Threat Intelligence Service Provider, the Defence Cyber Agency, and CERT-In concerning a suspected exposure of customer information on the Dark Web.

"During the preliminary analysis of approximately 3,75,000 records available on the Dark Web, 3,897 customer records containing Personally Identifiable Information were identified," SBI told the exchanges as per SEBI norms, and noted that cyber incident response and containment protocols were promptly activated.

The exposed information included customers' registered mobile numbers, dates of birth, names, gender, email addresses, residential addresses, branch and CIF identifiers, lead IDs, and metadata associated with loan/lead records and other related files, SBI, stated.

It said a detailed investigation was required to establish the authenticity and completeness of the exposed data, determine the potential source and extent of the exposure, and assess the associated risks to customers and the bank.



SBI said a detailed investigation would establish the authenticity of the data, the potential source, and extent of the exposure. REUTERS

Additionally, an independent CERT-In-empanelled cybersecurity agency was engaged to conduct a comprehensive assessment and investigate the nature and extent of the alleged compromise, it said.

Emphasising that this incident does not have any material impact on the bank's financial performance or business continuity, SBI said that it's core business functions continue to operate normally without disruptions.

"A detailed assessment is currently under way and appropriate remedial and preventive measures are being implemented as required," the bank said.

Meanwhile, the Internet Freedom Foundation, in a statement issued on Wednesday, said that the SBI did not detect the breach itself and learned of it from outside agencies after the data had already been published.

"On the same day, a threat monitoring account on X flagged a claim by a group calling itself "Siriusim" that it had released 3.75 lakh rows of SBI data and 2,722 PDF documents, including loan applications and account opening forms," the Foundation said.

"The bank's disclosure does not mention these documents. It also does not say what the remaining records, beyond the 3,897 it has identified, contain," it stated.

'Inform customers'

At the time of this statement, the Foundation pointed out that SBI had not said that it had informed any of the affected customers, and its disclosure was silent on the point.

"Five days passed between the alert and today's filing. The filing assures investors that the incident has no material impact on the bank's operations. However, it does not state anything to the 3,897 people whose phone numbers, dates of birth and home addresses are now with fraudsters," the Foundation highlighted.

The Internet Freedom Foundation called on SBI to inform every affected customer directly and without further delay.

INBRIEF



T.N. Governor pays tributes to Vummidi Ethirajulu

T.N. Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar on Wednesday paid tribute to Vummidi Ethirajulu, who played an instrumental role in designing and making the *sengol*, the golden sceptre (in picture) installed in the new Parliament House. In a post on X, the Lok Bhavan quoted the Governor as saying, "Vummidi Ethirajulu, who played a historic role in making the sacred *Sengol* in 1947, at the age of 20, has passed away. His contribution to the creation of the *Sengol*, a timeless symbol of India's civilisational heritage, righteous governance, and the transfer of power at the dawn of Independence, will always be remembered with reverence and pride."

PM to visit Bihar's Bhagalpur on Nov. 20 to launch projects

Prime Minister Narendra Modi is likely to visit Bihar's Bhagalpur district on November 20 to inaugurate and lay the foundation stones of several projects related to electricity, higher education, air connectivity and infrastructure development. Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary held a high-level meeting of officials on Wednesday to review preparations for the visit. According to sources in the BJP, Mr. Modi might inaugurate the 2,400 MW greenfield ultra-supercritical coal-fired Pirpainti Thermal Power project in Bhagalpur.

Bengal govt. sets up SIT to probe Kolkata Durga Puja pandal stampede

Six-member team headed by Justice Anindita Roy Saraswati (retd.) will investigate the incident at Chorbagan that claimed 19 lives on October 17; report to be submitted within three months

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

The West Bengal government on Wednesday issued an order setting up a Special Investigation Team (SIT) to undertake a comprehensive, impartial and thorough inquiry into the stampede at Chorbagan Sarbojanin Durga Puja Pandal here which claimed 19 lives on October 17.

The six-member SIT will be headed by Justice Anindita Roy Saraswati (retd.) and comprise officials of the State government as well as a representative of National Disaster Response Force.

After the incident, Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari had said that the SIT will be headed by a sitting judge of the Calcutta High Court. However, on October 20 a Division Bench presided by Chief Justice Ravindra V. Ghuge said a sitting judge of the High Court could not be appointed to head an inquiry, in accordance with a Supreme Court directive.



Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari handing over a cheque to family members of a stampede victim on Wednesday. PTI

The SIT shall submit its report, together with its findings and recommendations, to the State government within three months from the date of issue of the order, the notification by the State government stated.

The order, signed by State's Chief Secretary Manoj Agarwal, said that the SIT will ascertain the time, location and manner in which the initial crowd surge occurred and developed into a stampede and examine the prevailing weather conditions, including relevant meteorological reports and rainfall or thunderstorm bulletins, and their possible impact on crowd movement.

The SIT will also inspect and assess the condition and adequacy of passages, barricades, stairways, gates, emergency exits and other structural and access arrangements at the pandal and examine whether permissions were granted in accordance with applicable rules and whether adequate crowd-management plans, disaster-management plans were in place.

Chorbagan Sarbojanin Durga Puja Pandal, which was inaugurated by Mr. Adhikari himself, was drawing large crowds till the tragedy occurred on the evening of October 17. Most of the deceased were women and children. Seven persons, including the organisers of the Durga Puja pandal, have been arrested.

CM meets kin of victims

Meanwhile, Mr. Adhikari for the second consecutive day met the families of the victims. He visited New Barrackpore and New Town areas and handed over a cheque of ₹ 25 lakh to kin of each deceased. The State government has promised a compensation of ₹25 lakh to the next of kin of the deceased.

Kunal Ghosh, spokesperson of Mamata All India Trinamool Congress, said that unless the BJP leaders who were in charge of the Durga Puja pandal are arrested, the SIT has no real purpose.

Cong. alleges voter roll manipulation in Pilibhit constituency

Press Trust of India
LUCKNOW



Cong. leaders Supriya Shrinate and Rajendra Pal Gautam at a press conference in Lucknow on Wednesday. ANI

The Uttar Pradesh Congress on Wednesday alleged large-scale manipulation of electoral rolls in Pilibhit Sadar Assembly constituency, claiming that names of 13,150 voters were changed while their EPIC and serial numbers remained the same.

Addressing a press conference at the Uttar Pradesh Congress Committee headquarters in Lucknow, AICC in-charge for U.P. Rajendra Pal Gautam alleged that the Election Commission had created a system through which "anyone can be defeated, and anyone can be made to win".

He claimed that after the final draft of the special intensive revision (SIR) electoral roll was published on April 10, 2026, changes were made to voter details between July and September without altering their EPIC and serial numbers.

"A voter sees his name, address, EPIC number and serial number in the final draft and assumes that his vote is secure. But if the name is changed later, he may be told on polling day that his name is not in the electoral roll despite having an EPIC card and identity proof," Mr. Gautam said.

He claimed that in Pilibhit Sadar, names of 13,150 voters were changed, 884 names were deleted despite the voters continuing to reside there, and 2,600 names were added of people who allegedly did not live in the area. This, according to him, amounted to manipulation involving 16,554 votes.

'Party preparing list'

Mr. Gautam mentioned party workers were preparing booth-wise lists of such cases and claimed that similar irregularities could have occurred in other Assembly constituencies as well.

Congress spokesperson Supriya Shrinate alleged that voter names were being deleted, added and changed through the Election Commission's software and technology.

Murdered anti-drug crusader's family, Oppn. seek resignation of Mann as CBI launches probe

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Even as Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) registered a case into the alleged murder of anti-drug crusader Parvinder Singh Jhota in Punjab's Mansa, his family members and Opposition parties on Wednesday demanded Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann's resignation.

The BJP's Punjab unit supported the demand for the CM's resignation, asserting that the Punjab government should also transfer the cases surrounding Gulzar Singh and Bikramjit Singh, who lost their lives in incidents related to the drug menace, to the CBI.

Punjab BJP chief Kewal Singh Dhillon said Union Home Minister Amit Shah has kept his promise with the CBI launching its investigation into Jhota's case.



Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann

The Leader of Opposition in the Punjab Assembly, Congress's Partap Singh Bajwa, said the Chief Minister, who also holds the Home portfolio, has completely failed to maintain law and order. He said the Congress would demand Mr. Mann's resignation when the Assembly session commences on Thursday.

CBI officials on Wednesday said the agency has taken over the probe into the murder Mr. Jhota. A CBI team had reached Mansa police station on Tuesday night to take over records and seizures.

Inquest proceedings

Jhota's post-mortem is slated to be done at the Postgraduate Institute of Medical Education and Research in Chandigarh by a team of experts, the CBI said. Inquest proceedings to determine the cause of death will then be carried out by a magistrate in Chandigarh. However, Jhota's family and the Insaf Committee set up to secure justice for him have refused to cremate the body until their demands are met.

The Punjab government had earlier set up a three-member team of IPS officers for the case. Jhota was shot dead on October 13 at a local medical store in Mansa, sparking public outrage in the State.

2024 Cong. complaint to be primary charge against Veeramani

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

The first complaint lodged by M.P. Ranjan Kumar of the Congress on November 22, 2024, will be taken as the primary charge in the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act (POCSO) case against Gem Granites owner R. Veeramani, police sources said on Wednesday.

Mr. Kumar, president of Tamil Nadu Congress Committee's Scheduled Caste Department, had filed a complaint with then Additional Commissioner of Police, South, N. Kannan, seeking action against Veeramani and his associate, Shanthi. [This was first reported by *The Hindu*.]

He had alleged that Veeramani sexually exploited minors, mostly belonging to the Below Poverty Line category, and minority and SC communities. He also gave screenshots and later video evidence of the businessmen abusing a minor girl.



Gem Granites founder R. Veeramani.

'No case registered'

The complaint was referred to the then Commissioner of Police A. Arun who forwarded it to the Central Crime Branch (CCB) for investigation. However, no case was registered, the sources said.

Investigators are also in the process of arraigning N. Prakash as an accused in the POCSO Act cases.

Bihar relaxes curbs to provide jobs under VB-G RAM G in 38 districts hit by floods, drought

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

The Bihar Rural Development Department on Wednesday said employment will be provided under the Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G) scheme to workers in 22 flood-affected and 16 drought-hit districts.

Under the rural employment scheme, launched across the country on July 1, infrastructure development, asset creation and other development works are to be undertaken with funding shared by the Central and State governments in a 60:40 ratio.

According to an order issued by the department, urgent restoration and repair of damaged infrastructure is required in the 22 flood-hit districts. The department identified these districts as Arwal, Begusarai, Bhagalpur, Bhojpur, Buxar, Darbhanga, Gopalganj, Katihar, Khagaria, Lakhisarai, Madhepura, Munger, Muzaffarpur, West Champaran, Patna, East Champaran, Purnia, Saharsa, Samastipur, Saran, Supaul, and Vaishali.

Crops damaged

The order stated that there was substantial decline in demand for agricultural workers following damage to rabi crops in the 16 districts that experienced drought-like conditions this year due to below normal levels of rainfall.

These districts were identified as Araria, Aurangabad, Banka, Gaya Ji, Jamui, Jehanabad, Kaimur, Kishanganj, Madhubani, Nalanda, Nawada, Rohtas, Sheikhpura, Sheohar, Sitamarhi, and Siwan.

It added that employment opportunities must also be ensured for workers returning home in view of the upcoming festivals.

Earlier, the department had suspended construction work during the designated break from October 22 to December 10 to ensure that farm operations are not disrupted during the agricultural season.

However, officials said, the restrictions have now been lifted to provide employment to people in the disaster-hit areas.

"Bihar has been hit by disasters. Roads, bridges, culverts, pathways, embankments, and other infrastructure have suffered extensive damage. It is essential to repair and restore the damaged infrastructure so that development activities can be accelerated," Rural Development Minister Shravan Kumar told reporters.

CM orders action after Tripura youth 'harassed'

The Hindu Bureau
AGARTALA

Tripura Chief Minister Manik Saha on Wednesday directed in-charge DGP G.S. Rao to initiate legal action in coordination with the Delhi police against a national capital-based content creator for allegedly harassing a youth from the State.

Mr. Saha ordered the action after a video of Amir Shokeen making objectionable remarks about the youth, including calling him a "foreigner" and making fun of his appearance at an unidentified location in Delhi, went viral on social media on Tuesday. Mr. Shokeen has since apologised and claimed the video was "scripted".

Malfunctioning Pink Saheli smart cards cause chaos for women commuters, bus conductors in Delhi

Shrimansi Kaushik
NEW DELHI

Women travelling in Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) buses are facing significant hurdles due to malfunctioning Pink Saheli smart cards, forcing many to pay a replacement fee of ₹60 for new ones. Meanwhile, DTC bus conductors remain equally confused over whether to allow women without valid smart cards to travel for free or ask them to pay, citing conflicting instructions from different depot managements.

The Delhi government introduced the smart cards in March this year, making them mandatory for women to access free travel. Officially, the older paper tickets were supposed to be discontinued on October 1. However, due to non-functioning cards and varying instructions across depots, some bus conductors continue to issue free paper tickets while others ask women to pay.



Pink Saheli smart cards were set to replace pink paper tickets across the national capital from October 1. FILE PHOTO

For women whose cards fail, the Electronic Ticketing Machine (ETM) fails to link and displays a 'check validity' prompt. Beneficiaries are being asked to get their cards replaced at the depot.

Commuters' struggle

"I had to get a new card made after paying the amount. As per rules, you are supposed to pay this fee if you have lost your card or the card is damaged. Why should I pay if the original card never worked properly? Shouldn't it be replaced free of cost?" said Raunak, a student from Delhi University's Deshbandhu College. For her, the card worked in some buses, not in others.

For Antara, another student, the card never worked at all. "I, too, had to get it made again even though it never worked for me. The staff at Netaji Subhash Place depot said I might have damaged it, spilled water on it accidentally. That never happened. Why can't they check the cards before dispensing them?" she said.

Meanwhile, amid all these technical issues, the drastic reduction in card-issuing hubs from 70 to 38 across the city has resulted in long queues.

Conductors confused

Meanwhile, the DTC Karamchari Ekta Union has written to Managing Director Niharika Rai seeking clarification over "lack of consistency in instructions".

"In some instances, conductors are instructed to issue a manual pink ticket if the ETM malfunctions, while in others, they are directed to print a machine-generated 'free ticket' without a valid card. These inconsistencies are resulting in conductors being held responsible, with some depots demanding a recall of all manually given pink tickets and others prompting reports against conductors," the complaint letter said.

Engineering student found dead in hostel room in Mumbai

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

The incident at the ICT comes a month after a student of IIT-B ended his life

A student of second year of engineering at the Institute of Chemical Technology (ICT) here was found dead in his hostel room on the campus on Tuesday night, while protests continue at the Indian Institute of Technology-Bombay (IIT-B) over death of a student and demands for changes in system.

The ICT student has been identified as 19-year-old Siddhesh Patil, police said.

The institute administration took Patil to a hospital where doctors declared him to have died upon arrival, while Vice-Chancellor A.B. Pandit sent a message to students and faculty stating that police had been informed.

The over-90-year-old ICT is a premier public deemed university, specialising in chemical engineering, chemical technology, and pharmacy. The incident at the ICT happens a month after Sahil Wakode, a student of IIT-B, died by suicide on September 18, which triggered protests at the Powai campus.

(Those in distress can contact Tele MANAS at 14416 to seek help)

Published by Nirmala Lakshman at Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002 on behalf of THG PUBLISHING PVT.LTD. Editor: Suresh Nambath Chandrasekar (Responsible for selection of news under the PRP Act).

ISSN 0971 - 751X

INBRIEF



Cargo vessel sinks off Kerala coast; all crew members safe

A cargo vessel carrying about 160 tonnes of construction materials and other goods sank nearly 18 nautical miles off the Beypore coast in Kerala late on Tuesday night. All eight crew members were rescued by the Indian Coast Guard and brought ashore by Wednesday morning. The vessel, *MSV Jesus Heart*, was on its way from Beypore in Kozhikode district to Kavaratti in Lakshadweep when the accident occurred.

Three organisers surrender after tragedy at dandiya event

A 19-metre-high iron truss that collapsed onto students during dandiya celebrations at a college in Nadargul in Telangana on October 17, killing a student and injuring 22 others, was erected on just two pillars instead of four, the police said. Three persons involved in organising the event and installing the structure at the MVSR Engineering College surrendered before the police on Tuesday. Two faculty members who served as event coordinators are absconding.

5 held; gold smuggled from Bangladesh seized in A.P.

Five persons were arrested with foreign currency and smuggled gold near Vijayawada in Andhra Pradesh in an operation by the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) on Sunday. Investigators said the group was part of a smuggling network that sourced foreign-origin gold from Bangladesh and routed it through Kolkata before transporting it to Hyderabad. Gold and foreign currency seized from them were collectively valued at ₹5.84 crore.

SC extends date to publish final list of candidates in the fray for A.P. civic polls

Its directive to SEC came after YSRCP complained that its workers were stopped from contesting; Bench tells poll body to grant more time to file nominations in seats where there was violence

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI



Police personnel deployed in Pulivendula town last week following violence during the filing of nominations. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The Supreme Court directed the Andhra Pradesh State Election Commission (SEC) on Wednesday to postpone the publication of the final list of candidates contesting urban local bodies' (ULBs) elections in the State.

A Special Bench of Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V. Mohana convened in the middle of Dasara vacations to pass directions on a petition filed by the Opposition's Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party (YSRCP), which alleged that 63.5% of its candidates were "physically blocked" from filing nominations. The YSRCP blamed the "workers of the party in power" for resorting to large-scale violence in the run-up to the elections.

The Bench extended the date of publication of the final list of candidates till October 25. The final list was scheduled to be published on Wednesday.

The top court directed the SEC to consider representations of political parties and their candidates, including evidence, and take a call on extending the last date of filing nomination for candidates in the elections "wherever it [SEC] is of the view that candidates were unable to file". Such a decision must be taken positively by October 22. "The right to file nominations is a facet of free and fair elections," the top court observed.

'Provide security'

The court said that in urban body seats where the SEC was convinced that violence or other extraneous reasons prevented candidates from filing nominations, the poll body could extend the time for filing nominations. The court also ordered the State's Director General of Police to provide security and maintain CCTV footage and file a compliance report in the court on the next date of hearing, October 27.

The YSRCP, represented by senior advocate Maninder Singh and advocate Mahfooz A. Nazki, said its numerous candidates were prevented from filing nominations. They were subjected to assault and obstruction in the face of police inaction, the party said. It also sought a blanket extension of time for filing nominations. The court refused and said that only those places where violence marred the filing of nominations would get an extension of time.

Senior advocate K. Parameshwar, for the SEC, denied the YSRCP's allegations, and said necessary remedial measures were already in place. He said the police were directed to provide security to candidates.

Attacks are continuing despite court order: YSRCP

G.V.R. Subba Rao
VIJAYAWADA

Welcoming the Supreme Court's directions, YSRCP State coordinator Sajjala Ramakrishna Reddy, however, alleged on Wednesday that attacks on the Opposition candidates, obstruction of nominations and tearing of nomination papers were continuing despite the order.

Addressing the media at Tadepalli, he claimed that 76 incidents, including attacks, police-assisted detentions, house arrests, threats and seizure or destruction of nomination papers, were reported from 11 districts on Wednesday. He said the YSRCP would bring the latest incidents to the Supreme Court's notice.

Mr. Reddy said the SEC should act against officials allegedly favouring the TDP. He urged the State Election Commission to get reports from the District Collectors and Superintendents of Police and ensure CCTV surveillance at nomination centres.



The 'Thuli' mascot for rainwater harvesting awareness, which was unveiled by Tamil Nadu CM C. Joseph Vijay. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

New campaign to harvest rainwater launched in T.N.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay unveiled the 'Thuli' mascot, representing rainwater harvesting awareness, at an event organised by the Municipal Administration and Water Supply Department in Chennai on Wednesday.

Mr. Vijay also inspected rainwater harvesting models installed at the Tamil Nadu Water Supply and Drainage Board headquarters at Chepauk. He launched a public awareness campaign on rainwater harvesting at Marina Beach.

Teams of Chennai Metrowater officials are expected to begin auditing rainwater harvesting structures, particularly in multi-storeyed buildings, across Chennai from Thursday. Similar initiatives to survey existing structures and restore them would be carried out in all corporations and local bodies across the State.

A press release said workshops on rainwater harvesting would be organised for government officials, teachers, students, and volunteers to encourage the people to harness rainwater and recharge groundwater.

Tamil Nadu Chief Secretary M. Saikumar and Additional Chief Secretary, Municipal Administration and Water Supply, Gagandeep Singh Bedi, were present on the occasion.

Repair of structures

Meanwhile, the government has ordered all households to inspect, clean, and repair rainwater harvesting structures in view of the Northeast monsoon.

According to a G.O. issued on October 16, under the 'Implementation of Rain Water Harvesting as a Mass Movement - Renewed Initiatives' campaign, citizens, apartment complexes, commercial establishments, and institutions are required to ensure that their rooftop rainwater harvesting systems, filter chambers, recharge pits, and wells are fully functional.

Kerala HC tells SBI to refund ₹3.73 lakh to victim of cyberfraud

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Kerala High Court recently directed the State Bank of India (SBI) to refund ₹3.73 lakh to a victim of cyberfraud. The court observed that she was entitled to the refund as she reported the fraudulent transaction to the bank and the police within the prescribed time.

Justice Harisankar V. Menon noted that the bank did not take any steps to recredit the amount siphoned from her account, even though she registered a complaint immediately after the incident. Even after the police identified the fraudster, the bank did not take any further action, the court observed.

The petitioner said on July 13, 2019, she received a text message stating that her debit card was proposed to be blocked and that she could reactivate it online. She had earlier been notified that non-chip based debit cards were to be blocked by SBI. Later, she received a call from the same phone number informing her that the debit card was blocked. She was then directed to provide OTP for registration of the "State Bank Secure App".

Right after the OTP was shared, ₹3.73 lakh was debited from her account. She immediately called the SBI's customer care service, and blocked her bank account.

The banking ombudsman argued that the petitioner was privy to the entire transaction and hence was not entitled to the refund.

Suspected IED blast injures 2 in Bengaluru

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

NIA and Internal Security Division have been kept in the loop, says Police Commissioner

Two persons were injured in a blast suspected to have been triggered by an improvised explosive device (IED) at an under-construction building in Pulakeshinagar in East Bengaluru on Tuesday.

Allauddin, who was working in the building, is said to have lost a finger in the explosion. He hails from Assam.

Suraj, a security guard, from Uttar Pradesh, escaped with minor injuries. He is being questioned by the police.

Wires found

Bengaluru City Police Commissioner Seemant Kumar Singh quoted the injured persons as saying that the explosion was triggered after one of them pressed the button of a torch.

Another senior officer familiar with the development told *The Hindu* that small wires had also been recovered from the scene and sent for forensic examination.

"By the look of it, it has all the characteristics of an IED assembly, but it can be confirmed only after the report from the FSL (Forensic Science Laboratory) is out," he said.

Mr. Singh said the Internal Security Division (ISD) and the National Investigation Agency (NIA) had been kept in the loop.

Show-stopper



Curtain comes down: Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar, along with his Keralam and Telangana counterparts V.D. Satheesan and Revanth Reddy, showers petals on the idol of Chamundeshwari in the golden howdah during the Jamboo Savari procession in Mysuru on Wednesday. The procession led by tusker Prashanth marked the culmination of the 10-day Dasara celebrations. M.A SRIRAM

Howdah elephant runs amok in Shivamogga

The Hindu Bureau
SHIVAMOGGA

The Jamboo Savari procession at Shivamogga in Karnataka on Wednesday witnessed tense moments after two elephants – one of them carrying the howdah with the idol of Goddess Chamundeshwari – ran helter-skelter.

Caretakers and Shivamogga City Corporation staff ran behind the animals to stop them. Somanna, the elephant carrying the howdah, ran towards a corner, and hit a couple of cars and two-wheelers. The caretakers eventually brought the animals under control. Superintendent of Police B. Nikhil told reporters that there were no casualties. A couple of vehicles were damaged.

Keralam's first-ever vistadome coach to hit Kollam-Sengottai route today

The Hindu Bureau
KOLLAM



Up close: The vistadome coach has rotatable seats designed to offer a panoramic view of the Western Ghats. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Passengers on the Kollam-Sengottai route are in for a sensory feast as Keralam's first-ever vistadome coach hits the track on October 22.

Attached to the Madurai-Guruvayur Express, the addition of this executive vistadome AC coach adds a distinct attraction for travellers, featuring expansive glass windows and rotatable seats designed to offer panoramic views of the Western Ghats along the picturesque Sengottai-Punalur ghat section.

Passengers will be able to experience the winding tracks, lush green landscapes, and mountain scenery of the Sengottai gap connecting Kerala and Tamil Nadu. Combining the convenience of rail transport with the region's natural splendour, the service is expected to appeal strongly to tourists, families, and nature enthusiasts.

The basic fare for the vistadome coach is set at ₹515, with complete end-to-end route costing ₹1,875.

According to the schedule, Train No. 16327 (Madurai-Guruvayur Express) with the vistadome coach will depart Madurai Junction at 11.35 a.m. on October 22. The train will reach the border station of Sengottai at 2.30 p.m.

N.K. Premachandran, MP, said the train will stop at maximum number of stations to allow passengers to fully appreciate the region's scenic beauty.

Karnataka SIR: many remain clueless on getting back on rolls

Rishita Khanna
BENGALURU

"We only recently found out that we had to apply for inclusion in the electoral rolls because everyone's name had been deleted. Our booth-level officers (BLOs) told us there was no last date, so we have not filled out Form 6 yet. But many people in the neighbourhood later checked with officials and learnt that there would be another list, the final roll, and that our names could have been included had we filled out Form 6 earlier," said Sonu, a carpenter who lives in New Timber Yard Layout in Bengaluru.

Mr. Sonu was among the 776 electors deleted from polling station Part No. 242 amid the Special Intensive Revision exercise (SIR) in Karnataka. According to the Summary Revision 2025 data, the station had 1,419 electors. Of these, 776 were marked for deletion.

Most residents in the locality work as labourers, carpenters or daily-wage workers. They said the nature of their work meant that many people were away from home from morning until late afternoon or evening.

Several other polling stations have lost more than half their electors to the Absent, Shifted, Dead, Duplicate, and Others (ASDDO) list. At Shanti Children School (Room No. 1), for instance, the Summary Revision 2025 data recorded 1,134 electors. Of these, 1,053 were marked under the ASDDO category.

Many were unaware that their names had been deleted or that they could apply using Form 6 for inclusion in the rolls. Some residents knew that the SIR exercise was under way but said BLOs had told them that their enumeration forms would be issued on another date.

Delhi Police finish audit of education institutes and parks

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI



Students take out a march against the Delhi gang rape.

The Delhi police on Wednesday concluded their survey of 1,600 parks in the Capital. The report will soon be submitted to Lieutenant-Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and civic agencies, said an officer.

At several open, green spaces, boundary walls were found to be broken, CCTV cameras dysfunctional, lighting inadequate and security personnel lacking. The police have suggested forming local units to inspect parks regularly.

The survey followed a Supreme Court directive on September 28. The court took *suo motu* cognisance of a spate of sexual assault incidents against minors and women in Delhi-National Capital Region, and directed Delhi Police to identify vulnerable areas, step up patrolling, and undertake an audit of lighting and CCTV coverage in public spaces within four weeks.

The report also contains details of a security audit of nearly 3,000 educational institutions, and recommended that pink booths be set up near those.

Special Commissioner of Police Devesh Chandra Srivastava said at some locations, footage was not being stored for the mandatory period while cameras were incorrectly positioned and failed to cover parts of the parks, leaving blind spots. The police have recommended setting up police booths in larger parks, deploying PCR vans, pruning trees to improve visibility, and strengthening CCTV surveillance.

Reimpose President's Rule in Manipur, say Kuki-Zo groups

Council says no members were killed during President's Rule from February 2025 to February 2026; women's forum says 32 killed in violence since March and 55 houses were burnt down

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



Regional autonomy: The Kuki-Zo Council reiterated its demand for a separate administration for the community. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Kuki-Zo groups on Wednesday demanded the reimposition of President's Rule in Manipur, claiming that at least 32 people from the community have been killed since March 2026.

President's Rule was revoked in Manipur on February 4 after being imposed a year earlier, on February 13, 2025.

The Kuki-Zo Women's Forum, Delhi said that at least 32 Kuki-Zo people, including two pregnant women and 10 other women, had been killed since March 2026 in violence it attributed to members of the Isak-Muivah faction of the Nationalist Socialist Council of Nagaland (NSCN-IM) and the Zeliangrong United Front (ZUF-Kamson). The Forum also claimed that around 55 houses in 14 Kuki-Zo villages had been burnt during the period.

At a press conference in Delhi, Kuki-Zo Council spokesperson Ginza Vualzong claimed that no Kuki-Zo civilian had been killed during President's Rule. The Council sought the reimposition of Central rule "in the interest of the safety, security, and dignity of the Kuki-Zo people".

The organisation also reiterated its demand for a separate administration for the Kuki-Zo community in the form of a Union Territory with a legislature, arguing that the prolonged ethnic conflict in the State had eroded the community's confidence in the existing administrative arrangement.

Economic hardships

Mr. Vualzong added that prices of essential commodities in the Kuki-Zo-inhabited areas of Kangpokpi, Ukhrul and Kamjong districts and the Longpi area of Noney/Tamenglong had gone beyond the reach of ordinary people.

He claimed that residents of Chassad and Aishi villages in Kamjong had faced an economic embargo, while supplies to villages in the Kotlen and Leilon areas of Kangpokpi had been obstructed. He further accused the United Naga Council (UNC) of blocking commodities bound for Kangpokpi town at Namdilong and Senapati.

As a consequence, petrol prices had risen to ₹250 a litre and LPG cylinders to ₹5,000 in affected area, he said.

'Political problem'

"Manipur is not a security problem, it is a political problem and requires the solution accordingly," he said, insisting that the continuing violence involving both the Meitei-Kuki-Zo conflict and more recent clashes involving Naga and Kuki-Zo groups demonstrated the need for a political settlement.

The violence between the Kuki-Zo and Meitei people which started on May 3, 2023 has claimed lives of more than 350 people.

Cong. accuses BJP of failing to restore peace in Manipur

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Mallikarjun Kharge asks how many more innocent lives must be lost before the government acts

The Congress on Wednesday accused the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) of failing to restore peace in Manipur, saying the continuing violence in the strategically important border State exposed the government's inability to ensure law and order, protect constitutional rights, and safeguard national security.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge posed three questions to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah, asking how many more innocent lives must be lost before the government acts. He also questioned the efficacy of the measures taken by the Centre to end the ethnic conflict that erupted in May 2023.

"Manipur is bleeding again because of BJP's incompetence! The horrific killing of four innocent civilians in the latest spate of violence is deeply condemnable. My heartfelt condolences to the bereaved families," Mr. Kharge said in a post on X.

Since May 2023, more than 300 people have lost their lives, while 24,530 people continue to live in relief camps under "pathetic conditions" and women, children and vulnerable families continue to bear the brunt of the prolonged crisis, he added.

"The BJP's political machinations, from imposing President's Rule to replacing the Chief Minister and reinstalling its own government, have yielded no peace. PM Modi, who did not even set foot in Manipur for nearly 29 months after violence erupted, has abysmally failed on his so-called assurance in Parliament," Mr. Kharge said.

He asked what had happened to the Peace Committee constituted by Mr. Shah in June 2023.

India and U.S. 'pretty close' to trade deal, says Trump

Press Trust of India
WASHINGTON

The U.S. and India are "pretty close" to making a trade deal, which will be much different than the earlier pacts, U.S. President Donald Trump said in Washington.

Speaking to reporters at the Oval Office on Tuesday, Mr. Trump said India and the U.S. were pretty close to making a trade deal. "They want to make a deal. We are going to make a deal. Pretty close, yeah," he said.

"It's going to be a much different kind of deal than we have done," he added.

Mr. Trump's remarks came at a time Secretary of State Marco Rubio is visiting India.

India and the U.S in February announced the finalisation of the framework for the first phase of the bilateral trade agreement (BTA).

Rubio meets Chandrasekaran, Adani; visits Reliance's refinery in Jamnagar

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI


Building bridges: U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio and his wife Jeanette Dousdebes at the Mumbai airport on Wednesday. AP

U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio met Adani Group chairman Gautam Adani and Tata Sons chairman N. Chandrasekaran in Mumbai on Wednesday before heading to Jamnagar in Gujarat to visit Reliance Industries' oil-refining complex.

Mr. Rubio, who arrived in Mumbai on Tuesday afternoon, first met Mr. Adani, followed by a meeting with Mr. Chandrasekaran, sources said.

Neither side released details of the meetings.

The visit comes as India and the U.S. seek to deepen commercial and strategic ties, with energy security, manufacturing and technology among the areas of potential cooperation.

Mr. Rubio's Jamnagar visit puts energy and industrial investment at the centre of his India trip, with the Reliance complex emerging as a focal point for potential cooperation between Washington and New Delhi on global oil supplies.

Crude oil processing

The refinery's ability to process a wide range of crude grades makes it strategically significant as the U.S. explores expanding markets for Venezuelan oil and India seeks to diversify its energy supplies.

Mr. Rubio, accompanied by his wife, Jeanette Dousdebes Rubio, toured the world's largest single-site oil-refining complex, the Vantara wildlife rescue and conservation centre, and Reliance's emerging clean-energy manufacturing hub, people familiar with the visit said.

He spent a few hours in Jamnagar before departing for the United States.

Almost the entire Ambani family, led by billionaire Reliance chairman Mukesh Ambani, welcomed the U.S. delegation. Those present included his wife, Nita Ambani, daughter Isha Ambani and her husband, Anand Piramal, and younger son Anant Ambani and his wife, Radhika Merchant, along with Reliance Industries Executive Director P.M.S. Prasad and U.S Ambassador to India Sergio Gor.

Mr. Gor said liquefied petroleum gas from the U.S. had risen sharply as a share of India's imports. "Over the past year, India's imports of US LPG have surged from under 10 per cent to 67 per cent, making the United States India's largest LPG supplier," he said in a post on X.

He also highlighted Reliance's planned investment in a new refinery in Texas as an opportunity to expand U.S. energy production and create jobs.

Panchayat polls to be held in Ladakh on November 21; Kargil hill council dissolved

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

The last elections for panchayats and municipalities were held in Ladakh in 2018, when it was part of J&K

The Ladakh administration on Wednesday dissolved the Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Council (LAHDC)-Kargil and announced panchayat elections on November 21 in the cold desert region.

An official said the Ladakh State Election Commission (SEC) proposed to hold the Panchayat General Elections across all panchayat *halqas* on November 21. The nominations will close on November 2, the official said. The Model Code of Conduct (MCC) has come into force with immediate effect.

The Ladakh administration has notified 100 elected constituencies for the eight districts of the region, with Leh comprising 22 seats, Kargil 21, Sankoo 13, Changthang 10, Nubra nine, Sham nine, Zanskar nine and Drass seven.

Officials said the number of elected constituencies will also "be the basis for the constitution of" the LAHDCs in eight districts of the region. Earlier, Ladakh had only two hill councils for Kargil and Leh districts. However, the administration has created six additional districts in the region.

The last elections for panchayats and municipalities were held in Ladakh in 2018, when the region was part of Jammu and Kashmir.

The administration of Ladakh also dissolved the erstwhile LAHDC-Kargil "with immediate effect following the reorganisation of districts". The elections to the council in Kargil were held in 2023 and the body would have completed five years in 2028. The elections were won by the National Conference-Congress alliance that won 24 seats, with the NC winning 12 seats and the Congress 10 seats. Two seats were won by the BJP and two by Independent candidates.

The latest developments came at a time when the Centre was holding talks with the representatives of Ladakh over the demands of Statehood and Sixth Schedule.

Ladakh Lieutenant-Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena termed the election announcement as "a historic milestone for grassroots democracy in Ladakh".

Haryana CM urges power staff to call off 3-day strike

The Hindu Bureau
GURUGRAM


Nayab Singh Saini

Haryana Chief Misnister Nayab Singh Saini on Wednesday urged electricity employees' unions to call off their three-day Statewide strike from Thursday and said the State government stands firmly with them in opposing the decision to grant a private company 25-year parallel electricity distribution licence in Gurugram and Nuh.

At a review meeting with administrative secretaries, Mr. Saini said the government would challenge the Haryana Electricity Regulatory Commission's (HERC) decision before the Appellate Tribunal for Electricity and vigorously pursue the case.

He said the government is also willing to fight the case through lawyers of the unions' choice, if they so wished, and that the doors for dialogue remain open.

The Haryana Electricity Employees' and Engineers' Joint Front had announced the strike after the HERC, in an order dated October 19, granted Eleven Power Private Limited the licence under Section 14 of the Electricity Act, 2003. Now, over 8.3 lakh power consumers in Gurugram and Nuh, including households, farms, shops, industrial units and offices, can choose between two discoms.

In a statement, the union had alleged that the decision would "undermine" the State-owned Dakshin Haryana Bijli Vitran Nigam (DHBVN) by handing over high-revenue areas to a private player. Farmers' organisations and Opposition parties had also condemned the move.

Regular monitoring

Mr. Saini directed all departments to remain proactive and ensure that the strike does not cause inconvenience to the public, particularly during the festive season. The Chief Minister directed all Deputy Commissioners to constitute committees to monitor the situation and regularly report to a high-level committee headed by the Chief Secretary.

Meanwhile, Power Minister Anil Vij said the government had not invited applications for the distribution licence to a private company. The HERC rules, however, allowed any company to apply for such a licence, he said.

Supreme Court judgment opens up debate on religion-neutrality of OBC classification

NEWS ANALYSIS

Abhinay Lakshman
NEW DELHI

The religion-neutrality of the Other Backward Classes (OBC) classification has been thrown open for debate after the Supreme Court's recent decision that an OBC Hindu person loses the entitlement to reservation once they convert to another religion.

While the Scheduled Castes (SCs) have always been identified by a religion criterion, and the Scheduled Tribes (STs) classification has never considered religion, and the OBC classification, since its implementation after the 1992 *Indra Sawhney vs. Union of India* judgment, has remained religion-neutral.

Communities are examined for 11 social, educational, and economic backwardness indicators, and then classified as such based on a threshold score. Forms for OBC certificates across States do not ask for the religion of an applicant nor does an OBC certificate declare the holder's religion.

In deciding the question of whether a Hindu OBC person is entitled to reservation after converting to another faith, the Supreme Court Bench of Justices Prashant Kumar Mishra and Shree Chandrashekhar, in its October 15 judgment, has established that the "source of social backwardness" must necessarily be considered in this inquiry.

The judgment noted that, for a Hindu OBC individual, the "legal foundation" of their entitlement to reservation is "specifically conditioned upon membership of that Hindu social order".



Discussing the "source of social backwardness", the court noted that while *Indra Sawhney vs. Union of India* prevented caste from being the sole criterion for OBC classification, what cannot be disregarded is that in Hindu society, the "foundational institution" of caste has historically determined social and other manifestations of backwardness.

While the court admitted that educational, economic, and other forms of backwardness may continue for an OBC person who has left the Hindu faith, their very act of choosing another faith puts them in a different "social order".

This reading of the Bench of Justices Mishra and Chandrashekhar flows from how it has understood the idea of social stratification across faiths in India, essentially noting that the source of social backwardness varies based on the nature of social stratification in any given social order. This understanding of social stratification makes a subtle departure from how the same concept was discussed in the Indra Sawhney judgment, without entering the question of the source of social backwardness, regardless of whether the communities are classes or castes, Hindu or Muslim.

Ever since *Indra Sawhney vs. Union of India* cleared the way for identifying OBC groups, the social backwardness of communities requesting OBC status has been determined with four criteria, none of which required an examination of the "source of social backwardness". Apart from markers for levels of child marriage, degree of dependence on manual labour, and female participation in the workforce, the criteria say that the applicant community (class or caste) must be "considered socially backward by others".

While the approach of the court in the Indra Sawhney case was that caste had permeated all faiths in India and the difference was just a matter of degrees of operation, the 2026 judgement makes a point of distinguishing social stratification through caste in Hindu society and "caste-like" social stratifications in non-Hindu social orders.

Saurav Das, Ashutosh Ranka get bail after seven days in jail

CJP leaders released after giving undertaking that they would not call for protests at Jantar Mantar as long as it remains a denotified site; police transfer cases against them to Crime Branch, citing sensitive nature and need for an impartial probe

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) activists Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka, who were in jail for the past seven days, were released on Wednesday after a special executive magistrate (SEM) court in Delhi accepted their sureties and granted them bail.

Assistant Commissioner of Police Ritu Raj, presiding over the proceedings as the SEM, issued orders for their release despite the Delhi Police seeking a three-day extension of their judicial custody, citing law and order concerns, even as counsel for the CJP activists challenged the legality of their continued detention.

The two were released after submitting an undertaking before the SEM court that they would not call for any protest at Jantar Mantar as long as it remains a denotified protest site.

They assured the court that they would not engage in any activity that would breach peace and expressed "full faith in the judiciary and all its instruments, including the learned SEM".

The next hearing in the matter is on October 23.

The police objected to the conduct of the other members of the CJP during the hearing. "....the conduct of the other members of the Respondents as a consequential effect of the statement given by them while en-route to Tihar Jail, on the last date of hearing, wherein she has given a media byte undermining the Majesty of the SEM Courts," the police said.


CJP leaders Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka hold the National Flag after being released on Wednesday. PTI

In response, counsel for Mr. Das and Mr. Ranka made a verbal unconditional apology to the court and assured it that such conduct shall not be repeated in future.

Jantar Mantar entry

The Delhi Police detained the two activists on October 13 for entering the barricaded protest area at Jantar Mantar by climbing over its gates. They were remanded in judicial custody for five days on October 14, which was extended by two days on October 19.

While extending their judicial custody on Monday, the SEM court expressed concerns that their actions could disturb public peace and questioned their regard for the law. It rejected their initial sureties, deeming them unsuitable.

Plea withdrawn

Mr. Das and Mr. Ranka approached the Delhi High Court on Tuesday seeking an urgent hearing, which was denied.

The matter was heard by the Bench of Justice Subramonium Prasad on Wednesday, where the petitioners were questioned for allegedly breaking a barricade to enter Jantar Mantar.

"The challenge to the denotification (of Jantar Mantar) is pending in the Supreme Court. Now, when you go there and you break a barricade... the chances of 10 or 20 more people in violation of Section 163 BNSS, is very bright. Again, I'm not saying good, bad, indifferent," the judge remarked while observing that authorities could demand stricter proof from individuals accused of breaching peace after violating a bond.

The judge said police permission for protests serves not only to regulate gatherings but also to prevent unwanted individuals from joining and damaging their reputation. He cited examples of student protests abroad that escalated into arson and looting.

During the hearing, the court also asked the petitioners' counsel about their ages. After being told that they were 27 and 31, the judge questioned whether they could be classified as 'Gen Z'.

"Because in the first protest in July-August, students were there. But now, its another cause. People remain the same, cause is changing. Next question will be who are you, what are you? What is your association? What is the purport of your association," the court remarked.

The judge explained that, "When there is a question of breach of peace, all these questions will assume importance. As to what is your motive."

The plea was later withdrawn after the court advised them to await the SEM's decision and approach the appropriate appellate or revisional forum if necessary.

Meanwhile, the Delhi Police on Tuesday transferred two cases against Mr. Das and Mr. Ranka to the Crime Branch, citing their sensitive nature and the need for an impartial investigation.

(With inputs from Rocky Singh and Lavpreet Kaur)

Trade ties, Russia-Ukraine war in focus as Modi set to meet Polish PM today

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI


Vital visit: Prime Minister Narendra Modi with his Polish counterpart Donald Tusk in Poland. FILE PHOTO

Building trade and defence ties as well as discussing the war in Ukraine will be at the top of the agenda as Poland Prime Minister Donald Tusk meets Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday.

Mr. Tusk visited India in 2010, during his previous tenure as Poland PM, and in 2017 when he was President of the European Council. Among other outcomes, Delhi and Warsaw are focusing efforts to double bilateral trade, which is at about $6 billion at present, with the India-European Union Free Trade Agreement due to be signed in December expected to give it a fillip.

Mr. Tusk will also travel to Bengaluru on Friday.

The visit will provide the opportunity to further strengthen the India-Poland Strategic Partnership and advance cooperation in areas of mutual interest, including trade and investment, defence, emerging technologies, renewable energy, education, culture and people-to-people ties," the External Affairs Ministry said.

"It would also serve to deepen the India-EU strategic partnership," it added, signalling the India-EU Summit scheduled for signing of the FTA on December 16, when Mr. Modi is expected to travel to Brussels. Mr. Tusk is accompanied by Mr. Andrzej Domanski, Minister of Finance and Economy, and a large business delegation, the Ministry said.

Confidentiality pact

While defence cooperation will be a priority, Poland is also keen to insulate ties from Russia by signing a "confidentiality agreement on classified information", sources said.

A joint working group on defence met in September in Warsaw to finalise agreements that would be discussed. Among them is an agreement to take into account sensitivities of Polish defence companies worried about "technology leakages to Russia", and to ensure scrutiny of dual use items, they added.

In addition, Mr. Modi and Mr. Tusk will discuss the war in Ukraine, including recent initiatives by New Delhi to mediate between Kyiv and Moscow by conveying messages over issues such as the Black Sea grain export and safety of mariners who have faced attacks in the war.

During his visit to Warsaw in September, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar had listed a number of other agreements the two sides were working on in the fields of cybersecurity, space cooperation and information technology.

Officials said the business delegation, which will take part in India-Poland business forums in Delhi and Bengaluru with top Indian CEOs, includes representatives of about 100 companies keen to broaden business with India.

Among them will be a number of defence firms and renewable energy technology firms seeking to invest in projects for recycling lithium-ion electric batteries, as well as those related to green hydrogen and ammonia, to boost green transformation.

4,263 SIR 'objections' missing from Delhi CEO's website

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI

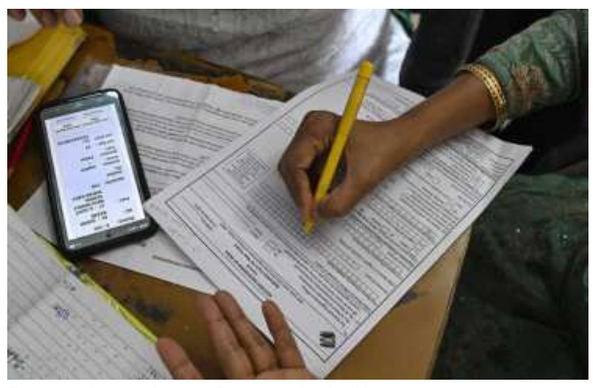
At least 4,263, or nearly a third of the objections, seeking the deletion of names from Delhi's electoral roll via Form 7, are missing from the mandatory disclosures made during the first 45 days of the ongoing claims and objections phase of the special intensive revision (SIR), *The Hindu* has found.

According to the Election Commission of India's (ECI) Manual on Electoral Roll 2023, an objection through Form 7 cannot be acted upon without its publication in the public domain. The manual specifies that electoral registration officers (ERO) can take action on any objection only after it had been published in Form 10 listings on its website for a period of seven days.

From August 31 to October 16, Delhi's Chief Electoral Officer reported receiving 13,462 Form 7 applications, but only 9,199 of these have been disclosed in the public domain, *The Hindu* found. For the remaining 31.67% applications, several details are not known, including who filed the objection, against whom, and why reasons are unknown as as they have not yet been uploaded.

The ECI mandates that list of all claims and objections received during revision period be uploaded on a daily basis on the public website of the State Chief Electoral Officer.

For objections, Form 10 is a consolidated, constituency-wise list of Form 7s carrying details, including the name of the objector against whom the objection has been raised, and the reason for the objection. It stays on the Chief Electoral Officer's portal for a period of seven days. The same list is also to be shared with political parties on a weekly basis, and displayed on notice boards, and only then can any action can be initiated by the ERO. A personal notice also has to be served to the person whose name is proposed to be deleted in cases other than death, with 15 days provided for a response.


Between August 31 and October 16, 13,462 objections were received but only 9,199 were disclosed in the Form 10 list. FILE PHOTO

"Essentially, if any objection has not been publicly listed, then it is invalid and cannot be acted upon. Processing such an application will be a violation of rules," a senior election official said.

While the claims and objections period draws to a close on October 30, Delhi's Chief Electoral Officer shares district-wise data of all objections received per day, including online and offline forms. "The daily number of applications is compiled based on the number of forms that have been digitised by the EROs, and is picked from their dashboard," an official said. Apart from public scrutiny, these lists show in which cases the notices had been generated from the ERO's or the Assistant Electoral Registration Officer's system.

Officials maintain that there should be no mismatch between the number of Form 7 applications reported in the daily bulletin, and those listed via Form 10. A list of questions was sent to office of Delhi Chief Electoral Officer seeking an explanation for the discrepancy However, no response had been received till the time of publication.

Mostly self-objections

In the analysed 45-day period, the highest number of objections were listed on October 15, which shows 1,402 records. The daily bulletin from the same day shows 2,046 Form 7s were received.

Around 84% of these objections were self-filed, the list showed, with the most cited reason given as "permanently shifted" or "absent/permanently shifted".

Okhla received the highest objections between August 31 and October 16, with 531 listed Form 7s, followed by Timarpur (335), Najafgarh (323), and Vikaspuri (289). The 214 objections received in Timarpur were listed on October 15 itself.


BJP chief Nitin Nabin, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and others at an event on the 75th Anniversary of Bharatiya Jana Sangh. ANI

Learn from struggles of your predecessors, Nabin tells BJP cadre

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Bharatiya Janata Party president Nitin Nabin on Wednesday urged the younger generation of party workers to draw inspiration from their predecessors and work towards fulfilling Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of "Viksit Bharat (developed India)".

At the 75th foundation day of the Bharatiya Jana Sangh, Mr. Nabin said the BJP would continue along the path established by its ideological and political predecessor.

He said the seed of the Jana Sangh, planted by leaders such as Dr. Syama Prasad Mookerjee and Pandit Deendayal Upadhyaya with the spirit of "Nation First" and "Antyodaya (welfare of the people in the bottom of the pyramid)" had today grown into the world's largest political party, BJP.

The programme was attended by BJP State president Harsh Malhotra, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Assembly Speaker Virendra Gupta and other party leaders.

Reflecting on the journey of the Jana Sangh, he spoke about the "nationalist vision" that inspired the creation of an organisation."At that time, Dr. Syama Prasad Mookerjee, despite being a Union Minister, had a broad national outlook... The government of that era appeared to be influenced by Western and Leftist ideas and did not demonstrate the required commitment towards nationalist thought and national interest," said Mr. Nabin.

'A clear message'

"It was under such circumstances that Dr. Syama Prasad Mookerjee, after consultations with his colleagues, not only resigned from the Union Cabinet but also sent a clear message to the nation that he was prepared to struggle for the fulfilment of the original objectives of India's freedom. It was with this nationalist consciousness and resolves that the Bharatiya Jana Sangh was established," he said, listing the contributions made by the organisation.

"If the BJP of the future is to be built, the present generation must work with the same spirit of dedication and struggle," he said, asking the party workers to embrace new technologies and adapt to changing times while also "learning from their history, the struggles of their predecessors, and their spirit of sacrifice".

Parakala Prabhakar to join Dipke, Prakash Raj, others at anti-SIR protest tomorrow

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

Economist Parakala Prabhakar, actor-activist Prakash Raj, and Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke will be among those leading a nationwide protest on Friday against the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar.

Mr. Prabhakar said, "*Har gali me* Jantar Mantar!"

The protest, being organised by the People Against SIR alliance, will see activists, public figures, farmers' and workers' organisations, and student and youth groups mobilise across the country.


Parakala Prabhakar

Among others who will be joining the protest include lawyer and activist Prashant Bhushan, Anjali Bharadwaj, Ganesh Devy, activist and author Tushar Gandhi, farmer leader Rakesh Tikait, AISA president Neha Bora, SFI joint secretary Aishe Ghosh, and AISF national president Viraaj Devang.

The organisers have urged citizens to participate in marches and demonstrations in their respective localities, calling for a broader, people-led movement to oppose the SIR exercise.

The October 23 mobilisation follows the formation of People Against SIR last week, after an emergency consultation in Delhi attended by representatives of more than 200 organisations.

The alliance has also appealed to parties in the INDIA bloc to join the march.

Rahul questions timing of Epstein-Puri photo release, asks who is U.S. blackmailing

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The release of a photograph of Union Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri with convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein by the U.S. Department of Justice has triggered fresh questions from the Opposition, with the timing coinciding with U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio's visit to Mumbai.

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday questioned the timing of the release, and asked whom the U.S. was trying to "blackmail". "Rubio goes to Mumbai. The US DOJ releases a picture of Epstein and Puri," Mr. Gandhi said in a post on X. "Dear BJP and RSS workers, which anti-national traitor do you think they're blackmailing?" he added.

Mahua's post

Mamata Trinamool Congress MP Mahua Moitra also targeted Mr. Puri, referring to the Minister's earlier statement that he had met Epstein three or four times as part of official delegations.

"Epstein Paaji told us he only met Epstein as part of a delegation 3-4 times. Guess the other delegates were hiding under the table in these 2 photos, Paaji," Ms. Moitra said in a post on X, sharing photographs of Mr. Puri with Epstein.

"Have some shame & stop attending Cabinet meetings now at least," she added in another post.

Congress leader Pawan Khera also questioned Mr. Puri's account of his interactions with Epstein. Citing documents available on the DoJ website, Mr. Khera claimed that 62 emails had been exchanged between the two between 2014 and 2017.

"14 meetings and extensive interactions – that we know of so far – were held, and many of those were one-on-one meetings. The recent photos have only strengthened our claims while questions persist," Mr. Khera said on X.

INBRIEF



Army top brass to release Land Warfare Doctrine

The Army Commanders' Conference, the Indian Army's apex-level biannual forum, commenced in New Delhi on Wednesday, with senior military leadership set to deliberate on the evolving security environment, operational preparedness and capability development. The conference, chaired by the Chief of the Army Staff (COAS), is being held from October 21 to 23. According to the Defence Ministry, a key highlight will be the release of the Land Warfare Doctrine by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh. The doctrine is expected to provide an overarching framework to prepare the Army for the changing character of warfare and future conflicts.

Centre inks ₹770-crore pact with BEL for low-level radars

The Defence Ministry on Wednesday signed a contract worth nearly ₹770 crore with Bharat Electronics Ltd. (BEL) for the procurement of Improved Low Level Light Weight Radar (LLLR-I), to strengthen the Army's air defence capabilities against aerial threats. According to the Ministry, the contract was signed in New Delhi on October 21 in the presence of Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh. The LLLR-I system can detect and track fighter-sized targets as well as mini- and micro-drones. It can prioritise aerial targets, enabling the Army to respond more effectively to the growing threat posed by unmanned aerial systems (UAS), the Ministry said.

Photos of protest removed from exhibition: Raihan Vadra

Controversy erupted after visual artist and photographer Raihan Vadra, son of Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, took to social media on Wednesday and said that the management of Bikaner House has removed many of his photographs documenting recent protests and movements. Titled "No Idea Is Final", the exhibition featured wildlife photography, abstract art and pictures documenting recent youth movements in India. He alleged that the authorities also directed him to remove two photos of the Tiranga. Mr. Vadra was told by the organisers, that it was not the appropriate time to display "such images".

25,000 people to attend Ekta Divas parade: Mohan

Around 25,000 people are likely to attend the Rashtriya Ekta Divas parade on October 31 at Ekta Nagar in Gujarat, Union Home Secretary Govind Mohan said on Wednesday. October 31 is celebrated to commemorate the birth anniversary of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel. The event is not an alternative to or a competition for the Republic Day parade, Mr. Mohan said. Around 2,000 artistes from 126 Naxal-affected districts across the country will participate in this year's Ekta Divas parade, cultural performances and other events. The theme of this year's cultural events at the Rashtriya Ekta Divas celebrations is *Vande Mataram*.

As Delhi's air quality turns 'poor', restrictions enforced

AQI was at 245 on Wednesday, the first time in the 'poor' category since July; CAQM tells States to impose curbs on diesel generator sets, inter-State transport as part of a graded response action plan

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



The last time the AQI was in the 'poor' category in Delhi was on July 13, when it stood at 246. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Residents of north Indian States around the national capital will not be permitted to use diesel generator sets as a regular source of power supply and only inter-State buses using clean fuel will be allowed to enter Delhi, according to a series of measures announced on Wednesday as part of an action plan to reduce pollution in the city.

With the air quality in the capital worsening to the 'poor' category, the Commission for Air Quality Management in NCR and adjoining areas (CAQM) on Wednesday announced the implementation of Stage 1 of the Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP), a set of short-term emergency measures taken to reduce air pollution. It is divided into four stages depending on the level of air pollution that exists at a particular time or is predicted for the near future.

Delhi's 24-hour overall average air quality index (AQI) was at 245 (poor) at 4 p.m. on Wednesday, up from 179 (moderate) a day earlier, as per the Central Pollution Control Board's daily official bulletin, which is considered the day's official AQI. The last time the AQI was in the 'poor' category was on July 13, when it stood at 246.

Under GRAP 1, the CAQM has directed States to ensure that diesel generator sets are not used as a regular source of power supply. "Do not permit inter-city/inter-state buses from any city/town of the states of Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan and also from the adjoining states of Punjab, Himachal Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Uttarakhand and J&K, other than EV/CNG/BS-VI Diesel, to ply in Delhi-NCR," reads one of the measures under Stage 1 of the GRAP.

Most of the other measures under Stage 1 are directing authorities to strictly implement existing norms related to air pollution.

Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa said that, with public participation and coordinated efforts by various departments, Delhi has recorded 214 clean-air days so far this year, the highest over the past decade, excluding the COVID-19 period.

Mr. Sirsa said that around 30 agencies are working under an 11-point pollution control plan in line with the guidelines of NITI Aayog and the CAQM. The government is also focussing on traffic management, dust control, monitoring industrial emissions, and increasing green cover. He said that the government is also taking steps to reduce traffic congestion. Round-the-clock monitoring is being carried out through the Integrated Command and Control Centre to strengthen pollution control and ensure effective resolution of citizens' complaints, he said.

Tree planting spree

Mr. Sirsa added that extensive efforts are being made to increase Delhi's green cover. Against the target of 70 lakh saplings, a total of 78 lakh saplings have been planted this year. The Forest Department has carried out geo-tagging of the plantations, and the survival rate of saplings has been recorded at between 96% and 97%, he added.

Every winter, air pollution spikes in Delhi-NCR and many parts of the larger Indo-Gangetic Plains, mainly due to meteorological factors such as lower wind speed and a drop in temperature, exacerbated by pollution from stubble burning and the use of firecrackers.

Festivals or elections, CAPF personnel are always vigilant: Shah

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI



Amit Shah

Personnel of the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) remain vigilant and strengthen the nation's internal security on every occasion, whether elections, festivals, protests, or border security duties, Union Home Minister Amit Shah said on Wednesday.

India succeeded in eliminating electoral violence in Uttar Pradesh and Bihar, but electoral violence continued in West Bengal for a long time, Mr. Shah said. During the recent West Bengal Assembly election, security personnel achieved significant success by ensuring that polling was completed without a single fatality, he said. "In doing so, the CAPFs established a new benchmark and the entire country now recognises that electoral violence has been brought to an end in the country," the Minister said.

The Home Minister paid tribute to police personnel who had laid down their lives in the line of duty, at the National Police Memorial in New Delhi on the occasion of Police Commemoration Day.

The ceremony was attended by Union Home Secretary Govind Mohan; the Director of the Intelligence Bureau Mahesh Dixit; the Director General (D-G) of the Indo-Tibetan Border Police Shatrujeet Kapoor; the D-G of the Border Security Force (BSF) Praveen Kumar; and the D-Gs of the other CAPFs.

"For the Indian police, 2026 is an extremely significant year," Mr. Shah said, adding, "On March 31, 2026 the country achieved freedom from Naxalism, which had plagued India for decades. From 1981 to March 2026, the country endured numerous hardships due to Naxalism. During this period, many brave security personnel and innocent civilians lost their lives. More than 36,000 security personnel were martyred, and nearly 13,700 innocent civilians also lost their lives."

Attacks on Left book stalls continue across West Bengal

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA



West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari continued his criticism of the Left parties and their book stalls.

Attacks on Left parties' book stalls continued across West Bengal, with stalls in Ashoknagar and Siliguri targeted over a 24-hour period.

Even as several BJP leaders and Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) functionaries condemned the incidents, Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari continued his criticism of the Left parties and their book stalls.

The stall in Siliguri came under attack as right-wing groups objected to the contents of some books, leading to verbal altercations with the workers.

The CPI(M) alleged on Wednesday that one of their stalls in Uttar Dinajpur district's Islampur had come under attack on Tuesday night, leaving several workers injured in a scuffle.

State Finance Minister Swapan Dasgupta said that Hindu pluralism and Bengalis' love for books do not allow him to support the vandalism of Left parties' book stalls.

"It is precisely because we have imbibed the traditional Bengali reverence for books that we are appalled. That is why the BJP defended the likes of Salman Rushdie (he got his visa back during the Vajpayee government) & Taslima. This tradition of Hindu pluralism has guided us and not those who feign a liberal inheritance," Mr. Dasgupta wrote on X on Wednesday.

However, Mr. Adhikari struck a different note, continuing his criticism of the Left parties and their book stalls. "We are all book lovers, but you do not follow any Sanatani Hindu rituals and oppose the traditions, yet want to set up book stalls in front of Durga Puja pandals," he said, adding that the Left parties should sell their books from inside their party offices.

In recent days, multiple BJP and RSS leaders and other right-wing figures have condemned the attacks. Jishnu Basu, a prominent RSS leader in West Bengal, said that there was no pride in destroying books or vandalising book stalls.

'Misleading' claims: Nestle India, Zydus Wellness get FSSAI notice

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The companies have been asked to provide scientific proof to support their advertisements

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has issued notices to Nestle India and Zydus Wellness over "misleading claims" in certain products and has asked the companies to provide scientific proof to support their advertisements.

In a social media post, the FSSAI said notices were sent to Nestle India for misleading claims and non-compliant promotions involving two food products 'Lactogen Pro 1 Powder' and 'Nan Excella Pro Stage 1'.

The regulator also issued notice to Zydus Wellness Product Ltd. citing misleading claims and advertisement on its food product Complan.

In the notice issued for Lactogen Pro 1 powder, the FSSAI said the company has claimed, in its labelling and advertisement material, that the product "contains whey protein, which is a part of milk protein that is easy to digest".

On whey protein

The food safety regulator has asked Nestle to furnish scientific substantiation for the claim regarding whey protein being easy to digest.

In the product Nan Excella Pro Stage 1, the FSSAI said that the claim "5 HMOs [human milk oligosaccharides] helps support normal immune system" was considered to imply that the product was suitable for supporting the immune system.

"The claim was considered non-compliant with provisions prohibiting claims relating to the prevention, alleviation, treatment or cure of any disease, disorder or particular physiological condition, unless specifically permitted under applicable regulations," the regulator said.

In the case of Complan, the FSSAI said the product label displays images of two children and claims include "2X Faster Growth", "Supports Concentration and Memory" and "Pro Immunity+ 34 Vital Nutrients".

The claims were found to be in violation of the FSS (Advertising and Claims) Regulations, 2018. The regulator has asked Zydus to provide scientific justification for such claims.

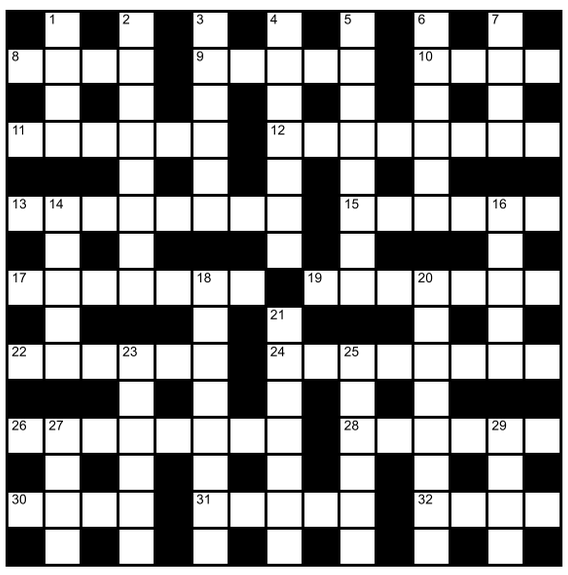
The advertisement claim "Growth Comes in 4 Flavours" was found to violate regulations of the FSS (Advertising and Claims) Regulations, 2018.

TH CROSSWORD + 14929

(set by Incognito)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

8 Capital from Mali distributed (4)
9 Equipment for diving from South America when carrying a little one (5)
10 Voltaire giving up vote in den (4)
11 Small enchantress produces stick (6)
12 Water, air and tiger moved (8)
13 Tear up Korea vet's pass (8)
15 Carry manuscript and tribal symbols (6)
17 American statesman from South Africa rejected during Lanka tour (7)
19 Sees about guards not having uniform (7)
22 A model sailing manoeuvre for assault (6)
24 A modified firearm for a part of 20 (8)
26 Groan horribly and pass away, producing cotton cloth (8)
28 First half of moon came up... It's gloomy (6)
30 Part of foot in China (4)
31 Excited about German submarine (1-4)
32 Amphibian part found in railway track (4)

Down

1 Scenery from movie wanted (4)
2 One bird between large and small lights (8)
3 Organised steam bath, after losing bad bet, for medical problem (6)
4 Planet having crater at centre (7)
5 Worriedly retreat after boy produces hair clip (8)
6 De-board! It's on fire! (6)
7 Can start to type "Colour" (4)
14 Drink in Vermont for man-servant (5)
16 Lady remaining unchanged on return (5)
18 Wrongly ousted a cocktail and invited for a date(5,3)
20 Plane fliers in court after top class retaliation at first (8)
21 Animal book in Arthur's place (7)
23 Indian from Andhra Pradesh with dull pain (6)
25 Exploding meteor is far away (6)
27 Currency mentioned in memorandum (4)
29 Awful cost for a Highlander (4)

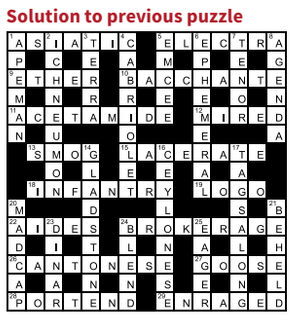
SUDOKU

2		3			7			
6		1	5				3	8
			6					
	8			7			1	2
3				8				4
1	2			5			6	
					4			
4	3				5	1		7
			7			2		3

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★☆☆

No.SS7038 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

8	2	3	1	6	9	7	4	5
1	6	4	5	8	7	3	2	9
9	5	7	4	2	3	6	1	8
7	3	2	6	9	1	8	5	4
5	1	9	7	4	8	2	6	3
4	8	6	3	5	2	1	9	7
6	7	1	9	3	5	4	8	2
2	4	5	8	7	6	9	3	1
3	9	8	2	1	4	5	7	6

FAITH

Unbreakable bond

Sudhama, affectionately known as Kuchela, shared an unbroken bond of companionship with Lord Krishna from childhood at Guru Sandipani's Gurukulam. When their studies concluded, Sudhama wept inconsolably at the prospect of parting. Krishna gently comforted him, assuring him that true spiritual friendship is never severed by physical distance, said Smt. Vishakha Hari in a discourse.

Sudhama lived a tranquil life alongside his wife Kalyani. Because of the poverty her family endured, she gently suggested that Sudhama visit his childhood companion Krishna, who had become the revered king of Dwaraka.

Accepting her counsel, Sudhama resolved to set out for Dwaraka, but felt that one should never visit a friend empty-handed. With no food grains left in their kitchen, Kalyani begged from the neighbouring doors, got a single handful of flattened rice (poha), and handed it to Sudhama to offer to Krishna. Upon arriving at Dwaraka, Sudhama was dazzled by the breathtaking grandeur of the capital. When Sudhama saw wealthy chieftains waiting with lavish tribute to offer Krishna, he felt self-conscious about his ragged appearance and considered turning back. However, the palace guard recognised his humble disposition and informed him that Lord Krishna had issued strict royal decrees granting immediate entry to the poor, devout and humble. When the attendants carried Sudhama's name into the inner sanctuary, Krishna rushed barefoot to welcome Sudhama and embraced him tightly. Lord Krishna and Sudhama's bonding makes us understand that material positions and wealth may fluctuate, but a true devotee's inner love for God remains steadfast.

The whales never stopped coming to Gujarat's beaches, the watchers did

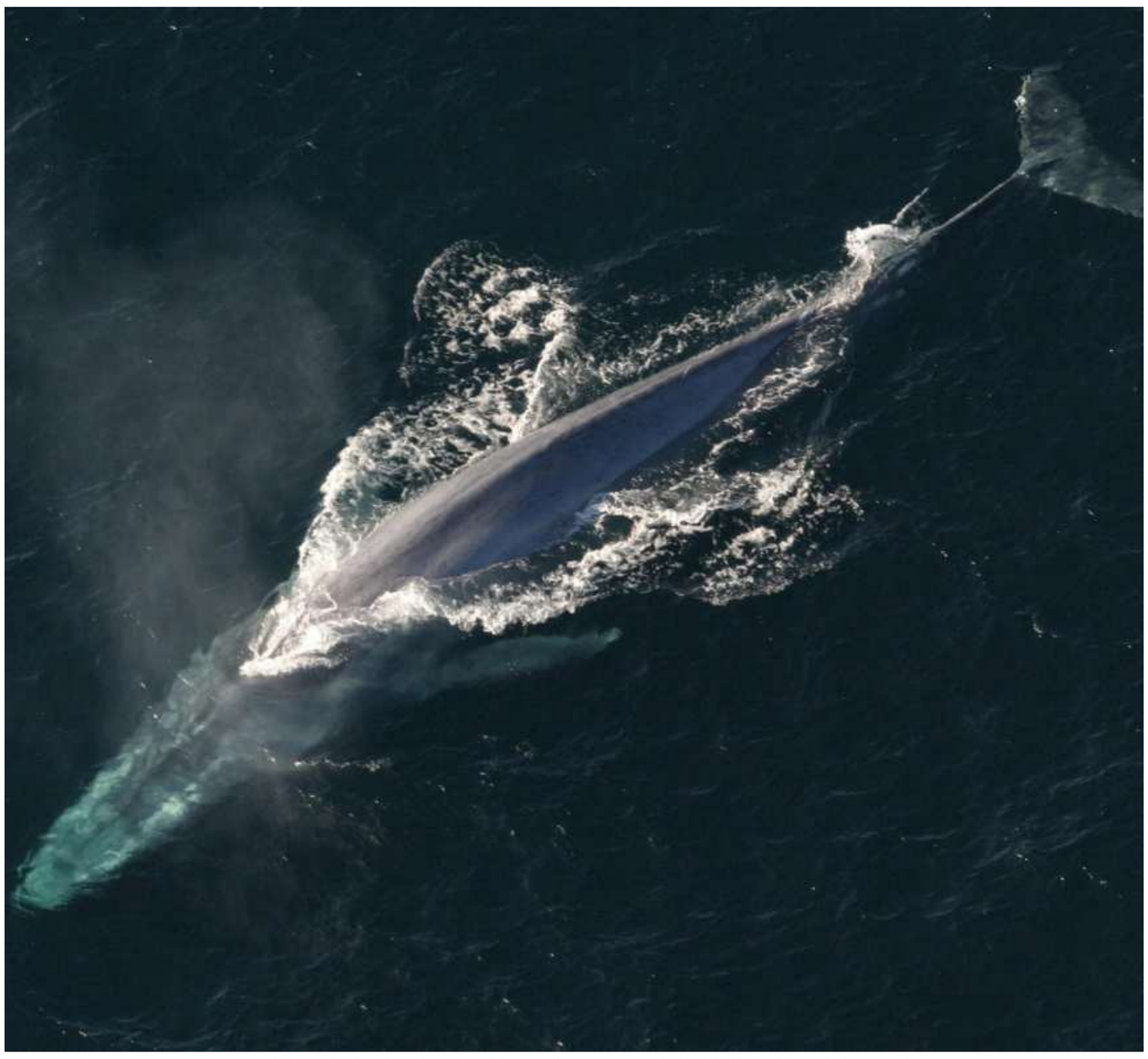
Every cetacean in India is protected under Schedule I of the Wildlife (Protection) Act 1972, which is the same level of protection accorded to tigers and lions; yet many may not recognise a Bryde's whale washed up on the beach and may never think to ask what happened to it afterwards

Seema Lokhandwala

A few weeks ago, an email arrived from the Marine Mammals Consortium, the kind of routine update I usually skim and file away. This one had a link to a global database of blue whale strandings, and, out of curiosity, I clicked it. A world map loaded, dotted with blue circles, and my eyes went straight to the western coast of India, which was covered with them.

I grew up in western India, close enough to the sea that the beach was simply part of the week. Almost every weekend we went to Dumas, and in all those years I never once heard anyone mention a whale. Whales belonged in documentaries and in other people's oceans, somewhere cold and far away.

Yet here was a map telling me that for more than a century, the largest animals ever to have lived had been washing up dead on the coast I thought I knew.



Out of sight: Gujarat was once one of the main sites in India where blue whales were recorded, with fifteen blue whale strandings on record, fourteen of them in the twentieth century and many of them in the Gulf of Khambhat and along the river mouths near Surat. But after 2000, there was just one. U.S. NOAA

Something startling

I zoomed in and a rabbit hole opened. One of the records sat near Gavier, just outside Surat, the same place where we go birding every weekend. On February 23, 1963, a blue whale roughly twenty metres long came ashore near Magdalla Port, already badly decomposed, and someone took the trouble to measure its flippers and its lower jaw and write it all down. I have stood on that shoreline with binoculars more times than I can remember, looking for waders and never imagining what had once lain there.

Then I did what I now do with most questions that will not leave me alone. I downloaded the data, uploaded it to an artificial intelligence (AI) tool, and asked it to show me the trends. The trends were interesting but the thing I could not shake was how wide the gap was between what the records showed and what people on this coast actually know. Growing up, none of us had heard that whales strand on India's coast, and most people I meet still do not know it.

The numbers were striking. Of the roughly 470 blue whale strandings recorded worldwide, India accounts for about one in seven, and three-quarters of those are along its west coast. Recorded strandings have become more frequent in recent decades. A growing share of the animals are also calves, some less than ten metres long.

Then I noticed something startling: my home State of Gujarat was once one of the main places in India where blue whales were recorded, with fifteen blue whale strandings on record, fourteen of them in the twentieth century and many of them in the Gulf of Khambhat and along the river mouths near Surat. But after 2000, there was just one.

A story in the fragments

At first, I wondered whether the whales had simply stopped coming. But when I looked at where the records came from, a different story took shape. Nine of those 15 records trace back to just two moments when someone was paying close attention: S.T. Moses, a naturalist in Baroda who compiled whale strandings in the 1940s, and a single compilation of Gujarat records published in 2001. After that, unfortunately, no one seems to have been systematically recording Gujarat's whales.

So when I started searching online, the whales began to reappear. A 2016 news report noted in passing that Gujarat had had at least two whale strandings that year, in May and July, one of them a blue whale – and that animal is nowhere in the global database.

A 2016 report by the Konkan Cetacean Research Team to the International Whaling Commission listed a Bryde's whale that had washed ashore at Dwarka beach on April 12, 2016, and an unidentified baleen whale, possibly another Bryde's, near Mandvi in the Gulf of Kachchh a month later.

A short technical note from the Central Marine Fisheries Research Institute described a dead Bryde's whale about 10.4 metres long and weighing roughly seven tonnes on the beach at Veraval in August 2017, known locally as "Machchh". It had been towed ashore under the supervision of forest officials for a post-mortem before being buried on the beach. None of these incidents became stories that the rest of the country got to hear about.

Closer to home, in August 2023, a Bryde's whale calf was stranded near Mor village in the Olpad taluka of Surat, not far from the beaches I grew up on. Young men from the village dug a large pit, filled it with seawater, and kept the calf in it while they called the forest department and a local NGO. It was released with the help of a bulldozer at high tide, but the sea pushed it back to shore, and a veterinarian declared it dead. It made a brief appearance in the news and then disappeared.

What these fragments tell me is that Gujarat's coast was never entirely quiet. Its fishers certainly know. Fishers interviewed in Mandvi and Porbandar for that same report said they see whales through the year, more often between October and April, and they call baleen whales "Maccha Raja", 'the king of all fish', whose appearance on a fishing trip is taken as a good omen. The whales are still here. What Gujarat has lost are its watchers: the people and systems that examine and document a carcass on a beach, create a record somewhere, and preserve it so that others can find and read it.

Listen to the whales

This is important work because stranding records are one of the few sources of data about where and when these whales occur along India's coast, and which offer clues to their distribution, seasonal movements, and population structure that are otherwise very hard to find. Much of what we know about cetaceans off the coasts of India comes from stranding records plus occasional coastal research. With cetacean research in India still in its infancy, data from stranded animals is rightly described as a scientific treasure.

This is also why where people are watching, the picture changes quickly. The Maharashtra coast alone recorded 109 marine mammal strandings in 2020 and 2021, and it is no coincidence that the State today accounts for a large share of India's recent blue whale records.

In 2015, it was also a team surveying Maharashtra's coast for humpback dolphins that had reported a blue whale mother and calf about 3 km off the Sindhudurg coast, the first blue whales seen off the State in nearly a century. The whales were found because someone was out there looking.

Blue whales are also only the beginning. Of the roughly 120 marine mammal species in the world, 30 to 35 whales, dolphins, and porpoises, along with the dugong, are found in the waters around the Indian subcontinent. Most of the recent Gujarat strandings I could find were Bryde's whales. Further out, surveys across India's exclusive economic zone between 2003 and 2007 found the Indo-Pacific bottlenose dolphin to be the most frequently sighted species (across instances) and spinner dolphins the most abundant (in individual instances), with sperm whales also turning up regularly.

In January 2016, more than 100 short-finned pilot whales stranded along a 15 km stretch of Manapad beach in Thoothukudi in Tamil Nadu. Local fishers spent many hours pushing surviving animals back into the sea. In 2021, a false killer whale that washed ashore in Karnataka became the first such stranding recorded in that State.

Perhaps the most remarkable of all is the humpback whale of the Arabian Sea. These whales in other parts of the world undertake the longest migration of any mammal – but those in the Arabian Sea stay put. Genetic studies have suggested that this group became separated from other humpbacks around 70,000 years ago. Researchers believe there are only around a hundred of them remaining, with their songs having been recorded off the coasts of Goa, Karnataka, and Maharashtra. I study elephants by listening to them, so it moves me to know that whales have been singing off the coast where I grew up, and hardly anyone has heard them.

Keep watch

Every cetacean in India is protected under Schedule I of the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972, which is the same level of protection accorded to tigers and lions. Yet most of us may not recognise a Bryde's whale on the beach, may not know whom to call, and may never think to ask what happened to it afterwards.

The villagers at Mor did know whom to call, and their response is exactly what we need to see along the whole coast. If you find a stranded whale or dolphin, alive or dead, call your local forest department, take photographs, and note where and when you found it, because that record may be the only trace the animal ever leaves among humans.

For anyone curious to learn more, the Marine Mammal Research and Conservation Network of India lists the species found in the country's waters, explains how to identify them, and what to do at a stranding. It also allows anyone to submit a sighting or stranding record to its online database.

The next time I am home and standing on the mudflats by the sea with my binoculars raised for waders, I will be looking a little further out than I used to. The records say whales have been passing this coast all along, through every weekend of my childhood, and the only reason most of us never knew is that so because few people were keeping an eye out. That part we can change. The whales will keep coming to our shores: let us get out there, watch, and record what we see.



Rare inhabitants: A humpback whale calf. These whales in other parts of the world undertake the longest migration of any mammal, but those in the Arabian Sea stay put. Researchers believe there are only around a hundred of them remaining in the region, with their songs having been recorded off the coasts of Goa, Karnataka, and Maharashtra. SHARP PHOTOGRAPHY (CC BY-SA)

(Seema Lokhandwala is a wildlife biologist and communication co-lead at Coexistence Consortium.
seema.lokhandwala@gmail.com)



A 2011 photo of the entrance to Denisova Cave in the Altai Mountains in southern Siberia where the small bone fragments of the previously unknown large mammal was recently found. REUTERS

Siberian cave yields remains of yak-like Ice Age mammal

Reuters

A Siberian cave already famous for yielding the first remains of an extinct human lineage called the Denisovans, has now produced evidence of a previously unknown large Ice Age mammal closely related to today's yak.

Researchers said they discovered small bone fragments of the animal in Denisova Cave in the Altai Mountains of southern Siberia in Russia, and obtained DNA that showed these remains belonged to a bovine species distinct from others already known, living and extinct.

In all, the researchers studied 20 bone fragments from this species – 14 from Denisova Cave and 6 from other sites in the broader region. The oldest specimen dated to about 2,50,000 to 2,00,000 years ago, and the youngest to about 27,000 years ago.

The bones themselves were so fragmentary that their shape alone did not reveal that they belonged to a previously unknown large mammal. But the researchers were able to generate 20 ancient genomes from the bones, and these showed that this was a unique species whose evolutionary lineage diverged from the ancestors of the modern-day yak approximately 4,00,000 years ago.

The Yak X discovery deepens the understanding of the diversity of Ice Age mammals and adds to the list of species that disappeared at around the end of that epoch

"It is unusual, especially to recognise a large mammal species from small, unidentifiable fragments," said evolutionary geneticist Love Dalén of the Centre for Palaeogenetics, a collaboration between Stockholm University and the Swedish Museum of Natural History, senior author of the research published in the journal *Current Biology*.

"I would say that this is related to the advances in the field of ancient DNA, as genetics is a powerful new layer of information applied to ancient materials," said Alexandre Gilardet, a doctoral student at the Centre for Palaeogenetics and co-lead author of the study, along with Centre for Palaeogenetics postdoctoral researcher Jonas Oppenheimer.

Genetic evidence alone is not sufficient to allow for giving a scientific name to a new species, so the researchers are calling this one "Yak X."

Mr. Dalén said Yak X lived alongside other bovines including steppe bison and the aurochs, the extinct wild ancestor of today's domesticated cattle. It also shared the Ice Age landscape with woolly mammoths, woolly rhinoceroses, horses, and large predators such as cave hyenas and brown bears. The Yak X lineage diverged from the ancestors of modern yaks around the same time as the evolutionary split that occurred between the ursine lineages that led to today's brown bears and polar bears.

"I would expect it to have looked more like a yak than a bison, given its close relationship to modern yaks," he said.

Yaks are sturdily built animals with horns, long fur and a hump at the shoulders, looking a bit like a hairy ox. The largest males can weigh as much as a ton. Wild yaks are restricted to higher elevations of the Tibetan Plateau.

The Yak X discovery deepens the understanding of the diversity of large Ice Age mammals and adds another species to the long list that disappeared at around the end of that epoch.

For feedback and suggestions
for 'Science', please write to **science@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Daily page'

Peace for progress

Economic objectives can be met only in a stable security environment

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh's address at the SCO Council of Heads of Government meeting in Tajikistan, on Tuesday marks another significant occasion since Operation Sindoor (2025) when India has used the multilateral forum to raise the issue of terrorism, including cross-border terrorism from Pakistan. He said that regional cooperation cannot be meaningful if countries approached terrorism selectively. Pakistan's Deputy Prime Minister Ishaq Dar's presence added significance to the remarks, underscoring New Delhi's diplomatic challenge within an organisation whose members have divergent strategic interests and security priorities. India has consistently argued that terrorism cannot be divorced from the broader agenda of regional peace, economic integration and development. By calling on SCO member-states to dismantle the ecosystem of terrorism, he reiterated that the threat must be addressed at its source rather than treated as an isolated security challenge. The intervention follows India's refusal to endorse the joint statement at the 2025 SCO Defence Ministers' meet in Qingdao, China. New Delhi had objected to a draft that failed to reflect its concerns over cross-border and Pakistan-sponsored terrorism, including the Pahalgam attack (2025), while referring to militant activities in Balochistan. India maintained that such an approach would undermine the organisation's credibility by overlooking the threat it had brought before its members.

The SCO has the potential to advance regional stability, trade and connectivity instead of becoming another source of strategic friction. Yet, its effectiveness will remain limited if political disagreements prevent members from developing a common approach to security threats. India's position is not that cooperation on trade, culture, connectivity and development must be suspended until every security dispute is resolved. Rather, these objectives cannot be met independently of a stable security environment. Economic corridors require predictable borders, investors need confidence in the rule of law, and transport networks must be violence- and disruption-free. Connectivity projects such as the International North-South Transport Corridor and the development of Chabahar Port offer Central Asia connectivity with wider markets. Their long-term value, however, depends on respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, alongside conditions that allow goods, capital and people to move freely. The SCO's challenge is to translate its stated commitment to combating terrorism into practical cooperation through intelligence-sharing, action against terror financing, disruption of recruitment networks and the denial of safe havens to terrorist groups. While retaining its principle against terrorism, India should lead efforts to achieve more regional cooperation in tackling it.

Bitter and sweet

The FSSAI must expand restrictions to cover all added sugars in infant foods

The Food Safety and Standards Regulations 2020 currently allow manufacturers to add sucrose and fructose, provided their combined total does not exceed 20% of the carbohydrates in a product intended for infants aged 0-6 months. In a draft proposal, the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has pitched to eliminate this allowance – in line with WHO's recommendation to have infants breastfeed exclusively for the first six months, followed by nutritionally adequate complementary foods avoiding added sugars until 24 months. While corporations have defended sugary formulations as abiding by the Codex Alimentarius, public health experts have repeatedly described their decision to sell infant foods with added sugar as nutritional dumping. Adding sugar has often been a commercial strategy, as it serves as a cheap bulking agent, improves palatability and encourages repeat purchases. WHO's nutrient and promotion profile model for baby foods in 2022 also identified sweet purées and products in which fruits released sugars during processing as concerns. While the FSSAI's draft proposal is a step in the right direction, stopping here would allow manufacturers to replace sucrose with another sweetening ingredient. It should assess the ingredients that manufacturers add and the nutritional profile of the finished food, thus completing the loop, with the Infant Milk Substitutes, Feeding Bottles, and Infant Foods Act 1992 rightly restricting aggressively the marketing of infant foods for children up to two years old.

Research has found that children who regularly received sweetened water during infancy subsequently preferred sweeter liquids, while exposure to different infant formula flavours influenced their dietary preferences years later, including for foods tasting neutral or bitter. Across both personal and public health dimensions, then, infants need to encounter diverse flavours. Since the 2024 dietary guidelines of the ICMR-National Institute of Nutrition say that children under two should avoid added sugars, the FSSAI's draft proposal limiting itself to six months seems like a concession to manufacturers. This should be avoided since India's regulatory response to ultra-processed foods is expanding after years of sluggishness. India is currently mulling restrictions on added sugar in foods for the youngest infants, on unhealthy foods around schools, and on front-of-pack labelling for packaged foods. If the FSSAI does not expand its proposed restriction to cover all added sugars and extend it across the first 24 months, and pair it with mandatory, interpretative front-of-pack labelling for all foods, its regulatory progress will remain incomplete.

The Kingdom of Saudi Arabia in dire straits



Mahesh Sachdev

A retired Indian Ambassador specialising in the Arab world and oil issues

As if the simmering trouble in the Strait of Hormuz were not bad enough, Saudi Arabia has lately been embroiled in an intensifying conflict at the Bab al-Mandeb Strait as well. West Asia's largest economy and the world's eighth-largest defence spender is no pushover. Yet, the simultaneous constrictions at its two vital chokepoints pose an unprecedented challenge to the Kingdom, already grappling with an economic downturn at home and shifting alliances abroad. The evolving situation may be the toughest test yet for Mohammed bin Salman (MbS), Saudi Crown Prince and Prime Minister, although existential alarms seem overblown. The high-stakes crisis could have profound domestic, regional and global consequences for geopolitics, energy and global trade. A granular analysis of its causes and ramifications is called for.

An old conflict, slanted reportage

Despite media saturation with related developments, the coverage is often myopic and slanted, perpetuating several myths that need either debunking or proper nuancing.

Historically, the Saudi-Al-Houthi conflict is nearly a century old. Saudi King Ibn Saud's forces defeated Yemeni Imam Yahya's tribal fighters in 1934, compelling the latter to cede three provinces in the Asir region under the Treaty of Taif. Although a bilateral border was demarcated in 2000, many Yemeni nationalists still question its finality.

Second, until 1990, Yemenis did not need visas to travel to and work in Saudi Arabia, leading millions to migrate to the booming oil economy. A significant number of Saudi nationals, particularly in the Hijaz and Asir regions, still have Yemeni ancestry, the most egregious example being al-Qaeda founder Osama bin Laden.

Third, sectarian differences sharpen the divisions: while Saudis are predominantly Wahhabi Sunnis, al-Houthis are mostly Zaydis, a five-worshipping Shia sect. Al-Houthis constitute around a third of Yemen's total population, with the rest being Sunnis. This sectarian divide underlies the vicious 12-year-old Yemeni civil war – Saudi Arabia supports anti-Houthi Sunni factions and accuses al-Houthis of attacking Islam's holiest cities.

Fourth, although al-Houthis have strong ties with Iran, describing the relationship as a proxy arrangement is an oversimplification, as it gives insufficient weight to their Arab identity.

Al-Houthis remained inactive during the two recent United States-Iran wars. In contrast, when Israel attacked Hamas and Hezbollah in 2023-24, al-Houthis were the only Arab side to wade into hostilities, launching missile and drone attacks against Israel and disrupting shipping through the Bab al-Mandeb Strait, despite intensive American and Israeli airstrikes. Rather than supporting al-Houthis, Iran recently offered to mediate between Riyadh and Sana'a. Similarly, al-Houthis have reportedly promised not to attack U.S. and Israeli assets unless in retaliation, causing U.S. President Donald Trump to vacillate over MbS's call for support. Arguably, the al-Houthis' successful closure of the Bab al-Mandeb Strait set a precedent for Iranian action in the Strait of Hormuz 18 months later.

Two chokepoints, one crisis — Riyadh faces growing threats to its security, oil exports and regional influence

Last but not least, the media has also been silent on al-Houthis' rationale for air and naval attacks against Saudi Arabia: retaliation for the Kingdom's decade-old air and sea blockade against them.

Similar myths are percolating about navigation through the Strait of Hormuz and need to be challenged. A 70% rise in global oil prices belies loud and repeated claims that oil and gas flows from the Gulf are near normal. Truth has been collateral damage in Trumpian hyperbole to 'talk down' U.S. pump prices ahead of crucial congressional midterm elections.

Second, Iran has been inconsistent about its self-appointed role as the 'supervisor' of Hormuz traffic. After turning a blind eye to the U.S.-protected stealthy oil shuttle for weeks, it has stepped up attacks on tankers. This has raised suspicions that Iran's Revolutionary Guards initially entered into an informal tolling arrangement with some Gulf oil exporters. However, Tehran has now decided to restrict supplies to keep oil prices high until the U.S. midterm elections.

Lastly, why has Pakistan, credited with the June 17 Islamabad Memorandum, been sidelined from a peacemaking role, even as Qatar, Iraq and even Moscow are being requisitioned? Some reports indicate that Mr. Trump has quietly demoted Islamabad as a go-between, with Iran blaming Pakistani diplomacy for being either gullible or complicit in selling him a document tilted in Iran's favour.

The Iran-Houthi pincer

Riyadh has long perceived Tehran as a geopolitical and sectarian rival and sought to resist its influence in West Asia. It remains deeply suspicious of the Iran-backed "Axis of Resistance" of non-state actors in general, and al-Houthi militias in particular. The Kingdom aims to keep Yemen as a weak but not dysfunctional state. Yemenis, on the other hand, chafe at Saudi interference and nurse their historic grievances against Riyadh.

These smouldering tensions, kept in check by a tenuous ceasefire since 2022, exploded in July 2026. In September, in a sudden escalation, the al-Houthi militia occupied coastal plains along the Red Sea, positioning themselves more strategically at the Bab al-Mandeb chokepoint, menacing nearly 12% of global maritime traffic. The Saudi-led coalition's recent counteroffensive has rekindled the fighting, with a strong Saudi bombing campaign. The al-Houthi militia retaliated by launching missiles and drones at strategic Saudi targets, including Riyadh airport and Aramco headquarters, denting Saudi Arabia's image as a safe and stable country. This is the first time in 35 years that the Kingdom's cities have come under sustained attack. Iran's blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, the al-Houthi threat to Saudi-linked maritime activity, and the disruption of the Trans-Arabian Pipeline, allegedly by Iraqi Shia militias, have created a worst-case scenario for Saudi Arabia, jeopardising its vital oil exports, particularly to Asia.

The Saudis have no good options for untangling this unprecedented Iran-Houthi pincer. Despite an $83 billion defence budget, Riyadh lacks the military heft to dislodge the al-Houthis from their mountainous perches by a ground offensive. The offensive by its local Yemeni allies has bogged down into a war of attrition. Pro-Saudi stakeholders, such as the White House and the partners to the Makkah Agreement, have responded with tokenism, seemingly daunted by Yemen's reputation as a graveyard of foreign interventions and the prospects of the Bab al-Mandeb Strait being blocked again. The only other viable strategy, therefore, is to negotiate a package of measures to de-escalate tensions, lift mutual air and maritime blockades, and negotiate a truce based on the 2022 ceasefire. From Riyadh's perspective, the risks would include a loss of prestige both domestically and regionally, the possible collapse of Yemen's fractious "internationally recognised government", and the consolidation of the Tehran-Sana'a axis.

An expeditious resolution of the Yemeni crisis is a Saudi priority, as it would help insulate the Kingdom from the fallout of the next round of U.S.-Iran conflict, which could follow the U.S. midterm elections. Iran has made no secret of its intention to retaliate for American attacks on its civilian infrastructure by hitting the Gulf Arab states acting as the U.S. accomplices. In the past, Riyadh has been privately inconsistent on this issue, advising Washington to clobber Iran until regime change at one time, and also cautioning it about the potential blowback against Saudi Arabia's vulnerabilities. Unless the current fracas with Yemen is sorted out, Saudi Arabia may have to face attacks from Iran as well as the al-Houthis.

The stakes for India

Although India has avoided any direct entanglement at the two maritime chokepoints in the Arabian Peninsula, it is not immune from the impact. Beyond the ongoing economic losses and related supply disruptions from interrupted trade, high oil, gas and fertiliser prices, India needs to look after the safety and well-being of nine million of its citizens currently resident in the Gulf. It is worth recalling that in 1990-91, the huge expense involved in repatriating 1,60,000 Indians from Kuwait precipitated the economic crisis, forcing the country to pledge its sovereign gold for the first time. While India is much stronger today, it remains sobering to note that the number of Indians living in the Gulf now exceeds that figure by more than 50 times.

The struggle to preserve a fair international law



Prabhash Ranjan

Professor and Vice Dean (Research), Jindal Global Law School

The news that South African jurist Navi Pillay is the recipient of the 2026 Nobel Peace Prize could not have come at a better time for those agonisingly disconcerted by global apathy towards international law. At a time when international law is being battered by powerful, authoritarian men, drunk on power and willing to go to any lengths to pursue their imperialistic designs, the Nobel Committee has unequivocally signalled that international law matters. The real question, however, is what kind of international law matters.

Multiple narratives shape international law. One key narrative, as mentioned, is that vital tenets of international law, such as prohibiting the use of force in international relations, have been completely shredded, with multiple wars raging. Likewise, with rising authoritarianism, there has been a precipitous waning in compliance with international human rights law and an increase in the commission of war crimes and crimes against humanity.

While the normative decline of international law has been going on for quite some time, the fall has been precipitous in recent years, accompanied by utter disdain for universally accepted international norms. This scornful attitude towards international law became evident when (then) U.S. President Joe Biden leaned heavily towards using the ambiguous term "rules-based order" instead of "international law", signalling a movement towards an era of norm-light global governance. U.S. President Donald Trump took this several notches up when he said that he did not need international law because he was guided by his own morality.

Authoritarian international law

This brings us to what Tom Ginsburg calls authoritarian international law – an attempt to create a new normative order. Thus, while authoritarian leaders attacking the fundamental tenets of international law might give the impression that they are hollowing it out, the more nuanced picture is that authoritarians are retooling international law to pursue their objectives. As Ginsburg, Shirley Scott and others argue, the liberal international law order that emerged after the Second World War and which intensified after the end of the Cold War was a product of what democratic states did on the international plane.

Authoritarian leaders are undermining legal norms and reshaping international institutions to serve their interests

Although the liberal international law order's democratic credentials can always be questioned, civil, political and human rights were institutionalised and made part of its operating system. Countries created international organisations (IOs) to which they delegated significant powers, accompanied by high judicialisation – the creation of international courts and tribunals to settle disputes.

A scant respect for rights

With the rise of authoritarianism, including in liberal democracies, the fundamental nature of the liberal international legal order is being altered or, as Anne Applebaum argues, its operating system is changing. Authoritarian states view international law as a tool for coordinating regime survival. Respect for civil, political and human rights, and holding executive power accountable for war crimes and crimes against humanity, has little place in the authoritarian international legal order. Innovative uses of the age-old concept of sovereignty are another key feature. While developing countries often invoke sovereignty to shape international legal norms to serve their aspirations, today, sovereignty seems to be the cloak aimed at shielding authoritarian regimes' excesses from international scrutiny. Israel's systematic rejection of reports by UN human rights bodies that chide it for human rights violations, on the grounds that they interfere in its sovereign affairs, is a case in point.

Creating weak IOs with limited independent powers is another key feature of authoritarian international law. Once created, an IO takes on a life of its own, and member-states should not be able to control on a whim. This, however, does not suit authoritarian states, which want to retain maximum power while delegating as little as possible to IOs. The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation is a case in point. A preference for negotiation or quasi-judicial mechanisms to resolve disputes, rather than faith in third-party international adjudication, is also a pivotal attribute of authoritarian international law. The recent backlash against international courts, such as the International Criminal Court, is an example.

The need for a fightback

The kind of international law that Ms. Pillay represents is what most authoritarian regimes despise. The clearest example of this is Israel's condemnation of the Nobel prize, saying that the Nobel Committee has awarded the prize to the "greatest lie" of the 21st century. Israel was referring to Ms. Pillay's role as the Chair of the UN's Independent International Commission of Inquiry on the Occupied Palestinian Territory, which concluded that Israel has committed genocide in Gaza.

Rather than serving merely as a tool for extending a regime's influence and values beyond its borders, the kind of international law that Ms. Pillay represents has a thicker conception of the rule of law, laced with values of equality, fairness, accountability and making the individual a subject of international law. Authoritarian regimes cannot be expected to develop a fair international legal order premised on justice. Other actors, including courts, civil society and academia, must therefore mount international resistance to authoritarian regimes to pave the way for a liberal and fair international law.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Oil diplomacy and balance

When powerful nations come knocking with energy deals, it signals that India's global influence is growing ("Rubio pitches oil from U.S., Venezuela in Mumbai visit", October 21). India's massive refining capacity has made it a crucial player in the global energy market. However, such high-stakes diplomacy demands careful navigation. India must welcome new partnerships and diversify its oil sources to keep fuel affordable for ordinary citizens. Yet, it cannot afford to be drawn into global rivalries. India's strength lies in its independence. The true test of this visit lies not merely in the oil India buys, but in whether it helps secure a stable, affordable and peaceful future for every Indian household.

K. Chidanand Kumar,
Bengaluru

The 'master switch'

The report on the 'Charchagram' audit of ECINet, suggesting that access for State nodal officers can be disabled and that access to enumeration forms can be switched off State by State is alarming (Inside pages, "Report flags feature to centrally control access on ECINET", October 21). The report raises very serious questions about transparency, accountability and the autonomy of State-level election officials. The Election Commission of India must clarify who controls these permissions and what safeguards prevent arbitrary restrictions. Electoral integrity depends on public confidence in the systems.

V. Subramaniam,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Why sensitive legal language matters



Priyamvadha Shivaji

Senior Resident Fellow, Justice Access and Lowering Delays in India (JALDI) Initiative at Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy. Views are personal

Over the last few months, the Supreme Court of India has been engaged in an ongoing conversation about reforming judicial language, through the Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant's call for revising its 2024 Handbook on Combating Gender Stereotypes. In February, the CJI claimed that the Handbook was 'technical and Harvard-oriented', prompting a revised version which was published in August 2026. The revised Handbook on Judgments and Gender also advocates sensitivity in judicial language and practice.

In light of these developments, the Karnataka High Court's recent decision to replace the term 'visitation' with 'parenting time' in child custody cases is a welcome step in furthering the conversation around sensitive judicial language. Justice Lalitha Kanneganti's October 7 order rightly recognises the fact that parenting is not a responsibility that can be easily abdicated. Unfortunately, such steps continue to remain limited and context-specific, rather than becoming widespread judicial initiatives.

For every instance of the judiciary displaying empathy, multiple instances of insensitivity continue to persist. This was recognised by the Supreme Court itself, while condemning the remarks of an Allahabad High Court judge in a 2025 Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) judgment which eventually led to the revision of the 2024 Handbook. The 2026 Handbook analysed 125 trial court judgments across States, and admitted that although judgments reflected 'a modern, gender-sensitive judicial approach', the use of outdated, patriarchal terms such as 'real victim' and 'rape myths' persisted.

Past attempts to introduce gender sensitivity have clearly not been very successful. Judges have been sent for training and awareness sessions at judicial academies, and have been asked to study the recommendations for using specific language which have been laid out in the Handbooks as well as other material, including international frameworks such as the 2022 Bangkok General Guidance for Judges on Applying a Gender Perspective in South and Southeast Asia.

What will be done differently this time?

Dealing with insensitivity

The answer, perhaps, lies in the way shown by Justice Lalitha in truly engaging with what judicial insensitivity means, and why it matters. At first glance, her statement that 'no parent is a visitor in the life of a child' could be taken as a simple, universal fact. The parent's gender does not really make a difference when it comes to not being a 'visitor'. The truth, however, goes back – as all things do – to patriarchal expectations. The general assumption is that mothers are the more natural parents. The immediate parenting responsibility is thrust upon them in child custody cases. This is again linked with gendered parenting norms, such as the idea that mothers 'take care' while fathers 'babysit' their children, particularly in the Indian social context where women are still overwhelmingly the primary caregivers at home.

The powerful reminder that fathers, then, are not merely 'visitors' but must also be cast as active parents beyond the payment of maintenance understands that judicial sensitivity is not just a matter of swapping one problematic term for another slightly less problematic term. Words have meanings which cannot be separated from their social contexts, and change will come forth only when we are willing to recognise and confront them. This is what the Feminist Judgments Project aims to do. Sensitivity cannot be brought in by memorising and using specific terminology. The aim should be to examine underlying assumptions and identify areas where a feminist gaze would confront these biases and lead to a different conclusion, upholding substantive equality.

This requires meaningful representation of women and other diverse communities on the Bench in order to proactively identify areas where seemingly neutral terms cover up stark insensitivity. Attention must also be paid to insensitivity that can slip through other contexts: for example, well-intentioned efforts to provide access to persons with disabilities which nevertheless continue to dismiss dignity and individuality, or gaps in understanding caste or tribal socio-historical realities. The judiciary's ongoing conversations on sensitive language must contextualise these, delve deeper, and dismantle structural societal barriers.

Words have meanings which cannot be separated from their social contexts, and change will come forth only when we are willing to recognise and confront them

Unlocking agri-potential of FRA lands



S. Mahendra Dev

Chairman, Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister (EAC-PM)



Sushil Kumar Singla

Secretary (Environment, Science Technology and Climate Change), Government of Himachal Pradesh

For millions of forest-dwelling communities, securing rights over land is a vital milestone. For a tribal household, a parcel of land can mean much more than just a legal right. It can be the foundation of livelihood security – provided that conducive conditions exist to make the land productive and sustainable.

While the Forest Rights Act (FRA), 2006, has strengthened land and livelihood rights of millions of tribals and forest-dwelling communities, the next step is to complement these rights with sustainable agriculture practices, improved soil and water management, institutional support, and market access.

Oilseed and pulses can play a significant role in unlocking the productive potential of FRA-recognised lands. Promoting the cultivation of these crops can turn these lands into more productive and remunerative livelihood assets, while simultaneously strengthening domestic supplies and helping reduce India's import dependence. The adaptability of pulses and oilseeds to rain-fed and marginal lands make them a suitable choice to improve agricultural productivity and promote climate-resilient agriculture.

The geographical spread of tribal districts across 33 States and Union Territories reflects ecological and socio-economic diversity. These regions also differ in settlement patterns, resource availability and agricultural potential, underscoring the importance of approaches that are responsive to local conditions and development priorities. An analysis based on the UN Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) soil map suggests that several tribal regions are well suited to crops such as soybean, groundnut, sunflower, mustard, chickpea and other pulses. Further, a State-wise cropping pattern analysis shows considerable diversity across tribal regions: paddy and maize dominate the Kharif season, while wheat, gram, mustard, lentil and other pulses are important Rabi crops.

Regional crops namely millets, soybean, cotton, groundnut, sesame, spices, and horticulture crop further reflect local agro-ecological conditions, offering scope for sustainable diversification of oilseed and pulse cultivation on FRA lands.

Scoping the country

The analysis also found that out of 244 tribal districts, 60 districts have major oilseed production potential, 31 have strong pulse production potential, while 23 districts possess favourable conditions for the cultivation of both pulses and oilseeds. Such a spatial alignment of FRA lands with agricultural potential suggests that one needs targeted interventions to expand sustainable pulse and oilseed cultivation in these regions. Expanding access to quality seeds and improved varieties, improving the soil moisture regime, and scientific crop management can strengthen pulse and oilseed production, with potential benefits for farm incomes, nutrition and livelihood resilience. Integrating these measures with FRA land development can make tribal development more resilient and simultaneously strengthen national food security and improve tribal livelihoods, particularly since many tribal districts overlap with aspirational districts.

A region-specific strategy could be adopted to help develop oilseed and pulse production clusters on FRA lands in high-potential tribal districts. Priority measures could include timely and adequate access to certified seeds, improved irrigation and watershed management and stronger agri-extension. Further, investments in local drying, storage, grading and primary processing infrastructure can reduce post-harvest losses and improve value realisation. Empowered and stronger farmer producer organisations, cooperatives, self-help groups and other community institutions in and around tribal regions can facilitate aggregation, value addition and market access. Convergence with programmes such as the Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchayee Yojana, National Food Security and Nutrition Mission, National Mission on Edible Oils, Pradhan Mantri Annadata Aay Sanrakshan Abhiyan and Van Dhan Yojana can broaden institutional support. GIS-based crop planning, together with improved institutional credit, crop insurance and assured procurement can strengthen the overall marketing ecosystem.

The journey from forest rights to livelihood security does not end with land recognition; it begins from there. The productive potential of FRA lands can be strengthened by aligning local agro-ecological conditions with suitable pulses and oilseeds and providing the support needed to cultivate and market them effectively.

While the Forest Rights Act (FRA), 2006, has strengthened the livelihood rights of millions of tribals and forest-dwelling communities, the next step is to complement these rights with sustainable agriculture practices

Drug prices: overcharging claims of ₹8,447 crore remain unpaid

The outstanding amount accounts for about 84% of the cumulative demand

DATA POINT

Devyanshi Bihani

On October 12, the Centre informed the Supreme Court that it had decided to cap trade margins at 30% for non-scheduled anti-cancer medicines. A Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta questioned why similar restrictions could not be extended to other medicines and medical products. Citing steep differences between the prices at which products were supplied and those charged to patients, the court asked the government to work out broader measures for regulating medicine prices. The matter is scheduled to be heard again on October 27.

While high trade margins are not necessarily illegal, overcharging beyond regulated prices violates the Drugs (Prices Control) Orders (DPCO), which governs medicine pricing in India. Both, however, raise questions about the costs borne by patients.

The National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA), the government's drug-price regulator, continues to pursue companies over past cases of overcharging. Although established in 1997, the NPPA's records cover cases dating back to 1979. Since certain pricing violations can attract penalties, as of March 31, 2026, ₹10,029.8 crore had been demanded, including with interest. Of the total demanded, ₹1,582.4 crore had been realised, leaving ₹8,447.4 crore outstanding. The scale of the issue matters because medicines make up a significant share of household hospitalisation costs. According to the National Statistics Office's Household Social Consumption: Health survey, conducted in 2025, medicine expenditure averaged ₹6,368 per hospitalisation case in rural areas, out of a total of ₹32,884 – nearly one-fifth of the cost. In urban areas, the average was ₹6,948 out of ₹46,774, or about one-seventh **(Chart 1)**.

The outstanding amount is more than five times the amount realised and accounts for about 84% of the cumulative demand. Moreover, these figures cover only cases in which the NPPA has raised demands against companies for overcharging. They do not include cases that may have gone undetected or have not been pursued by the regulator. The NPPA's year-wise data show that the number of cases has varied considerably between 2009-10 and 2025-26. The highest count in this period was 268 cases in 2015-16, followed by 224 in 2017-18. The number fell to 38 in 2020-21 before rising to 148 in 2022-23. In 2025-26, the regulator recorded 133 cases **(Chart 2)**.

The annual entries after 2009 add up to approximately ₹5,265 crore in demands, including interest, of which about ₹4,460 crore remain outstanding. For the period before 2009, the NPPA recorded 731 cases, with ₹4,764.75 crore demanded and ₹3,987.5 crore outstanding. Outstanding amounts were highest in 2015-16, at ₹1,003.3 crore, followed by ₹576 crore in 2017-18. In 2025-26, ₹45.1 crore remained outstanding against a demand of ₹72.2 crore **(Chart 3)**. Of the total outstanding amount, more than ₹5,800 crore is tied up in litigation. Another ₹200 crore relates to cases referred to collectors for recovery, while ₹2,369.3 crore remains under process **(Chart 4)**.

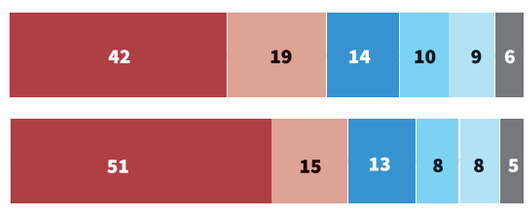
Importantly, recovering money from pharmaceutical companies is distinct from compensating patients who paid higher prices. In a Lok Sabha reply in 2019, the Department of Pharmaceuticals stated that "there is no mechanism to compensate the consumers for the amount overcharged." However, the NPPA accepts complaints from consumers about medicine overpricing, shortages, new drugs being sold without prior price approval, and refusal to supply or sell medicines. The regulator takes action where warranted.

A bitter pill to swallow

The data for the charts were sourced from the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) and NSS Report no. 596: Household Social Consumption: Health (2025) by the Ministry of Statistics and Program Implementation



CHART 1: The break-up of average medical expenditure (₹) (excluding childbirth) per hospitalisation case by its component across medical institutions in rural and urban areas during 2025



When hospitals charged a single package price and households could not specify expenditure on individual items, the amount was recorded as a lump sum under the 'package component'. Since these packages may include medicines, the actual share of hospitalisation costs spent on medicines could be higher than the separately reported figures of nearly 1/5th in rural areas and 1/7th in urban areas

CHART 3: Amount outstanding and amount realised against demands raised by the NPPA for each financial year cohort, from 2009-10 to 2025-26 (₹ crore). Recoveries may occur in years subsequent to the demand

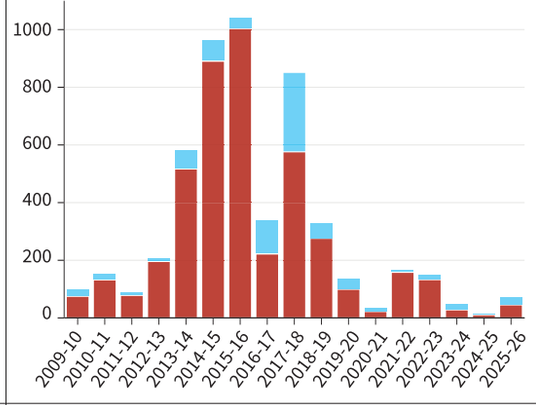


CHART 2: Number of overcharging cases recorded by the NPPA each financial year, from 2009-10 to 2025-26

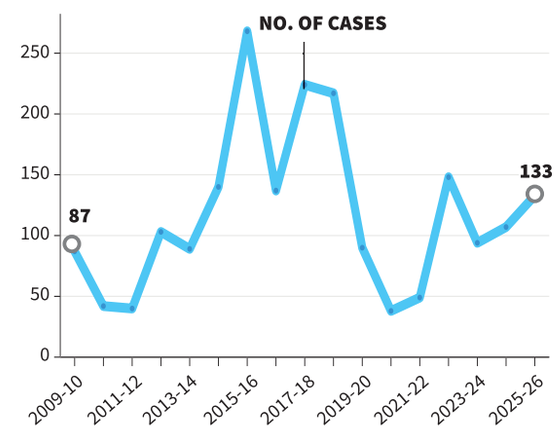
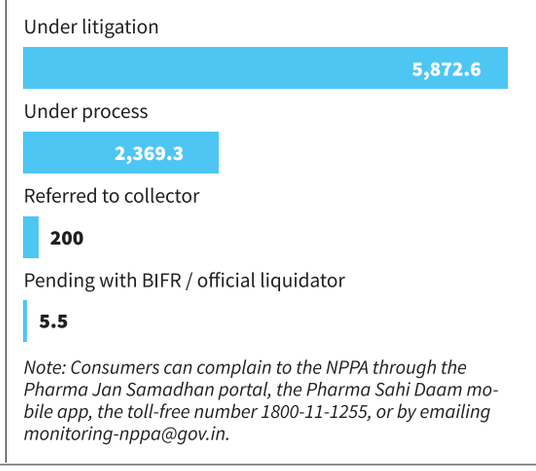


CHART 4: Break-up of the NPPA's outstanding overcharging dues by status as of March 31, 2026 (₹ crore)



Note: Consumers can complain to the NPPA through the Pharma Jan Samadhan portal, the Pharma Sahi Daam mobile app, the toll-free number 1800-11-1255, or by emailing monitoring-nppa@gov.in.

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO OCTOBER 22, 1976

Massive march in Peking to back Hua's leadership

Tokyo, October 21: For the first time since the reported arrest of the four Shanghai radicals for their attempted coup, large-scale demonstrations criticising the group were held in the streets of Peking to-day, according to reports reaching here from the Chinese capital.

Thousands of soldiers, students, and ordinary citizens took part in the demonstrations carrying banners calling for the overthrow of the four – Mao's widow Chiang Ching, Wang Hung-wen, Chang Chun-Chiao and Yao Wen Yuan – for their anti-party and anti-revolutionary criminal acts.

Thousands of demonstrators paraded through the streets of Tien An Men shouting slogans and waving small flags with many carrying banners hailing the great victory won in smashing the anti revolutionary plot of the four radicals and expressing strong support for the appointment of Premier Hua Kuo-Feng as party Chairman and Chairman of the Military Commission. They also carried paper flags calling for the overthrow of Chiang Ching. The demonstrations against the four in Peking follow reports of the large-scale demonstrations, attacking them, which have been taking place for the past several days.

Meanwhile, 25 pictures taken at the time of the memorial services for Mao Tse-Tung were removed from the notice board in front of the People's Daily office in Peking last night.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO OCTOBER 22, 1926

England-Australia sea route

London, October 21: A group of business men, headed by Sir James Connolly, Sir John Biles, Mr. Eustace D'Eyncourt and Mr. Parles Parsons, have submitted to Australian Government a scheme to form a company, with a capital of eleven millions sterling to build in Britain, a fleet of 22 knot-liners to make a regular fortnightly service between Britain and Australia, calling at Bombay and Colombo both ways, half as fast again as the present weekly mail service, which would result in bringing Australia a week and India five days nearer to Britain. It is suggested that the Australian Government should give the new line, for a fixed period, same mail subsidies that are at present being paid to mailship companies and immigrants traffic to Australia above those carried by the Commonwealth line.

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Death toll from Sudan army strike in disputed territory

153 The death toll from a drone strike on Monday on a market in an area disputed between Sudan and South Sudan has risen to 153 and is likely even higher, a local official said on Wednesday. "The number may increase because some victims have been burned to ashes and the rescuers are doing their best to gather all the bodies," official said. AFP

MoUs signed by Pak., Maldives in defence and maritime security

20 Pakistan and the Maldives on Wednesday signed 20 memorandums of understanding to strengthen cooperation in various fields, including defence, maritime security and artificial intelligence. The agreements were inked during the visit of Maldivian President Mohamed Muizzu, who arrived in Islamabad at the invitation of Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif. PTI

Growth in India's key infrastructure industries in Sept.

7.9 in per cent. Output of key infrastructure industries increased by 7.9% in September 2026 against 3.1% in the year-ago month, driven by strong performance of iron ore, electricity and cement segments. According to the official data released by the Commerce and Industry Ministry on Wednesday, the core sector expanded by 5.9% in August. PTI

Vehicles registered in Maharashtra during Navratri

1.12 lakh. Maharashtra recorded the registration of 1,12,814 vehicles, including over 77,000 bikes and 25,000 cars, during the 10-day Navratri festival this year, a dip of about 2% over last year. They attributed the drop in the numbers to poor rainfall, drought and uncertainty in global financial conditions. PTI

Number of militants killed in Balochistan in the last 12 months

1,100 At least 1,100 militants belonging to banned insurgent groups and Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) have been killed in Pakistan's volatile Balochistan in the last 12 months, the Home Minister of the province said on Wednesday. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

Follow us facebook.com/thehindu X.com/the_hindu instagram.com/the_hindu

How exposed is India to foreign tech?

Elon Musk's reported restrictions on satellite services to Ukraine show the risks of India's dependence on foreign-controlled technology; from satellite navigation to cloud computing and military equipment, gaps in domestic capabilities can leave critical infrastructure exposed to external pressure

EXPLAINER

Vasudevan Mukunth

U.S. space tycoon Elon Musk recently throttled the military-grade Starshield network provided by his company SpaceX to Ukraine in retaliation for Ukraine's attacks on Russian oil infrastructure, *The Wall Street Journal* has reported. Musk's actions are not without precedent – with a similar move in 2022 (although SpaceX disputed media reports) – but his most recent transgression should put other countries still using or planning to use his services on alert.

That includes India. The Indian government and industry have thus far resisted Starlink's entry. Musk is unhappy and likely to keep pushing. On the flip side, quite a bit of India's critical infrastructure is exposed to services provided by other foreign operators. They have acted lawfully so far, but the country still retains strong incentives to substitute them with homegrown alternatives.

The worst possible outcome on the spectrum of possibilities vis-à-vis India is for a foreign operator to directly restrict a continuing service. Two other possibilities include foreign-controlled platforms disrupting access to an otherwise Indian system and a foreign supplier non-abruptly degrading India's ability to sustain important capabilities.



The Indian government and industry have thus far resisted Starlink's entry; Elon Musk is unhappy and likely to keep pushing. REUTERS

THE GIST

- India's satellite broadband, cloud computing and military programmes rely partly on foreign-controlled networks, systems and equipment
- NavIC's operational shortcomings and India's dependence on foreign cloud management systems expose gaps in domestic capabilities
- Homegrown alternatives such as UPI offer greater autonomy, but dependence on foreign suppliers and international financial networks leaves India vulnerable to disruptions

Satellite communications

The Indian government has currently licensed three companies to provide satellite communications services: Starlink, the Indian subsidiary of Eutelsat OneWeb, and Jio Satellite Communications. As of October 16, none had received the security clearance they need to offer broadband services provided by commercial satellites.

Musk's SpaceX controls Starlink and retains the ability to manage its network and restrict services (if needed). Eutelsat OneWeb is backed by the governments of European countries and its satellite network is effectively controlled by the continental bloc. The Bharti group has invested in it to the tune of 26%.

The French company Eutelsat operates the Eutelsat OneWeb satellite network, in which the French government holds a 29.65% stake, the British government 10.89%, and Bharti Space 17.88%. Bharti Airtel also separately owns 26% of OneWeb's Indian subsidiary.

Finally, Jio Platforms and the Luxembourg-based communications satellites provider SES announced a joint venture in 2022 in which Jio would own 51% in exchange for being able to use the provider's satellites. However, again, even majority Indian ownership of the business doesn't yield control of the network to Jio.

That said, India doesn't depend all that much on foreign satellite networks for communications at large: most ordinary telephone and internet traffic travels over terrestrial networks and the two score communications satellites the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) has launched since 1981 support broadcasting and strategic communications. The country also has dedicated military satellite communications capabilities.

Note, however, that the three aforementioned ventures plan to provide satellite broadband services alone.

Satellite navigation

India's position is particularly weak here because it has fumbled the setting up of its NavIC constellation, a group of satellites to provide position and navigation services over the Indian subcontinent the same way the U.S. GPS system does around the world.

On July 29 this year, Minister of State for the Department of Space Jitendra Singh admitted in Parliament that only three NavIC satellites are at present able to provide positioning, navigation, and timing (PNT) signals, i.e., that the constellation currently can't provide standalone positioning services. At least four satellites are required for this purpose.

The U.S. discontinued its policy to be able to deliberately degrade global civilian GPS accuracy in 2000 and committed to not reinstating that mechanism. However, it retains the ability to deny PNT services for military purposes over specific areas.

A less-than-direct but nonetheless important reason India hasn't been able to maintain NavIC's functional integrity is ISRO's ongoing difficulties with improving its launch rate.

Cloud computing and IT

Amazon Web Services (AWS), Microsoft Azure, and Google Cloud currently provide cloud-computing infrastructure and managed services to thousands of businesses and public institutions in India, with Gartner forecasting that Indians' expenditure on cloud services would reach $17.5 billion in 2026.

That said, the government operates its own cloud infrastructure, called MeghRaj, through the National Informatics Centre (NIC). In December 2025, the government reported that 2,170 ministries and departments were hosting applications on MeghRaj, but that they also depended on empanelled private cloud providers, including those based abroad.

In February, AWS and an Indian company named Yotta announced they would deploy AWS Outposts technology for MeghRaj 2.0, allowing cloud services managed by AWS to operate from within NIC data centres and thus keeping Indian data physically within India.

However, the AWS documentation says Outposts need a connection to an AWS regional control system for monitoring and software updates, meaning it's possible the arrangement will continue to leave Indian physical infrastructure exposed to a management service controlled by foreign operators.

In the cloud-computing as in the satellite services domain, while the providers' actions are constrained by contracts and Indian law, the services they deliver technically depend on their systems.

Finally, experts have also called to increase adoption of open-source software, including operating systems. The Union government's 2015 policy already made open-source software the preferred option for e-governance projects. The Centre for Development of Advanced Computing, under the Ministry of Electronics and IT, has developed the Linux-based 'Bharat Operating System Solutions'.

A good example from recent memory was a defective update from the U.S. cybersecurity company CrowdStrike disrupting Windows computers worldwide, including at Indian airlines, airports, and securities firms. Not all disruptive actions are retaliatory but are disruptive nonetheless.

Digital payments

The National Payments Corporation of India operates the Unified Payments Interface (UPI) and the domestic infrastructure provides India with considerable independence from Visa and Mastercard. That said, the consumer-facing layer is non-trivially concentrated in businesses controlled by foreign players such as Google Pay, owned by Google.

However, Google Pay shutting down would not disrupt UPI itself: users could simply switch to another solution, such as PhonePe. (Although U.S.-based Walmart has a majority stake in PhonePe, it can't control the underlying infrastructure itself – unlike with the Jio-SES venture.)

That said, banks also operate within payment and correspondent banking networks that involve foreign institutions. This is why, for instance, the European Union decided in 2022 to disconnect select Russian banks from the SWIFT transaction messaging network, significantly upsetting the ability of affected banks to access international payment channels.

India could face comparable disruptions if foreign governments imposed sanctions affecting Indian financial institutions even if the relevant banks have not violated Indian law. As a result, in the larger scheme, domestic payment systems like UPI insulate against but don't eliminate exposure to the risks accompanying cross-border commerce.

Military equipment

After the Operation Shakti nuclear tests in 1998, the U.S. imposed sanctions on India, including restricting military supplies. As a result, the Comptroller and Auditor General later found that the 30 LHTEC T800 helicopter engines Hindustan Aeronautics Ltd. had ordered from a U.S.-based manufacturer in April that year couldn't be delivered. So HAL nixed the arrangement and ordered replacements from a French manufacturer.

Both parties here acted within the law (such as they were) and neither engaged in unilateral corporate retaliation like Musk has. Yet a foreign political decision still disturbed an Indian procurement programme.

According to a Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI) analysis published in March this year, India was the world's second-largest importer of major arms between 2021 and 2025. Russia accounted for 40% of these imports, with India increasingly also purchasing equipment from France, Israel, and the U.S.

Even the indigenous Tejas fighter programme banks on U.S.-made GE Aerospace engines, and delays in the delivery of these machines have already constrained production and pushed delivery deadlines.

BIBLIOGRAPHY





GETTY IMAGES

How illness, stigma, and social realities find a place in Tamil literature

Tamil literature explores illness, caste, gender, and barriers to healthcare, though medical themes remain relatively rare; Imayam stands out for blending clinical detail with social commentary on disease, stigma, and human suffering

Ramya Kannan

Tamil literature is replete with references to Siddha practitioners, traditional healers, and the faith, or lack of it, that people have in them. A segment of Tamil literature that has focused on class and caste hierarchies has also looked sharply and sensitively at the socio-economic determinants for access to health care. Among the pioneers of drawing technology and science into his writings in Tamil was the legendary, prescient novelist and screenwriter Sujatha. But in modern Tamil fiction, the employment of medicine and medical issues as the central theme and plot has been rather minimal.

While there might be only a few texts in popular, modern Tamil fiction that weave the story around a medical condition, these form a significant contribution to the genre. Muthumeenal's *Mul* focuses on leprosy, and Sivakami's *Pazhayana Kazhithalum* offers a health perspective couched in caste discrimination.

Among the Tamil writers who have formed a strong bond between their stories and health issues, Imayam stands tall, not merely through sheer numbers, but through depth of content. Many of his short stories and novels couch the essential human experience he portrays in medical conditions, each wrapped in the other, not distinct, but influencing and impacting each other.

Health in Tamil fiction

But before we dip into Imayam's work, a full-length novel of note on a core health issue is *Mul* (thorn) by Muthumeenal, a deep and personalised account of living with leprosy. The narrator is a young girl whose life has been upended when she finds suspicious patches on her body. She moves into an institution where medical care is provided, around which the story is built, and the multiple angles, including stigma, politics, loneliness, and internal struggle, are woven into this autobiography. The public-health message is stigma-busting: that leprosy is treatable, and early therapy can cure it.

In retired IAS officer Sivakami's work, a Dalit feminist treatise, *Pazhayana Kazhithalum (The Grip of Change)*, the text deals strongly with the social determinants of health – caste violence, gender-based violence, bodily autonomy, and the mental and physical toll of bigotry.

In Imayam's *Ippothu Uyirodirukkiren (I'm Alive... For Now)*, the author artfully folds in the themes of both the above novels – crafting a social commentary within the nephrology ward of a government hospital where a teenager with end-stage kidney disease has been admitted. It follows his rapid decline, his transition onto dialysis, and organ donation. Reviewers have praised its 'authentic' portrayal of nephrology, the disease, and the treatment.

But this is an achievement across various novels that Imayam, a school teacher and politician, has penned. While known for his sharp critique of caste and gender hegemonies, Imayam has also built a strong subgenre of medical literature. Unlike authors who use disease as a generic plot device or a melodramatic tool to lead up to a crisis, he treats medical conditions with gripping sociological depth and clinical accuracy.

A Sahitya Akademi winner, Imayam attempts to explain the human condition through pain, suffering and debility, and as his longtime collaborator-translator Justice Prabha Sridevan says, "an astonishingly astute understanding of the feminine condition." His recent novel, *Noiputtru* (disease), also talks of life derailed by leprous patches.

Set in a Tamil Nadu leprosarium in the 1960s, the novel documents the lived experiences of patients ostracised from their families and confined to State-run institutions, including detailed descriptions of the diagnostic and treatment processes. The descriptions of the impact of leprosy are merciless – thickening ears, flattened noses, and physical disfigurement – there's no way to conceal this in the deliberate, yet sparse prose of the author.

Imayam's world of illness

Very few novels in Tamil come with the searing commentary that he delivers in *Sellatha Panam (A Woman Burnt)*. Unlike in the case of the protagonist of the above-mentioned novels, here, Revathi, an upper-caste woman who is forced to take the extreme move after her inter-caste marriage, is trapped in a liminal world and confined to bed. Around her, in the waiting corridors of the burns ward, social realities are exposed, the niceties ripped off, though his most effective literary tool is conversations between people. It is said Imayam spent time observing the JIPMER burns ward while researching the book.

Just launched, the English translation of *Uppu Vandikaran (The Salt Vendor)* harks back to the dark, panic-driven emergency of the pandemic lockdown. It's not just about falling ill with COVID-19; instead, it exposes the lacunae and inadequacies in the medical system, as Chellamuthu goes from one hospital to the other, being rejected by each one of them since he cannot produce a certificate confirming his infection- a situation the world was familiar with during the first couple of years of the 2020s. Similarly, his short story *Government Pinam* (*The Government Corpse*) is situated in the pandemic, focusing on a boy quarantined with his sick father in a house sealed shut by government officials.

In Imayam's debut novel *Koveru Kazhudaigal (Mules)*, over three decades ago, a significant segment is about how the women of the *Vannar* community deliver through traditional midwifery practices, outside of medical institutions. He also broaches the subject of patient attendants, a subject gaining currency in a nation growing increasingly grey, and the care of the elderly comes into the spotlight. In *Pinathuku Sondhakkari (Owner of the Corpse)*: Meenakshi, a live-in attendant, is left alone to handle her elderly employer Ramanan's sudden death, his children away and slow to return.

Manamurivu (Divorce) deals with the gendered nature of infertility, dragging the reader through IVF clinics, menstrual cycles, hormone injections, and the inordinate stress to bear children on the woman in the relationship.

Since the COVID-19 pandemic drew science and medicine into drawing rooms and headlines, willy-nilly, it remains to be seen whether Tamil literature will now make room for more health-related content.

THE DAILY QUIZ

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

There are student protests happening around the world, from India to France and Albania. Here is a quiz on some major student protests over the last decade or so:

Radhika Santhanam

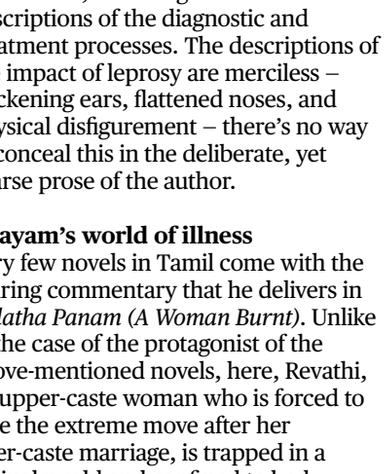
QUESTION 1
In 2022, a protest movement was launched in this country after the death of a young woman who was arrested by the morality police. Four years later, this country was jointly attacked by two other countries, and its leader was assassinated. Name this country and also the movement.

QUESTION 2
Peaceful demands from university students to abolish quotas in civil service jobs quickly turned into wider anti-government protests that turned violent. In response, the country's leader cut off internet access in parts, imposed a nationwide curfew, and described those protesting against her as "terrorists". Both her house and her father's house were vandalised. Name this leader and her father.

QUESTION 3
Several months before the Covid pandemic began, an estimated 1.4 million people around the world took part in strikes for climate action. One Swedish student's solo protest the previous year prompted the global movement. Name the student.

QUESTION 4
In 2018, thousands of participants gathered near the U.S. Capitol crying in grief and anger while displaying portraits of children. Thousands more gathered once again under the same banner in 2022 and were supported by the then President Joe Biden. What were they calling for?

QUESTION 5
This landlocked country is going to the polls in a couple of days. Its students pose the greatest threat yet to the rule of a leader who has dominated politics since 2014. Name this country, the home of a tennis player who is arguably the greatest of all time.



Visual Question:
A pro-democracy movement in this country called for the resignation of this leader. A former army chief, he seized power in a 2014 coup and was later appointed as premier after controversial elections. Name the country and the leader.

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily question: 1. In 2010, when Barcelona delivered a "manita" (little hand with five fingers) 5-0 victory against Real Madrid, who scored the fifth goal for the Catalan club? **Ans: Jeffren Suarez**
2. This footballer played for Barcelona in its 5-0 win against Real Madrid in 1994 and was fielded by Madrid in its revenge 5-0 win against Barcelona in 1995. **Ans: Michael Laudrup**
3. Lionel Messi holds the record for the most goals scored in the Clasicos. His countryman shares the record for the second-most goals scored. Name him. **Ans: Alfredo De Stefano**
4. Which player holds record for playing in the most Clasicos? **Ans: Sergio Busquets**
4. What connects Josep Samitier, Luis Enrique, Luis Figo and Ronaldo and the Clasicos? **Ans: They scored for both Barcelona and Real Madrid in the Clasicos**
Visual: Identify the manager. **Ans: Miguel Muñoz**
Early Birds: Prem Nath Tiwari | Ravindra Kumar Sahu | Sadhan Panda | Aryan Wari | Sudhir Thapa



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

"I have been waiting for an hour. Where were you?"
"I am sorry. I had to go to the station."
"I told you that I had to send all this stuff by this afternoon. I've been working myself up into a lather trying to...."
"Working yourself up into a lather?"
"It means he has been working very hard."
"I see. But what is the connection between lather and working very hard? I mean...."
".... the lather refers to the sweat. You need to work yourself up into a lather. The study has to be completed today."
"How about this example? Don't work yourself up into a lather. The assignment isn't due until next month."
"That's a good example. Atul worked himself up into a lather trying to get the project completed."
"That sounds like Atul. He and Dilip have always been very hard-working."
"Dilip doesn't need to work anymore."
"Everyone has to work."
"Dilip doesn't have to. That's for sure. Haven't you heard? He won the lottery a couple of months ago. And ever since then, he has been riding the gravy train."
"He's been riding the gravy train?"
"When you say that someone 'rides the gravy train' what you mean is that he/she is living in luxury."
"Leading a very comfortable life."
"That's right. It is an expression that is mostly used in informal contexts."
"I see. Can I say, even if I had a million dollars I wouldn't want to ride the gravy train."
"You cannot."
"Why not? What's wrong with it"
"It's not true, that's all. You won't work yourself up into a lather getting anything done. That's for sure."
"You have a point there. I'd probably hire others to do my work."
"Many people think that the kind of job that I have right now is a gravy train."
"Your job is a gravy train! What does that mean"
"Well any job that gets you a steady supply of easy money is called a gravy train."
"Easy money"
"A situation when you don't really have to work hard."
"In that case, I agree. Your job is a real gravy train. Are you as relaxed as this when you are at the office?"
"I shall not answer such dumb questions."
"Some people just don't know what is good for them. I'd be willing to ride the gravy train any time."
"Talking about trains. Why did you go to the station this morning?"
"My uncle arrived this morning. His train was two hours late."
"Which uncle are you talking about"
"The one who gave you a big lecture on why young girls shouldn't wear jeans."
"Oh that old fuddy-duddy. Is he..."
"....that old what"
"F..u..d..d..y..d..u..d..d..y. The 'u' is pronounced like the 'u' in 'mud', 'bud' and 'cud'."
"And the stress is on the first syllable of 'fuddy', I suppose"
"That's right."
"What does the word mean"
"An individual who has very old fashioned ideas and attitudes."
"People think that my grandfather is a fuddy-duddy. But when you talk to him you realise that he isn't one."
"You are a fuddy-duddy."
"I am not!"
Published in The Hindu on April 30, 2002

Word of the day

Garrulous:
full of trivial conversation

Synonyms: talkative, chatty, voluble

Usage: *My garrulous neighbour talks to everyone she meets.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/garrulous

International Phonetic Alphabet: /gærələs/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

INBRIEF



Essar Ports bags ₹2,276-crore Tuna Tekra terminal project

Essar Ports Ltd., part of the Essar Group, has received a Letter of Award (LoA) from Deendayal Port Authority (DPA) to develop a multipurpose cargo terminal at Tuna Tekra in Kandla, Gujarat, at an estimated cost of ₹2,276.06 crore under the public-private partnership (PPP) model. Essar Ports emerged as the highest bidder in a global competitive bidding process for the project, which will be implemented on a build, operate and transfer (BOT) basis.

Rupee strengthens for eighth consecutive day on IPO inflow

The rupee strengthened for the eighth consecutive session on Wednesday buoyed by foreign fund inflows linked to Jio Platforms IPO. However, a sharp rise in crude oil prices capped gains amid concerns over imported inflation. The rupee closed at 94.46 against the U.S. dollar, its strongest level in over a month, after touching an intraday high of 94.43. The currency pared some of its gains as benchmark Brent crude prices climbed to $110 a barrel.

Thiagarajar, Euro to set up ₹100-crore fabric unit in T.N.

A firm part of the Madurai-based Thiagarajar Group and German firm Euro Textiles will invest ₹100 crore to set up a specialised fabric unit at Virudhunagar in Tamil Nadu. The joint venture is expected to have 48 advanced air jet weaving pieces of machinery to make three million metre of cotton jacquard fabric every year. It will initially be an export oriented unit, but will later explore opportunities in the local market too, said K. Hari Thiagarajan, MD, Thiagarajar Mills.

Eight web security keys of eMudhra firm leaked

Many government websites, including Aadhaar issuer UIDAI and Income Tax filing portal, use digital certificates or other technology from the Bengaluru-headquartered company

Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI



Root of the matter: eMudhra is the sole Indian root certificate authority trusted globally. GETTYIMAGES/ISTOCK

Eight private keys used to issue web security certificates by Bengaluru-headquartered eMudhra Ltd. have been leaked, sending security teams at major Internet browser and operating system developers around the world scrambling to patch systems to stop trusting affected certificates.

The development comes as several government websites use a range of eMudhra's keys to "sign" security certificates necessary for any website to display on a modern browser.

The "intermediate" security certificate keys had a glaring flaw, according to an anonymous researcher who alerted major Internet infrastructure firms over the last few days. The uncovered flaw boiled down to this: instead of using a 384-bit private key, the intermediate certificates just had a numerical key that was between 1 and 256, making it easier to infer them. Public key cryptography, such as that used in web security certificates, or SSL certificates, rely on private keys staying unknown to any outside entities. One of the keys was just the number 4 preceded by 383 zeroes.

Dennis Jackson, involved in Mozilla's response to the incident, said eMudhra's private keys were "trivial to exploit," adding "6 of the impacted certificates were for TLS and trusted by Chrome, Mozilla, Microsoft and Apple root programmes". eMudhra revoked the affected certificates.

Response initiated

"eMudhra initiated incident response procedures, took measures to contain the affected certificates, and began working closely with browser and root-store operators to safeguard users and maintain the integrity of the broader WebPKI ecosystem," eMudhra said in an update.

"Importantly, none of the affected intermediate CAs (certificate authorities) were deployed in production, with the exception of one," eMudhra said.

"Furthermore, none of these intermediate CAs, including the one deployed in production, have issued any end-entity certificates.

In a statement filed with stock exchanges, eMudhra said, "A flaw in the [Key Generation Ceremony] caused a wrap/unwrap step to produce a second set of weak keys alongside the original strong keys." It added, "The weak keys were the ones published to the browser root stores. eMudhra is working to establish the root cause."

Yash Kakadia, founder of the Security Brigade cybersecurity firm, said the impact of this leak, even if patched on browsers, could extend to Internet-of-things (IoT) devices that are not frequently patched to address certificate compromise incidents like this. "The cleanup could be enormous, particularly for devices and software that cannot be easily updated.

Many government websites, including the Aadhaar issuer UIDAI and the Income Tax filing portal, use eMudhra certificates or other technology from the company.

MeitY said in a statement shared with *The Hindu* a "special team has been constituted to investigate the matter.

"Social media accounts are indulging in fear mongering about the impact of this incident," it said adding issuing web security certificates was "international in nature and operates under global trust framework." The "reported security incident pertains to this only". The IT Ministry was not involved in audit of this portion of eMudhra's operations, it said.

"The impact of this incident on Indian websites and applications have been very limited and for a very short interval," MeitY said. "Important to note that Digital Signature Certificates and eSign services regulated by Controller of Certifying Authorities (CCA), remains completely unaffected by this incident," the Ministry added.

There is no indication eMudhra's root certificates themselves– which sit above the tier leaked – have been compromised.

Global browsers have been reluctant to trust Indian root certificate authorities since "rogue" certificates were issued in July 2014 by the National Informatics Centre's root authority. eMudhra is the sole Indian root certificate authority trusted globally.

RBI MPC highlights widening inflationary pressure in economy

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI



Members acknowledged risks posed by the West Asia conflict.

Broadening inflationary pressures and the risk of second-round price rises dominated the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) deliberations in October, with members differing over the need to signal further monetary tightening, the minutes of the meeting reveals.

The MPC unanimously voted to raise the repo rate by 25 basis points (bps) to 5.5% during its October 5-7 meeting. However, external members Nagesh Kumar and Ram Singh dissented on the decision to shift the policy stance from neutral to calibrated tightening.

"I do not favour shifting the stance from neutral to tightening as it may signal an extended cycle of rate hikes. This can neutralise the benefits of growth-supportive monetary and fiscal policies in the recent past," Mr. Singh said.

Despite differences over the policy stance, the members broadly acknowledged the risks posed by the West Asia conflict, rising oil prices and the spread of inflation beyond food and fuel.

"Inflationary pressures are building up. Headline CPI is projected to touch the upper tolerance band [of 6%] in Q3 and stay significantly above 5% in the next two quarters," said Governor Sanjay Malhotra.

Pointing to the diffusion of price pressures, Mr. Malhotra said the share of commodities in the consumer price index (CPI) basket recording inflation above 4% rose to 37% in August from 20% in March.

Core inflation rose to 4.2% in August from 3.9% in July while core inflation, excluding precious metals, hastened to 2.9% on strong monthly momentum of 0.5%. Underlying inflation, measured by core inflation excluding precious metals, was also expected to rise above the target in the coming months, indicating normalisation from earlier benign levels, according to Mr.Malhotra.

He said the duration and extent of the rate-hiking cycle would depend on growth-inflation developments, the broadening of price pressures, second-round effects of supply shocks and demand conditions.

The calibrated-tightening stance signals that rate cuts are off the table in the near term, with future action limited to a hike or a pause depending on evolving conditions, he added.

Agrivoltaics on 10% land can meet 2050 power need: Joshi

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Operationalising just 10% of agricultural land suitable for agrivoltaics in India can generate enough electricity to meet India's projected power demand for 2050, Union Minister for New and Renewable Energy Pralhad Joshi said.

"If even 10% [of the land deemed suitable for agrivoltaics] is converted [towards operationalisation], more than whatever power requirement is being estimated for 2050 can be generated by agrivoltaics," he said, citing a study by The Energy and Resources Institute (TERI).

Published in July, the study identified about 47.5 million hectares, or almost 30% of India's more than 160 million hectare of arable agricultural land, as suitable for agrivoltaics.



Pralhad Joshi

The approach combines agricultural activity with solar photovoltaic power generation on the same land. The government is working on a dedicated policy framework for the sector with agrivoltaics potentially being incorporated into next phase of the Pradhan Mantri Kisan Urja Suraksha evam Utthaan Mahabhiyan (PM-KUSUM).

In his address, Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan stressed on the need to address land-use concerns and assess feasibility of projects across different regions.

Cost competitiveness

Mr. Joshi said agrivoltaic installations, which typically need elevated solar panel structures to facilitate farming underneath, could cost 25-30% more than conventional ground-mounted solar projects.

He stressed on the need to bridge the cost differential to make the model commercially viable.

"The average cost of electricity supply was about ₹7/unit in [fiscal] 2025-26. While some of the major agrivoltaics assessment indicate potential generation of ₹3.20-₹3.30/unit whereas ground mounted costs ₹2.5 to 2.6/unit. This difference has to be matched," he said.

Navratri auto retail sales rose 27%: FADA

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

About 11.23 lakh automobiles were retailed in ten days of Navratri this year (Navratri'26), up 27% over Navratri'24 – the last comparable festive period, as per Federation of Automobile Dealers Association's (FADA) provisional data.

Passenger vehicles retail sales rose by over 10% and that of two-wheelers by more than 32%.

But there was a 6.52% dip compared with Navratri'25. According to FADA the figures were not comparable as last year's Navratri ran for 11 days against 10 and coincided with GST 2.0 roll-out, which pulled a wave of pent-up demand.



Two wheeler retail sales rose by more than 32%.

EV sales surge

As per FADA data, EV retail sales grew 26.78% and now account for almost 10.5% of festive sales, up from about 7.7% a year ago, showing Indian EV shift had turned self-sustaining.

"Navratri'26 tells a fundamentally healthy story," said Sai Giridhar, president of FADA.

"As we enter the Dhanteras-to-Diwali wave, we stay cautiously optimistic: affordability is strong, aspiration is rising and auto retail continues to mirror the enduring momentum of the India growth story."

NVIDIA unveils 14-day AI data centre deployment

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI

NVIDIA unveiled a factory-built modular system for AI data centres, aiming to cut deployment time from several months to as little as 14 days as computing capacity demand surges.

DSX POD integrates computing racks, networking, cabling, power distribution and cooling into factory-tested units shipped in transportable containers. Deliveries are scheduled to begin worldwide in early 2027.

"An AI factory creates value when it starts producing tokens, not when construction is complete," NVIDIA founder and CEO Jensen Huang said at the company's GTC event in Berlin on Wednesday.

Tokens are units of text or other data processed and generated by AI models. For data centre operators, faster deployment means an earlier start to commercial operations and revenue generation.



Huang speaks during keynote at the NVIDIA GTC conference.

Risks of delays

Mr. Huang highlighted the financial implications of delays, saying a data centre expected to generate $40 billion in annual revenue would lose the equivalent of $10 billion if delayed by three months. The figures were illustrative estimates presented by him not losses at a specific facility.

The DSX POD approach shifts much of the installation, integration and testing work from customer sites to factories, reducing the complexity of on-site deployment.

Built around NVIDIA's Vera Rubin computing platform, the reference design includes seven liquid-cooled computing racks connected by 17 kilometres of Spectrum-X networking cables. The systems are fully cabled, integrated and tested before being shipped to customers.

"Once site utilities are ready, estimated on-site deployment goes to days," he said. The 14-day timeline is conditional on site utilities being ready viz. clients must finish preparation and infrastructure work prior to deployment.

Zydus' hormone therapy patch copy gets U.S. FDA nod

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Zydus Lifesciences secured final approval from the U.S. Food and Drug Administration (FDA) for its abbreviated new drug application for Estradiol and Levonorgestrel Transdermal System, 0.045 mg/0.015 mg per day.

Bayer's Climara Pro Transdermal System 0.045 mg/0.015 mg/day is the reference listed drug for the product. Estradiol and Levonorgestrel Transdermal System, primarily used to treat moderate to severe symptoms of menopause, had annual sales of about $45.7 million in the U.S., Zydus said citing IQVIA MAT Aug-2026 numbers.

The ANDA has been designated by the U.S. FDA as a competitive generic therapy. The product is eligible for the 180-day exclusivity period available to some first approved applicants under CGT pathway, subject to the provisions of the U.S. Federal Food, Drug and Cosmetic Act.

Dr. Reddy's secures DCGI approval for use of Zytorvi in esophageal cancer

N. Ravi Kumar
HYDERABAD

Dr. Reddy's Laboratories has received Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) approval for the use of Zytorvi (toripalimab) in the treatment of unresectable advanced, recurrent or metastatic esophageal squamous cell carcinoma (ESCC).

The approval from the body under the Drugs Controller General of India (DCGI) for use, in combination with cisplatin and paclitaxel, as the first-line treatment of adult patients with ESCC, expands the use of Shanghai Junshi Biosciences' drug beyond the initially approved indication for nasopharyngeal carcinoma (NPC).

In 2023, Dr. Reddy's entered into a licensing and commercialisation agreement with Junshi for toripalimab across 21 countries. The Hyderabad-headquartered generic drugmaker launched Zytorvi in November 2024 for recurrent or metastatic nasopharyngeal carcinoma, making India the third country in the world, after China and the U.S., to receive access to the medicine.

Globally, Toripalimab is approved by regulatory authorities, including U.S. Food and Drug Administration (U.S. FDA), European Medicines Agency (EMA) and the UK Medicines and Healthcare products Regulatory Agency (MHRA).

Fourth leading cause

In 2024, esophageal cancer was the fourth leading cause of cancer-related death in India, accounting for approximately 8.1% of all cancer deaths. ESCC, the predominant subtype, accounts for approximately 80% of all esophageal cancer cases in India. Through Zytorvi, the aim is to expand access to first-line immunotherapy for appropriate patients with advanced ESCC in India, Dr. Reddy's Laboratories said on Wednesday,.

On the latest approval, Dr. Reddy's CEO, Global Generics M.V. Ramana, said it was an important step in extending the reach of immunotherapy to patients with advanced ESCC. "As we continue to build our oncology portfolio, the focus remains on bringing meaningful advances and expanding access to innovative treatment options," he said.

'India AI startups can add up to $100 bn to m-cap in five years'

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

Private investments in Indian artificial intelligence (AI) startups are growing rapidly, and the eventual listing of such entities could add up to $100 billion to the country's market capitalisation over the next two to five years, a foreign brokerage said.

Private equity (PE) investment in Indian AI startups tripled in 2025 to $5 billion from $1.6 billion in 2024, Goldman Sachs said.

It said 84 "Private AI Contenders" are now valued at about $55 billion.

"We estimate about $50-$100 billion in incremental market cap could be added to India's listed AI complex from prospective IPOs over the next 2-5 years, assuming 25-50% of ~70 mid-to-late stage Private AI Contenders list at a weighted average 4x valuation step-up," the report said.

It also said India recorded the fourth-largest number of newly-funded AI companies worldwide.

Bond selloff revives debate about euro zone banks' 'doom loop'



Better prepared: A sculpture of Euro symbol in front of the European Parliament in Brussels, Belgium. REUTERS

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
MILAN/FRANKFURT

Soaring euro zone government borrowing costs are reviving fears of a replay of the debt crisis that 15 years ago rocked the bloc. Panic not, say analysts and investors: banks are better prepared.

Shaky public finances in the past created a so-called doom loop. Losses on holdings of government debt hit lenders, in some instances forcing state-backed bailouts and a further drain on budgets.

Funding costs to rise

Funding costs will rise and market perceptions will matter, say analysts, as banks remain exposed to their countries' fiscal fortunes. But capital buffers and tighter supervision should help banks weather the turmoil, according to investors, analysts and data collated by *Reuters*.

"There is a limit to which you can insulate yourself from the domestic credit," said Simon Ainsworth, a senior banking analyst at Moody's Ratings. "Banks come from a better starting point but they are not immune."

Revamped banking supervision

Since the 2010 crisis, the bloc has revamped banking supervision and armed the European Central Bank (ECB) with tools to intervene, while banks have improved their defences, helped by years of record profits. Yet sovereign concerns contributed to a 10% drop in European bank stocks over the past six weeks – five times the wider market's fall – a decline that follows a prolonged rally to 16-year highs. For France's top three lenders the fall has been 17% over the same period. With its debt costs hitting 25-year highs amid a large deficit, social unrest and a 2027 Presidential election where far-right and far-left candidates lead opinion polls, the eurozone's second-largest economy is in the eye of the storm.

Safe assets

Banks are allowed to treat government bonds as risk-free assets on their books. They count towards regulatory liquidity requirements and are used as collateral to borrow from central banks and other lenders.

Euro zone banks' net sovereign bond holdings have doubled since the crisis, reaching €4.3 trillion ($4.8 trillion) at the end of June, a *Reuters* analysis of European Banking Authority data showed. However, banks' capital buffers have risen even more, lowering the ratio of sovereign holdings to capital lenders keep to cover potential losses below 2.5 from 2.7 in 2013.

The lower the ratio the greater the banks' ability to sustain the hit from falling sovereign bond prices.

Both Axiom Alternative Investments Chief Investment Officer David Benamou and WisdomTree equity strategist Aneeka Gupta calculated that exposure to domestic debt for large French banks stand at roughly 15% to 30% of their best-quality capital. That compares with more than 100% for banks in Italy in 2011-12, the country at the forefront of the crisis then, Ms. Gupta said. Still, falling government bond prices – which move inversely to yields – can saddle banks with losses if lenders need to align the book value of bonds to market prices, or sell them to raise cash. Proposals to strip government bonds of risk-free status or impose concentration limits have so far failed. But the EU Commission has included a further diversification of sovereign bond portfolios among steps needed to boost the banking sector, and will present its proposals in early 2027.

Holding to matuity

Even without formal rules, the ECB has prodded euro zone banks to reduce exposure to their home country's debt. Domestic government bond holdings accounted for 41% of the total in mid-2026, the *Reuters* analysis of the EBA data showed, compared with more than 50% in 2013.

Also, banks tripled to 60% the proportion of bonds they value at cost – an accounting rule that enables lenders not to record losses when market prices fall. By classifying bonds as financial assets "held to maturity," banks can avoid booking capital-depleting losses, unless they are forced to sell, a risk which Moody's Ainsworth said shrunk as lenders rely less today on short-term funding.

Blurs into background: How Hermes Birkin bag is losing its scarcity appeal

Birkin bags used to sell at over double the retail price tags on resale platforms; demand was driven by scarcity; now the bags are more available for resale; prices of Birkin bags on resale platforms have been falling since pandemic peaks; UBS says Birkin , Kelly listings are 6-7 times pre-Covid level

FOCUS

Reuters
PARIS/LONDON



Waning value: A Hermes logo on a rare pre-owned Birkin bag. REUTERS

London-based Cai Baochun used to make a hefty profit reselling Hermes' famed Birkin bags for more than double the $10,000 retail price. Now, he has stopped stockpiling them as second-hand prices fall.

"I don't want to lose money," said Cai, who started selling the bags on online platforms such as Vestiaire Collective and on social media in 2020 and rode a pandemic-era luxury spending boom.

The resale value of unworn Birkins sold as second-hand online has dropped by more than $6,000 from its 2022 peak, he said. The decline reflects a broader shift in the market for one of luxury's most exclusive products whose appeal and success have been driven by scarcity.

Increasing supply of Birkin bags in the second-hand market is depressing resale premiums, according to resellers, industry consultants and analysts interviewed by *Reuters,* raising questions about a strategy that helped propel Hermes to become one of the world's most profitable luxury companies.

Named after the late British-French actor Jane Birkin, the handbag has been central to Hermes' performance. Between 2015 and 2025, group annual sales tripled to €16 billion ($18 billion) while its market value surged. Last year, Hermes posted an operating margin of 41%, above that of rivals including Chanel, Kering-owned Gucci and LVMH's leather and fashion division, which includes Louis Vuitton and Dior.

> For more than a decade, limited supply and strong demand allowed Birkins to command hefty resale premiums, benefiting both Hermes and resellers

Under pressure

All of that was underpinned by an aura of exclusivity.

Six resellers who source bags directly from Hermes shoppers said access to a Birkin is generally linked to spending on Hermes scarves, clothes and shoes, although the exact policy differs between regions and stores. Two estimated customers typically spend $10,000 to $20,000 before being offered the Birkin or the Kelly, the brand's other popular bag. Hermes, which says a Birkin takes 15 hours to craft, does not disclose its selling policies or how many bags it makes. It declined to comment for this story.

Of the nine Birkin resellers *Reuters* interviewed in the U.S., Europe and Asia, six said resale prices had fallen over the past year as more handbags became available, while five reported softer demand.

Antoinette Hunter, who founded luxury handbag reseller Lilac Blue in 2007, said when she got the first request for a Birkin, few people knew the bag. She eventually sourced one from a member of Japan's royal family.

Acquiring Birkins is no longer a challenge, Hunter said, but it's harder to make money from resales. She said the price for an unworn black Birkin 25 bag, one of the most sought-after models, has fallen by around £4,000 ($5,336) since 2022, to around £24,000. Cai, who sells via Vestiaire Collective and Instagram, says his price for the bag is around £20,000.

Hermes sells the same model for £9,390 in Britain, a Hermes sales assistant in London said.

Although Hunter still sees plenty of demand for Hermès bags, particularly the most high-end ones, she said the decline in resale prices might dissuade some from buying directly from Hermes.

"If Hermes continues to raise the prices, and the prices on the resale market continue to drop, that margin gets squeezed, and perhaps it will become less appealing," she said.

Brokerage Bernstein, which tracks individual auction results, said in a September note the resale price on Birkin 25 bags averaged about 1.7 times the retail tag in the third quarter, down from about 2.6 times at their 2022 peak.

Under scrutiny

Hermes' leather goods division, which includes other handbag models, generates 44% of annual group revenue. For more than a decade, limited supply and strong demand allowed Birkins to command hefty resale premiums, benefiting both Hermes and resellers as the prospects of making a profit via the secondary market encouraged Hermes clients to buy more from the brand.

"It was a win-win," said Sarah Davis, founder of California-based Fashionphile. The company said its Birkin listings have grown 32-fold in 15 years. The company's website currently lists 212 Birkins on sale.

Hermes has gradually expanded the production of its handcrafted items, opening one workshop per year on average. Meanwhile, the rise of resale platforms such as Vestiaire Collective and The RealReal, alongside vintage boutiques with online shops and social media channels, has made it easier than ever to resell.

The bags and other Hermes items remain highly sought after, resellers said, but the brand is showing some strain.

Hermes' shares have lost nearly 40% of their market value this year, making the brand one of the worst performers among listed luxury companies. Earlier this month, UBS analysts downgraded Hermes shares to "sell", saying that growing secondary-market supply of Birkins and Kellys could weaken the brand's scarcity-driven business model. "We believe the nature of the business is changing," they said in a note, estimating the number of the handbags listed for sale worldwide is now six to seven times higher than before the pandemic.

ITLA can hold key to better transport economics

Santosh V. Perumal



Right people: True independence calls for professionally selected CEO/Chairperson. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

The newly-established Integrated Transport & Logistics Authority (ITLA) comes at a time when India's infrastructure is fast integrating into a multimodal framework, even as doubts linger whether the "Apex" body strengthens GatiShakti or duplicate it?

The ITLA, a special purpose vehicle (SPV) under the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) of the Ministry of Commerce and Industry, seeks to address the lack of synchronisation among various transport infrastructure modes as PM's GatiShakti goes into full steam.

Outlining the roles and responsibilities, the press statement's first point was that ITLA would function as an "apex" institution. But naming so does not automatically make it one.

It has rather been designed as an expert arm of DPIIT than as an institution above departmental interests. The biggest limitation is its ability to improve outcomes will depend on how much influence it can exercise over Ministries and implementing agencies.

Its SPV structure may be useful for operational independence. But if the final word always rests with the concerned Ministry, ITLA's "Apex" status becomes largely advisory.

True [reasonable] independence would call for at least a professionally selected, fixed-tenure CEO/Chairperson, instead of a deputation-driven bureaucracy; guaranteed access to transport data and an independent budget, subject to Parliamentary and statutory oversight; and a mechanism for resolving any discord between and among stakeholders.

PM GatiShakti already has a Network Planning Group (NPG) which examines major Central infrastructure projects for multimodality, last-mile connectivity and synchronisation.

At the end of August 2026, a total of 396 projects at an estimated cost of ₹18.66 lakh crore had been evaluated through the NPG mechanism; 256 had been sanctioned and 198 were under implementation, illustrating the scale of the existing planning framework. The ITLA could complement this by examining the wider transport economics of projects.

For instance, before giving approval to a new highway connecting an industrial cluster to a port, ITLA has to review it multi-directionally – whether to improve an existing railway line, develop a multimodal logistics park or strengthen the coastal shipping – to offer a more cost-effective solution.

The proposed ITLA may encounter institutional resistance because Ministries may be reluctant to alter their investment priorities or accept recommendations that conflict with their sector-specific plans.

In the federal structure, State governments may have different priorities, particularly where projects involve land acquisition, connectivity or shared funding. Mostly so, when 'double engine' governance structures are not there.

Railways, road transport, port operators, state governments and urban transport agencies come with their own mandates, priorities and rigid administrative structures; thus making the coordination process a tedious process.

Many infrastructure projects face inordinate delays on rehabilitation needs, environmental approvals and legal disputes, compounding woes in the sector which otherwise has long gestation period. These problems cannot be resolved through technical appraisal or data integration alone.

Divergence in reporting standards, incomplete records, inconsistent definitions and delays in data sharing could affect the reliability of ITLA's analysis.

Finer details regarding the responsibilities vis-à-vis NPG and Ministries are yet to emerge, but efforts should be made to establish a single appraisal and data-sharing architecture, and define how inter-agency conflicts will be resolved. Without these guardrails or/and political backing, an authority conceived to dismantle institutional silos could end up creating another, struggling to secure compliance with its recommendations.

New direction

Nevertheless, ITLA is an attempt to give PM GatiShakti a new institutional direction as coordinating infrastructure development and optimising economics of the entire transport network form the bedrock of multimodal network.

The proposed ITLA is expected to steer the digital infrastructure-planning framework into better investment decisions, multimodal connectivity and lower logistics costs.

According to the National Council for Applied Economic Research, India's logistics cost was estimated at 7.97% of GDP in 2023-24, hence a modest gain in the efficiency of freight movement can release substantial economic value.

ITLA cannot reduce freight costs but can help eliminate infrastructure gaps, improve modal integration and cut freight delays while the potential benefits could extend across farmland, manufacturing, exports and domestic trade. PM GatiShakti's geospatial platform allows planners to examine infrastructure assets, economic centres and connectivity gaps, while ITLA's proposed National Transport Data Repository (NTDR) could add another dimension by integrating transport and logistics data from FASTag, GSTN e-way bills, Vahan, GPS-based systems and urban traffic management systems.

This would enable freight-flow and origin-destination analysis.

Breaking the Ministry-silo framework, the ITLA will prepare a National Transport Master Plan with a horizon of at least 10 years, wherein transport investments would increasingly be evaluated not merely by the asset they create, but by how the asset fits into the national freight and passenger network.

Logistics dividend

Having made progress through PM GatiShakti and the National Logistics Policy, including digital integration through the Unified Logistics Interface Platform; it is now time for ITLA to add an institutional layer for long-term physical infrastructure planning.

The proposed NTDR could allow the government to analyse freight flows and origin-destination patterns. Logistics firms, manufacturers and exporters are expected to be major beneficiaries on account of fewer bottlenecks, better modal choices, shorter transit times, improved asset utilisation and greater predictability.

More freight could shift to economically viable alternatives such as rail, coastal shipping and inland waterways, reducing excessive reliance on road transport.

Ensuring a wider economic multiplier, a unified command centre could lower logistics costs as well as improve the competitiveness of Indian manufacturing, agriculture and exports.

They make geographically distant production centres more commercially viable, strengthen the government's objective of creating integrated national supply chains.

Public capital use

ITLA has been entrusted with the responsibility for the technical appraisal of Central transport infrastructure projects costing ₹500 crore or more, while financial appraisal will remain with existing mechanisms. ITLA will also monitor the implementation and conduct post-project impact assessments.

International arena

There is no clear precedent among major economies for India's new model, even as the strongest integrated systems tend to give the coordinating institution either statutory powers, control over infrastructure/investment, or a clearly defined system-lead role.

India's ITLA is different as it is an SPV under DPIIT, with a powerful planning and appraisal mandate but without ownership of the major transport assets.

Economic gains

The combined effect of better project selection – coordinated construction and more efficient use of existing infrastructure – could vastly translate into higher economic gains.

Potential outcomes are there, but not guaranteed benefits – the extent to which businesses and consumers gain will depend on implementation, competition and the extent to which efficiency improvements translate into lower costs.

ATHENS

Greek students, teachers take to streets over education shortages



AP

Thousands of students and teachers took to the streets across Greece on Wednesday, demanding higher funding for education and better facilities, echoing protesters in other European countries. "From Greece to France, we want public, free education," protesters chanted as they gathered outside Parliament. REUTERS

MELBOURNE

Australia lawmaker struck by a car in 'targeted' attack loses both legs



REUTERS

Australian lawmaker Helen Haines has had both legs removed, her husband told journalists on Wednesday, after what police called a "targeted" attack. Ms. Haines is in a stable condition after being struck by a car on Monday in the town of Wangaratta. The suspect, Brendan Nugent, could face up to 10 years in prison, police said. AFP

ABUJA

Nigeria reports Ebola case, fourth African nation affected by outbreak



REUTERS

Nigeria reported its first Ebola case in more than a decade on Tuesday, becoming the fourth African country to be affected by the outbreak, first declared in Democratic Republic of Congo in May. The disease has killed 4,646 people so far. Cases have also been reported in Uganda and Kenya. REUTERS

RAMALLAH

Israel detains U.S. congressional candidate in occupied West Bank



AP

Israeli forces detained U.S. Democratic congressional candidate Brad Lander, along with a group of activists supporting Palestinians harvesting olives in the occupied West Bank on Wednesday. He posted on X that he was released given his prominence, adding that "Palestinians face far worse consequences every day". AFP

Putin agrees to resume three-way peace talks with Ukraine and U.S.

Discussions could start on or after November 10; Moscow frees retired U.S. teacher in goodwill gesture during Witkoff meet; Putin offers Trump his help to get a deal with Tehran; Zelenskyy calls for freezing of conflict with Russia as first step to talks

Reuters
ST PETERSBURG

Russian President Vladimir Putin has agreed to resume U.S.-mediated peace talks with Ukraine as soon as next month, the Kremlin said on Wednesday, after Mr. Putin met U.S. envoy Steve Witkoff in Washington's latest push to stop Europe's bloodiest conflict since the Second World War.

Mr. Putin held over three hours of talks with Mr. Witkoff in Saint Petersburg, a day after what the U.S. official called a "productive" meeting with Ukraine's Volodymyr Zelenskyy in Norway.



Russian President Vladimir Putin meets U.S. special envoy Steve Witkoff in Saint Petersburg, Russia, on Wednesday. REUTERS

The negotiations began with a goodwill gesture from Russia - the release of Stephen Hubbard, a retired U.S. school teacher held in Russia since 2022.

Wednesday's encounter unfolded amid concerns in Kyiv and among its allies that the U.S. is backing away from Ukraine.

Mr. Zelenskyy said freezing the conflict in Ukraine was the "minimum" required from Russia to bring about an end to the war.

"Right now, we have to freeze, and I think this is (the) real way to end this war," he told Fox News on Wednesday.

The Kremlin said the new three-way peace talks, which would beat a technical level, could take place in Abu Dhabi and would be focused on how to guarantee the security of Ukraine and Russia once the war ended. They could begin sometime on or after November 10, it said.

Mr. Putin also used the talks to offer to help Mr. Trump deal with Iran, saying Russia had a decades-long relationship with Tehran which it has repeatedly offered to leverage to address U.S. concerns about Iran's nuclear programme. Mr. Putin told Mr. Witkoff it was possible to get a deal with Tehran, the Kremlin said.

Russian Deputy Prime Minister Alexander Novak said Moscow will dispatch its first diesel tanker for the U.S. on Thursday, following a deal with Mr. Trump earlier this month.

Four killed in Ukraine

Meanwhile, Kyiv said on Wednesday Russian strikes killed at least four people – including two in the capital and an elderly couple in Kharkiv region.

Russian authorities in the Lugansk region, said a Ukrainian drone strike killed two people.

Macron slams foreign leaders for exploiting France unrest

Associated Press
PARIS



French President Emmanuel Macron meets Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed Bin Salman during a visit to Riyadh on Wednesday. AFP

French President Emmanuel Macron said on Wednesday that foreign leaders – including those "on the other side of the Atlantic" – were seeking to exploit France's tense social climate for political gain following a weekend of street violence and looting.

Protests over soaring living costs have led to widespread rioting and looting that have drawn worldwide attention. U.S. President Donald Trump has used the violence to rally his supporters, making unsubstantiated claims that Muslim migrants are responsible for the unrest.

Mr. Macron, speaking during a visit to Qatar, implied that Mr. Trump, and possibly Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, who is also fighting an election campaign, made "stupid comments" on the unrest for political gain, though he did not name either leader.

Mr. Macron said "there has been foreign manipulation of information in the aftermath" of the looting in Paris and other French cities last weekend. "And that has led to comments that are as unacceptable as they are stupid, from many people, including foreign leaders," he said.

Yellow vests

Further protests are planned for Thursday and Saturday following calls from student unions and groups within the "yellow vest" movement, whose demonstrations over fuel prices shook France in 2018 and 2019.

Toppling Iran govt. only way to end threat, says Netanyahu

Agence France-Presse
DIMONA

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said on Wednesday that the only way to remove the threat posed by Iran was to topple its government.

"Iran wanted to destroy us; we stopped them. They wanted to produce nuclear bombs; we stopped them... Yet they persist," he said during an election rally in the southern town of Dimona. "Therefore, there is only one way to end this: by toppling this regime."

"This is the directive I have issued to the Israel Defense Forces, to the Mossad, and to all our security branches," he added.

The sabre-rattling came as the premier headed into the last week of a tight race for re-election.



Benjamin Netanyahu

Mr. Netanyahu had instructed the Israeli military to plan for resumed strikes against Iran earlier this month, according to sources cited by *the Financial Times* on Wednesday, but U.S. President Donald Trump reportedly objected to the idea.

The U.S. leader has publicly said that he does not intend to restart the war, which Washington started in February alongside Israel, before the U.S. mid-term elections early next month.

Trump endorsement

This week, Mr. Netanyahu thanked Mr. Trump in a video for his endorsement in the Israeli election, and said that the two leaders have "a job to finish" in Iran.

Israeli Defence Minister Israel Katz also warned against a potential threat from Iran.

Speaking at an officers' graduation ceremony on Wednesday, he said that "the Iranian regime is at its weakest point ever, and we recognise that this weakness could lead it to take the most extreme steps".

"If Iran attacks Israel, Iran will burn!" he said.

Mr. Katz also warned against unspecified attempts by Israel's enemies to disrupt the upcoming vote.

Lost world



War frame: Tents sheltering people displaced by war stand amid the destroyed buildings in the Jabalia camp for Palestinian refugees in the northern Gaza Strip. Israel's military offensive has displaced nearly all the population of Gaza, says its Health Ministry. AFP

U.K. MPs back Northern Ireland Troubles Bill

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

British MPs have approved a controversial government Bill to tackle the legacy of the Northern Ireland conflict, despite warnings from former military chiefs that it could expose veterans to prosecution.

The Northern Ireland Troubles Bill passed the vote in the House of Commons on Tuesday. It will now go to the Upper House.

Decades of sectarian violence over British rule in Northern Ireland led to over 3,500 deaths until a peace deal was signed in 1998. How to deal with the conflict's legacy remains a thorny issue for pro-Irish nationalists and unionists, who support the region remaining part of the U.K.

Musk ordered cuts to Starshield services in Ukraine: report

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

Elon Musk ordered a reduction in Starshield services for Ukraine, the *Wall Street Journal* reported on Tuesday, after the tech billionaire said any limits on the SpaceX-operated communications system would ultimately have come from the U.S. President.

Mr. Musk capped the speed at which Ukrainian equipment could connect to the system, making some of Kyiv's drones useless, the *Journal* reported.

Kyiv has accused Washington of deliberately slowing speeds at which Starshield can be used effectively – a charge denied by Donald Trump.

Mr. Musk had previously said that "any limits on speed or usage" of Starshield were "decided by the U.S. military and POTUS," referring to Mr. Trump. On Tuesday, Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth said that the Pentagon had not directed any changes to Starshield, saying: "We haven't pulled anything back."

Houthis hit Saudi positions in Yemen; coalition intercepts drones in Medina

Agence France-Presse
ADEN

Yemen's Houthis said they attacked a Saudi position in Aden on Wednesday in the third attack in a week on the seat of power of Yemen's Riyadh-backed government while the Saudi-led coalition fighting the Iran-aligned group said it had intercepted six drones launched towards the kingdom, including in the Medina region.

Sources in Aden said the Houthi attack targeted a site near Al Rayyan airport that belonged to the Saudi-led coalition.



Saudi-backed Yemeni fighters in battle against Iran-backed Houthis in Taiz on Wednesday.

"Our armed forces were able to target the Saudi enemy's operations room in the Badr camp in Aden with a ballistic missile," Houthi military spokesman Yahya Saree said. The Houthis later also targeted a military base at an airport in Al Mukalla, military officials said.

Meanwhile, the Saudi-led military coalition said on Wednesday it intercepted six drones.

"Four drones have been intercepted and destroyed," coalition spokesman Turki al-Malki posted on X, adding that the interceptions took place in Eastern province, as well as Medina, home to one of Islam's holiest cities.

Mr. Al-Malki later said another drone had been intercepted, also in the Eastern province. On Wednesday evening, the coalition announced it had intercepted a sixth drone.

The Houthis earlier denied having targeted the kingdom, with spokesman Saree saying their forces had not carried out any "deep" operations.

Limited traffic at Riyadh

A limited number of Saudi airlines took off and landed at Riyadh's King Khalid International Airport on Wednesday.

Saudia and FlyNas were operating flights, according to flight-tracking data published by FlightAware.

Turkiye, Pakistan, Indonesia, and Qatar sign defence accord

Reuters
ANKARA

Turkiye, Qatar, Pakistan, and Indonesia signed an agreement on Wednesday to boost defence cooperation and strengthen defensive capabilities, the Turkish Defence Ministry said.

In a statement, the Ministry said the countries signed the "Badr Memorandum of Understanding" in Doha as a sign of their desire to further deepen cooperation and develop partnerships.

"The agreement holds substantial economic importance," it said. "By leveraging the unique military production capabilities of each country, the initiative will facilitate cooperation and integration, enhance defence industrial capacities, and enable the fulfilment of the needs of allied nations," it added.

Turkey, which has NATO's second-largest army and a robust defence industry, has been helping Gulf nations, including Qatar, where it has a military base, bolster their defences amid the Iran war.



People hold a doll dressed as a Soviet soldier during the Second World War, at the Native Toy contest in Moscow. AP

Toy contest in Russia blends play and patriotism

Reuters
MOSCOW

At Russia's state-backed toy competition, a plush cat dressed as a tank driver rubbed shoulders with characters from Slavic fairy tales, a model of a nuclear-powered icebreaker, and blue-eyed dolls in Russian army uniforms from the Second World War.

Launched in 2024, the annual "Native Toy" contest seeks to promote domestically produced toys that reflect Russian culture, history, and its spiritual and moral values, according to organisers. Eighty finalists displayed their creations on Monday at a vast exhibition centre in Moscow, where children carefully painted folk designs on wooden toys, played with a Lego-like replica of a Soviet space rocket, and built traditional cottages from multi-coloured bricks.

"Here, particularly in education, there is now a strong focus on ensuring that children learn to love their country through play. This is very important: not through force, but through play," said Valeria Mikhaleva-Ustinskaya, president of the National Association of Preschool Educators.

The competition is part of a broader push by the authorities, since the start of full-scale fighting in Ukraine in 2022, to promote patriotism, Kremlin-approved versions of history, and what the state calls traditional values, among children.

Rights group Amnesty International has condemned elements of Russia's educational policies as state indoctrination.

The prominence of army-themed products is in step with the growing emphasis on military-patriotic education in Russian schools.

U.S. invokes rarely used 1994 torture law in revamped case against Maduro

Maduro and his wife pleaded not guilty last week to an expanded indictment accusing them of conspiring to torture political opponents, alongside existing drug trafficking charges; they are scheduled to go on trial in June 2027; the fresh charge could strengthen prosecutors' case, say legal experts

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
NEW YORK

Nicolas Maduro is one of just a handful of people to be charged in the U.S. with violating a federal law criminalising torture committed overseas, a *Reuters* review of court records found, as prosecutors seek to broaden their criminal case against the ousted Venezuelan President.

Mr. Maduro (63), and his wife Cilia Flores (70), pleaded not guilty last week to an expanded indictment accusing them of conspiring to torture political opponents to remain in power, in addition to the drug trafficking charges they already faced. They are scheduled to go on trial in June 2027.

Mr. Maduro and Ms. Flores, captured in January during a U.S. military raid in Caracas ordered by President Donald Trump, are just the seventh and eighth people *Reuters* identified who have been charged with violating a 1994 law criminalising acts of torture. The law defines torture as an act intended to inflict severe physical or mental pain or suffering on a person in custody.

Four people have been convicted under the statute, including members of paramilitary forces in Liberia and Gambia, the head of a Syrian prison under ousted President Bashar al-Assad, and a U.S. citizen who developed an illegal arms factory in Iraq.

The Maduro case marks the first time the United States has prosecuted a head of state for allegedly authorising the use of torture in their country, according to Michel Paradis, a partner at the Steptoe law firm.

"This really is a landmark case," said Mr. Paradis, who previously represented detainees at the Guantanamo Bay U.S. naval base.

The torture charges mark a substantial shift in the focus of the case against Mr. Maduro and Ms. Flores. While they remain accused of abusing their power to help drug traffickers and enrich themselves, the new charges mean that alleged human rights abuses during the political upheaval that often marked Mr. Maduro's 13 years in office will become central to the trial.



Legal battle: Captured Venezuelan President Nicolas Maduro arrives at the Downtown Manhattan Heliport, en route to a court appearance in New York City in January 2026. REUTERS

'Significant escalation'

The torture charge could strengthen the hand of prosecutors by allowing them to tell a more comprehensive story about how Mr. Maduro allegedly employed a wide range of criminal activity to stay in power, and by enabling them to call more sympathetic witnesses, legal experts said.

"The torture charge is really a significant escalation," said Artie McConnell, a former federal prosecutor focused on national security issues.

Lawyers for Mr. Maduro did not respond to requests for comment.

Mark Donnelly and Andres Sanchez, lawyers for Ms. Flores, said she is "completely innocent" of all charges. They said they would revise a motion they previously made to dismiss the indictment on the basis of sovereign immunity – protection from prosecution as the head of a sovereign country – to account for the new charges.

A spokesperson for the Manhattan U.S. Attorney's office, which brought the charges, declined to comment.

Sentencing provisions

The 1994 law was passed by Congress to make good on U.S. obligations under the United Nations Convention against Torture, signed during President Ronald Reagan's tenure.

Under the law, each torture count is punishable by up to 20 years in prison, or by a life sentence or the death penalty if the victim dies due to the torture. People convicted of multiple acts of torture can receive longer sentences. Those convicted under the statute so far have received prison sentences of 60 to 97 years.

Mr. Maduro and Ms. Flores are not eligible for the death penalty because they are charged with torture conspiracy, not with carrying out torture themselves.

U.S. prosecutors can bring torture charges only against defendants who are U.S. nationals or who are physically present in the United States. The charges against Mr. Maduro and Ms. Flores came after they were brought to New York following the raid in Caracas.

Many of the other defendants in U.S. torture cases had moved to or attempted to enter the United States after the alleged torture.

Mr. McConnell, a partner at law firm BakerHostetler, said the new indictment was more detailed than the previous one, citing the descriptions of alleged torture victims and incidents.

In one 2018 incident described in the indictment, prosecutors said that Venezuelan military officers hit a detainee with a machete and sprayed him with a chemical irritant while interrogating him about the whereabouts of a Maduro political opponent.

Jurors could find testimony from alleged torture victims to be powerful, said Shane Stansbury, a former federal prosecutor in Manhattan.

Three of the alleged torture victims in the indictment are American citizens, and their testimony could resonate particularly strongly among the jurors, Mr. McConnell said.

A trial on the drug trafficking charges alone likely would have relied heavily on the testimony of cooperating witnesses, who may have played a role in the alleged crimes themselves. Defense lawyers often question cooperating witnesses sharply about their own criminal histories on cross-examination to try to undercut their credibility.

Cubans dig wells in search of water as U.S. energy blockade hits supply

Agence France-Presse
HAVANA

Kevin Martinez has come up with a creative new way to avoid shutting his restaurant when water runs low in Cuba, a common source of frustration for the business owner.

The U.S. energy blockade on the communist-run island has caused problems along the line of supply, so Mr. Martinez decided to drill downwards and find his own source.

His business is located in the Matanzas province, 100 kilometers east of Havana and one of the regions particularly affected by the shortages.

The issue affects nearly 29 per cent of Cuba's 9.4 million inhabitants, according to official figures, with the situation worsening significantly since January due to the U.S. energy blockade.



Water woes: A man fills water containers from a public supply point along a street in Havana, Cuba. AFP

The subsequent crisis has made prolonged blackouts the norm, which in turn reduces the water supply, as pumping depends primarily on electric turbines.

"On several occasions we had to close the establishment because we didn't have any water... and that's what brought us to the point of having to dig the well," Mr. Martinez said.

Water does not reach the homes of 2.7 million Cubans, Yunior Gonzalez, a senior official at the national water company, said. "Between 80 and 85 per cent of the water" supplied has to be pumped to get to these households, he said, adding that equipment breakdowns, leaks and drought have exacerbated the problem.

Water difficulties are forcing many Cubans to haul the precious resource for long distances, transporting it via wheelbarrows, bicycles, car trunks and even horse-drawn carts.

Municipalities in Havana have recorded several women-led protests over water shortages in recent months.

Living history



A rare milestone: The 117-year-old Qamile Marra holds a photograph from her youth at her home in Ferras, near Kucove, Albania. Born on August 19, 1909, according to official documents, she would be two days older than Britain's Ethel Caterham, recognised by Guinness World Records as the world's oldest living woman. Her age even surprised local authorities, who stopped her pension when she turned 100. AFP

As Serbia prepares to vote, students emerge as threat to Vucic's long rule

Reuters
BELGRADE

Aleksa Simic, a political science student at Belgrade University, did not hesitate when he learned that the collapse of a railway station canopy in the northern Serbian city of Novi Sad had killed 16 people in November 2024.

Demanding justice for the dead, and an end to the kind of corruption that many believed led to the station's shoddy construction, he and other students blockaded the political science faculty in protest. As Serbia mourned, sympathetic residents brought them homemade meals, mattresses and pillows. Many stopped by to discuss the students' demands.

"For the first time, I had a sense of belonging to a community. I realised that my voice mattered," Mr. Simic said.

Two years on, as Serbia prepares for elections on October 25, the student protest movement has ballooned to become one of the most powerful political forces in the country and poses the greatest threat yet to the rule of Aleksandar Vucic, who has dominated Serbian politics first as Prime Minister, then President, since 2014.

With protests raging in cities across Europe, fuelled by the high cost of living, a shortage of jobs and poor education standards, the Serbian students have shown what a force younger generations can be when they harness widespread discontent.

In interviews with *Reuters*, a dozen students and teachers described how a methodical countrywide door-knocking campaign, peaceful marches, a tightly controlled media message and a constant rotation of leaders to protect individuals from government smear campaigns have helped maintain momentum in Serbia.

Now, they have their own "Students Win" list of 250 candidates for Sunday's election, which includes university professors, actors, farmers and even a popular rapper.

The only poll published this month, by New Serbian Political Thought (NSPM) on October 20, showed the students' list of candidates edging ahead of Mr. Vucic's Serbian Progressive Party (SNS), with 44.5% of the vote against 42.7%, although betting odds favour Mr. Vucic.

The big question is how the students would govern, should they win on Sunday.



In solidarity: Supporters of the 'Student List - Students Win' gather in the village of Savino Selo in Serbia on October 11. REUTERS

Diplomatic tightrope

Mr. Vucic is a significant international figure, managing a delicate balancing act that seeks closer ties with China, a major investor, and Russia, Serbia's traditional ally and principal supplier of natural gas, while leaving the door open to joining the European Union even with the accession process stalled.

The students' list is headed by cardiologist Ilija Srdanovic, although they have said this does not mean he would become Prime Minister if they win.

Some political analysts wonder how the country would fare on the international stage with an unknown at the helm, while there are scant details about how the students will set about fulfilling their pledges to fight corruption, promote transparency, create greater media freedom and enact education reform at home.

Critics also point to their silence on joining the EU and relations with the former province of Kosovo. Pro-European opponents of Mr. Vucic's government criticise them for saying that they would not introduce sanctions on Russia.

"A (student-led) government would pursue broad reforms to tackle corruption, overhaul key public institutions and companies, and dismantle patronage networks," consultancy Teneo said in an analyst note on Tuesday. "However, strong bureaucratic resistance could generate short-term institutional instability."

Growing discontent

Mr. Vucic (56), stepped down as President in September to run again for Prime Minister in the snap election.

While he has overseen a period of strong economic growth and a fall in unemployment, critics blame him for democratic backsliding, the silencing of critics and the media, and hampering Serbia's EU accession by not undertaking necessary reforms. Police have beaten protesters and threatened people who voice opposition online, rights groups, activists and students told *Reuters*.

Simmering anger towards the government boiled over with the collapse of the station roof in Novi Sad. Mr. Vucic has sought to discredit the student movement, saying it is trying to destroy Serbia and accusing foreign agents from Croatia and Montenegro of financing it, but that has not dented their support.

Government representatives did not respond to a request for comment. Mr. Vucic and the authorities have repeatedly denied the allegations of corruption and violence. The students dismiss claims that they are being organised from abroad.

Ahead of Sunday's vote, student groups have undergone training on election fraud and say teams plan to be present at polling stations.

BLUNT TRUTH

It's not like Sooryavanshi can walk in right now: India captain Shreyas



X@BCCI

It's important that a talent like him [Vaibhav Sooryavanshi] should always be happy around the dressing room. He is very young and has more years to get opportunities. It's not like he can walk in right now, because our openers are scoring consistently, and they have won the World Cup — India skipper Shreyas Iyer.

VETERAN TOUCH

Bhuvneshwar brings in a lot of experience to the team: Shreyas



X@BCCI

India's T20I captain Shreyas Iyer said the team's bowling attack had been lacking experience in the recent past and Bhuvneshwar Kumar, *right in pic,* would help address this issue. "Bhuvi brings a lot of experience to the team. And we were lacking that, especially after the IPL. We had a lot of new bowlers," Shreyas said.

INAUGURAL EDITION

Barcelona to host Move Cup chess in January 2027



FILE PHOTO: SUDHAKARA JAIN

The inaugural edition of the Move Cup, organised by Betby, to be held in Barcelona from Jan. 19 and 20. The chess tournament carries a prize fund of €300,000 and it will be matched by the same amount for charity by the Move Foundation. The format will be rapid chess and Magnus Carlsen will headline the field of eight.

STELLAR SHOW

Haryana rallies past M.P., emerges senior men's National champion



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Haryana came from behind to beat Madhya Pradesh 2-1 in the Division-A final of the 16th Hockey India senior men's National championship in Jhansi on Wednesday. Navraj Singh (21st) and Joginder Singh (50th) found the target for Haryana after Mohammad Zaid Khan gave M.P. the lead in the 14th minute.

Jet-lagged Team India looks to soar on the mega Kiwi tour

Shreyas & Co. make the long journey after finishing the West Indies assignment at home on Saturday; the Men in Blue will be bolstered by Bhuvneshwar and Varun's presence; the teams will play five T20Is and five ODIs before the two-Test series

CRICKET

Press Trust of India
CHRISTCHURCH

Unbeaten in its last two T20I series here, India would rely heavily on its batting firepower to outwit New Zealand even though the relatively inexperienced tourists have got barely two days to rest, acclimatise and train for the five-match rubber beginning on Thursday. The Men in Blue's most recent T20I clash on New Zealand soil was in 2022 in Napier where the rain-interrupted match ended in a tie via the Duckworth-Lewis method.

The series, however, was claimed by India, which managed to win the only game that was not wrecked by inclement weather.

In the line-up of batters chosen for the upcoming assignment, only four have previously played T20Is in New Zealand. That includes skipper Shreyas Iyer, Ishan Kishan, Sanju Samson, and Shivam Dube.

Therefore, even though the likes of Abhishek Sharma, Tilak Varma and 15-year-old sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi are known marauders, the nippy and seaming conditions in this part of the world would need some adjustment.

For Shreyas, the challenge would be to prove himself in a challenging away assignment after his tenure began with back-to-back losses in Ireland and England. Mitchell Santner's New Zealand would be eager to make it as difficult as possible for Shreyas, who is coming here after India's second successive gold-winning run at the Asian Games and a drawn hard-fought home series against the West Indies.

India is also without two proven match-winners in injured all-rounder Hardik Pandya and pace spearhead Jasprit Bumrah, who will only play Tests in this tour. The return of veteran pacer Bhuvneshwar Kumar after nearly four years and fit-again mystery spinner Varun Chakaravarthy should solve part of the problem. The two countries are celebrating 100 years of sporting ties this year and the T20Is would be followed by a five-match ODI series and two Tests.

The teams (from):

New Zealand: Mitchell Santner (Capt.), Finn Allen, Michael Bracewell, Devon Conway, Jacob Duffy, Lockie Ferguson, Matt Henry, Bevon Jacobs, Kyle Jamieson, Adam Milne, Daryl Mitchell, Glenn Phillips, Tim Seifert, Blair Tickner, Josh Clarkson, and Nathan Smith.

India: Shreyas Iyer (Capt.), Tilak Varma (Vice-capt.), Abhishek Sharma, Sanju Samson, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Ishan Kishan, Axar Patel, Shivam Dube, Nitish Kumar, Naman Dhir, Prince Yadav, Mayank Yadav, Arshdeep Singh, Bhuvneshwar Kumar, Varun Chakaravarthy, and Kuldeep Yadav.

The battle against the Black Caps

India will be eager to extend its T20 dominance over New Zealand as the teams lock horns in a five-game series for the second time this year

INDIA IN NEW ZEALAND IN T20Is

Matches 12 | Won 7 | Lost 4 | Tied 1

India emerged victorious through a Super Over in two games in 2020

The third T20I in 2022, which was affected by rain, was tied via DLS method

SERIES-BY-SERIES IN NEW ZEALAND

Year	M	India	NZ	Tied
2009	2	**0**	2	0
2019	3	**1**	2	0
2020	5	**5**	0	0
2022*	2	**1**	0	1

**A match in 2022 was abandoned without a ball being bowled*

- The head-to-head record is 19-11 in favour of India (one match was tied)
- India **has not lost a T20I** in New Zealand since February 2019
- The Men in Blue have won each of the **last five series** against the Black Caps
- In India-New Zealand clashes in Kiwiland, the **200-run mark** has been breached only five times

1,158

Ishan Kishan is seven runs away from becoming the Indian batter with most T20I runs in a calendar year. Suryakumar Yadav currently holds the record with **1,164** (achieved in 2022)

- Among the Indian players selected for the series, **Kishan (372 runs in 12 innings)** and **Arshdeep Singh (17 wickets in 10 innings)** have the best stats against the Black Caps
- Mitchell Santner has **found the going tough against India**, losing eight of his 10 matches as captain. Meanwhile, Shreyas Iyer is yet to lead his team against New Zealand

THE SCHEDULE

- **Oct. 22** and **24** (Christchurch)
- **Oct. 27** (Wellington)
- **Oct. 30** (Auckland)
- **Nov. 1** (Hamilton)

All T20Is start at 12.30 p.m. IST

COMPILED BY
S. SHRIVATHSAN





Talking straight: Amritraj served up candid views about the modern game during his fireside chat with N. Ram at the *Sportstar* Hangout on Wednesday. JOHAN SATHYA DAS J

Tennis has seen a generational change, reckons Amritraj

Nihit Sachdeva
CHENNAI

When Vijay Amritraj retired from professional tennis in 1993 after a career lasting over two decades, the sport was in a completely different space.

Since then, the nature of the surfaces, the equipment, the playing styles, pay parity, player earnings and multiple other aspects have transformed in a significant way. But while these changes were taking place, former World No. 16 Amritraj was still very much involved in the sport in various capacities.

Hence, it wasn't a surprise that the 72-year-old, a Hall of Famer and a Padma Bhushan Awardee, shared his thoughts on the said subjects with absolute clarity during a fireside chat hosted by *Sportstar* at *The Hindu*'s headquarters here on Wednesday.

In a conversation with N. Ram, Director, *The Hindu Group*, Amritraj reflected on how the serve-and-volley style, a staple playing formula for his contemporaries, has vanished.

"The Wimbledon grass court is much slower like the French clay now. So, when you see the Centre Court on the last day, the baseline is completely chewed up but the middle of the court is pristine because they (the players) haven't been there yet," said Amritraj, the current president of the Tamil Nadu Tennis Association.

The factors

He mentioned factors such as the increase in the average height of the players, bouncier courts and the tennis balls used nowadays being "six times heavier" than when he played, forcing the players to use both hands to hit a backhand, as another example of how the sport has evolved.

On the issue of players in the current generation often getting injured, Amritraj blamed it on power replacing purity.

"The way they strike the ball today, I look at them and see why they get injured. The shoulder, elbow, the wrist, everything is in it by the time they strike the ball. When we used to strike the ball, it was a lot more graceful," said the Indian who won 15 Tour-level titles.

Amritraj, who served as the President of the ATP Player Council from 1989 to 1993, also shared his point of view on the frequent complaints surrounding the hectic calendars.

Packed schedule

"The packed schedule is supposedly for the Top 10 guys. They always have a choice. It's important to allow the rest of the tour to survive on the ATP 250s and 500s that we have, so that we give them a chance to play," he said.

The whole idea of home advantage has disappeared around the world: Stead

N. Sudarshan

Gary Stead knows a thing or two about beating India. The 54-year-old Kiwi was the coach when New Zealand overcame the subcontinental giant to win the ICC World Test Championship in 2021.

He was also at the helm when Tom Latham & Co. handed India a 3-0 drubbing at home in 2024, the latter's first Test series defeat in its own backyard since 2012.

As India begins an all-format tour of New Zealand from Thursday, Stead, who is now the head coach of Andhra, feels the tables could turn.

The two Tests India and New Zealand will play would be crucial for both teams' Test Championship hopes.

"[Earlier] when you played India, you'd have thought, 'Oh, we'll do a green track because they don't have good seamers'. Now they have real quality seamers, the same way we had quality spinners when we came here [to India]," said Stead during Andhra's Ranji Trophy opener against Karnataka last week.



Frank: Stead says the better batting team will prevail in the two-Test series. K.V.S. GIRI

"The whole idea of home advantage has disappeared a little bit around the world. I think everyone has shown competence to beat everyone else."

Stead opined that the better batting unit will prevail.

"The battle will come down to the two batting teams. Generally, the wickets have bounce and carry. The two Tests are at Hagley Oval [in Christchurch] and Wellington, traditionally two of the bouncier wickets in New Zealand. If India can nullify New Zealand's bowlers, I think it'll be a cracking series."

Amazing side

"India, obviously, is an amazing Test side, and we go to Australia after that. So there are six huge tests coming up. But if you want to be judged against the best, you've got to compete against the best."

The last time India went on an all-format tour was to South Africa (Dec 2023 - Jan 2024). Stead hoped that such sojourns would happen more often.

"Personally, I think the ICC should consider playing more multi-format type situations, rather than [teams] coming and going very quickly, and people forgetting about the series. Something like how the women do with their Ashes... and that could be something that takes off a little bit more".

KB Stars' thumping win dashes Railways' hopes

BASKETBALL

K. Keerthivasan
BENGALURU

Reigning National champion Indian Railways suffered another bruising outing, slumping to its second successive heavy defeat, this time at the hands of South Korea's KB Stars (81-42) in a Group-B match of the FIBA Women's Basketball League Asia at the Sree Kanteerava Indoor Stadium on Wednesday.

The defeat ended Railways' hopes of reaching the semifinals.

While Railways looked better organised and had a clearer gameplan than in its previous outing, poor shooting once again proved to be its Achilles' heel, with the team failing to translate its improved approach into points. Though its shooting improved marginally, Railways' struggles from the perimeter remained a major concern. It failed to convert any of its 19 attempts from beyond the arc, in stark contrast to KB Stars, which sank 16 three-pointers from 55 attempts.

Railways was found wanting on the defensive end as well, surrendering possession too easily and allowing KB Stars to capitalise on turnovers. The statistics told the story: Railways managed just two points off turnovers, while KB Stars scored 25. On the positive side, Railways outscored its opponent 34-22 in points in the paint.

For KB Stars, captain and forward Yunjeong Na led from the front with 18 points, while Manmeet Kaur was Railways' top-scorer with 17.



Leading the charge: Yunjeong was the top-scorer for KB Stars. K. MURALI KUMAR

The results:

Group-A: Cathay Life Tigers 85 (Penina Davidson 22, Chu Chu 14, Hui-Ju Liu 13, Yu-Lien Hsu 12, Yu Wen Hsiao 10) bt Akari Sparks 75 (Saicha Patricia Grant-Allen 21, Bre'Amber Shakira Scott 17, Kent Jane Pastrana 13, Stefanie Berberabe 11).

B: KB Stars 81 (Yunjeong Na 18, Yunha Song 12, Yebin Hoon 10) bt Indian Railways 42 (Manmeet Kaur 17).



Jansen. AFP

Jansen on fire as SA enforces follow-on

AUS IN SA

Agence France-Presse
GQEBERHA

Marco Jansen bowled South Africa to within sight of a series-levelling victory on the fourth day of the second Test at St George's Park on Wednesday.

Australia was 156 for four in its follow on innings after being shot out for 99 earlier in the day. It was still 170 runs short of making South Africa bat again.

Jansen took five for 33 as Australia crashed to its fourth-lowest total against South Africa.

The scores: South Africa 425/9 decl. vs. Australia 99 in 42.3 overs (Jansen 5/33) & 156/4 in 54 overs (Head 87 batting).

Chhattisgarh's follies hand Punjab a seven-wicket win

First Ayush Pandey and then Dharmendra Jadeja hold the fort, the former with a century, before their errors in judgement allows the host a way back in to the contest

RANJI TROPHY

Abhishek Saini
NEW CHANDIGARH

Chhattisgarh blundered in the crunch moments on Wednesday and sabotaged its own escape, handing Punjab a seven-wicket win in their Ranji Trophy second-round fixture at the New PCA Stadium in New Chandigarh.

Ayush Pandey (111, 252, 16x4, 2x6) was singlehandedly stalling Punjab's charge by picking on the spinners in the morning session.

Gurnoor Brar's bouncer sent back Amandeep Khare, who was struck on his left arm and had to retire hurt.

Harjas Tandon castled Vikalp Tiwari on one, but Rahul Pradhan channeled his on-side range to pick quick runs. He swept and paddle swept Harjas for boundaries before the off-spinner dragged a delivery shorter and quicker, forcing a leading edge to mid-on and ending the partnership on 57.

The sucker punch came one over later, minutes before Lunch, as Pandey threw away his work in wanting a hasty single. He tapped to substitute Ramandeep Singh at mid-on but was sent back from half-way down by his partner Ajay Mandal (45, 61, 7x4).



Fighting knock: Chhattisgarh's Ayush Pandey stonewalled Punjab before a hasty attempt at a single cost him his wicket. FILE PHOTO: EMMANUAL YOGINI

Chhattisgarh found second wind in Dharmendra Jadeja (47, 80b, 3x4, 2x6) and Mandal's partnership that lasted 21 overs and brought the side 84 runs. Jadeja did not digress from the go-to option of the day, sweeping abundantly for boundaries. The shot earned him two maximums over deep midwicket off Harpreet.

In an attempt to emulate the approach, Mandal made the error of not covering the line and was castled around his legs.

Khare returned despite an injured arm to hold one end. However, when Chhattisgarh needed Jadeja to assess his options, he was bowled on an mis-executed sweep off Harjas, leaving Punjab with an entire session to get 86 runs.

Jadeja and Mandal nabbed the openers within the opening four overs but it was hardly enough for a late twist.

Uday Saharan took the wheel with his unbeaten 40 and was once again joined by Salil Arora in steadying the ship and taking the team to its destination.

The scores: Punjab — 1st innings: 456.
Chhattisgarh — 1st innings: 206.
Chhattisgarh — 2nd innings: Ayush Pandey run out 111, Sanidhya Hurkat c Vihaan b Emanjot 25, Ashutosh Singh lbw b Emanjot 0, Sanjeet Desai b Harpreet 0, Amandeep Khare lbw b Emanjot 62, Vikalp Tiwari b Harjas 1, Rahul Pradhan c Emanjot b Harjas 35, Ajay Mandal b Harpreet 45, Dharmendra Jadeja b Harjas 47, Dev Aditya Singh c Vihaan b Gurnoor 0, Sandeep Warrier (not out) 1; Extras (b-4, nb-4): 8; Total (in 116.2 overs): 335.
Fall of wickets: 1-48, 2-48, 3-49, 4-176, 5-233, 6-233, 7-317, 8-318, 9-334.
Punjab bowling: Gurnoor 9-0-34-1, Harpreet 38-8-117-2, Harjas 29-7-92-3, Emanjot 23.2-8-45-3, Vihaan 4-0-15-0, Uday 5-3-3-0, Umesh 7-1-16-0, Shubman Gill 1-0-9-0.
Punjab — 2nd innings: Vihaan Malhotra lbw b Dharmendra 6, Harnoor Pannu c Sanjeet b Ajay 6, Uday Saharan (not out) 40, Prabhsimran Singh c Sanidhya b Dharmendra 24, Salil (not out) 10; Total (for three wkts. in 16.5 overs): 86.
Fall of wickets: 1-12, 2-14, 3-47.
Chhattisgarh bowling: Dharmendra 8.5-0-40-2, Ajay 6-0-31-1, Vikalp 2-0-15-0.

RANJI SCORES — ROUND 2, FOURTH AND FINAL DAY

Elite: Group A: At Puducherry: Pondicherry 177 & 98/1 drew with Madhya Pradesh 345.
Points: MP 3(6), Pondicherry 1(1).
Group B: At Vijayawada: Hyderabad 275 & 306/7 decl. bt Andhra 184 & 130 in 30.5 overs (Tanay Thyagarajann 6/35).
Hyderabad 6(13), Andhra 0(3).
At Bengaluru: Karnataka 342 & 243/7 decl. in 64.1 overs (K.V. Aneesh 79, K. Shrijith 52) drew with Saurashtra 349 & 137/2 in 42 overs (Chirag Jani 63 n.o.).
Saurashtra 3(6), Karnataka 1(2).
At New Chandigarh: Punjab 456 & 86/3 in 16.5 overs (Uday Saharan 40 n.o.) bt Chhattisgarh 206 & 335 in 116.2 overs (Aayush Pandey 111, Amandeep Khare 62, Ajay Mandal 45, Dharmendrasinh Jadeja 47). **Punjab 6(9), Chhattisgarh 0(1).**
Group C: At Pune: Jharkhand 169 & 344/8 in 136 overs (Shikhar Mohan 127, Utkarsh Singh 58, Virat Singh 41, Aditya Singh 51) drew with Maharashtra 527/5 decl. **Maharashtra 3(9), Jharkhand 1(4).**
At New Delhi: Delhi 648/6 decl. drew with Gujarat 479 in 174.1 overs (Manan Hingrajia 123, Jaymeet Patel 72, Chintan Gaja 82, Hrithik Shokeen 5/143) & 15/1 in eight overs.
Delhi 3(3), Gujarat 1(8).
At Thiruvananthapuram: Kerala 404 bt Odisha 225 & 143 in 58.3 overs (Gourav Choudhary 53, Jalaj Saxena 5/34).
Kerala 7(8), Odisha 0(0).
Group D: At Bilaspur: Himachal Pradesh 140 & 291 in 99.1 overs (Pukhraj Mann 50, Vaibhav Kalta 63, Mohit Avasthi 5/44) lost to Mumbai 528/8 decl.
Mumbai 7(14), HP 0(0).
At Jaipur: Rajasthan 497 drew with Railways 338 in 127 overs (Eshaan Goyal 64, Bhargav Merai 73, Ravi Singh 53, Toufik Mondal 53 n.o., Kukna Ajay Singh 4/106) & 176/2 in 46 overs (Eshaan Goyal 59 n.o., Mohammad Saif 103 n.o.).
Rajasthan 3(6), Railways 1(2).
Plate: At Shillong: Meghalaya 380 & 172 bt Manipur 277 & 272 in 75.2 overs (Ronald Longjam 43, Karnajit Yumnam 53, Pheiroijam Jotin 43, Rex Rajkumar 51).
Meghalaya 6, Manipur 0.
At Sovima: Mizoram 581/9 decl. drew with Nagaland 516 in 181 overs (Joshua Ozukum 48, Sedezhalie Rupero 113, Yugandhar Singh 98, Hokaito Zhimomi 71, Rongsen Jonathan 118 n.o.).
Mizoram 3, Nagaland 1.

India to open U-19 Women's T20 WC against WI

Press Trust of India
DUBAI

India will begin its ICC U19 women's T20 World Cup title defence against the West Indies in Kathmandu on January 22.

The ICC on Wednesday announced the schedule for tournament, which will be played in Bangladesh and Nepal from January 21 to February 6.

The third edition of the tournament will feature four groups of four teams each.

Two-time champion India is clubbed alongside co-host Nepal, West Indies and Ireland in Group A.

Co-host Bangladesh and UAE will play the tournament opener on January 21.

Groups: A: India, Ireland, West Indies and Nepal. **B:** South Africa, New Zealand, Pakistan and Samoa. **C:** Australia, Bangladesh, Nigeria and UAE. **D:** England, Sri Lanka, USA and Scotland.

FC Goa stays alive with win over Fortis of Bangladesh

AFC CHALLENGE LEAGUE

Agencies
HAWALLY (KUWAIT)

FC Goa held off Fortis FC of Bangladesh to clinch a 2-1 win in its second Group-C match of the AFC Challenge League 2026-27 here at the Mohammed Al Hamad Stadium in Hawally, Kuwait, on Tuesday.

The AIFF Super Cup champion, which lost its opener 1-2 to FC Regar-TadAZ of Tajikistan, kept its campaign alive with the win.

The Gaurs will face Kuwait's Qadsia SC on Friday. Only the group winners and the best second-placed side across all three groups in the West Zone will progress into the last eight.

The result: Fortis FC 1 (Tudu 78) lost to FC Goa 2 (Ortiz 6, Chiki 85).



Chiki.

Sindhu survives a scare to advance at French Open

Press Trust of India
PARIS

P.V. Sindhu survived a scare from Thailand's world No. 26 Supanida Katethong before advancing with a 21-14, 8-21, 23-21 win at the French Open Super 750 badminton tournament, in Paris on Wednesday.

The results (round of 32):
Women: P.V. Sindhu bt Supanida Katethong 21-14, 8-21, 23-21.
Riko Gunji bt Unnati Hooda 21-18, 12-21, 21-17.
Asmita Chaliha bt Hang Qian Xi 21-18, 24-22; Tanvi Sharma bt Isharani Baruah 21-12, 21-12.

Doubles: Lin Chih-Chun & Yang Chu Yun bt Treesa Jolly & Gayatri Gopi Chand 21-17, 21-18.

Men: Doubles: Christo Popov & Toma Junior Popov bt Satwiksairaj Rankireddy & Chirag Shetty 21-19, 18-21, 21-13.

Important to be backed as a spinner, says Shokeen

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

In recent seasons, Delhi's spin department in the Ranji Trophy has been a revolving door. Many tweakers have been tried and moved on without a semblance of stability.

Off-spinning all-rounder Hrithik Shokeen has had a taste of the environment. He made his First Class debut against Assam in December 2022, but has just played 17 games in five seasons. That includes one Duleep Trophy outing for India-C against India-D in 2024. In the last two Ranji campaigns, he appeared in two games each.

Having taken his maiden five-for on Wednesday, the 26-year-old will hope for a longer run now. He plugged away for 53 overs in Gujarat's first innings on a turgid track at the Palam 'B' ground and yielded returns of five for 143.



Hrithik Shokeen. R.V. MOORTHY

"It is my first five-for. So, it is very special," he told reporters. "I have spoken to coach Vijay Dahiya. He did say that our spinners have not been doing well. But he has given me confidence that I can do well. That backing is very important."

While it appears puzzling that Shokeen has had just 12 appearances across formats since December 2024, he disclosed that a stress fracture in his lower back has also contributed to the sporadic game time.

"I got injured last season. I have felt that Delhi has backed me. I had a setback because of the injury. My physio did say it was unusual for a spinner to have a back injury. I have worked on my bowling action as a result. I have improved the follow-through," Shokeen revealed.

PSG halts Barca; Liverpool fights back, City cruises

CHAMPIONS LEAGUE

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

Holder Paris Saint-Germain made it three wins from three in this season's Champions League, beating Barcelona 4-2 thanks to late goals from Vitinha and Fabian Ruiz, while Liverpool clinched a dramatic comeback victory over Villarreal on Tuesday.

Phil Foden scored a hattrick as Manchester City thrashed AEK Athens 5-1, while there were also much-needed wins for Roma and Napoli.

PSG kept its place at the top of the early league-phase table. Barcelona twice levelled but was ultimately well beaten as it slipped to its first defeat of the season.



Edging in front: Vitinha shoots in PSG's third against Barcelona. AFP

Liverpool battled back from two goals down to also maintain its 100-percent record by edging out Villarreal 4-3 at Anfield.

Roma eased to its first Champions League win since 2019 as the capital club brushed aside pointless Slovan Bratislava 4-0 at the Stadio Olimpico.

All four Serie A clubs in the competition lost last week, but Napoli made it two wins from two on Tuesday for the Italian sides.

Massimiliano Allegri's Napoli was twice pegged back by Bodo/Glimt but eventually got the better of the Norwegians in a 4-3 thriller.

Draw for Atletico

Atletico Madrid played out a 1-1 draw with Stuttgart in Germany, despite playing much of the second half with 10 men.

Borussia Dortmund ended a run of four straight away defeats in the Champions League with a 2-1 win over Sabah in Baku.

Fenerbahce suffered another setback after last week's humiliating 6-0 loss at Aston Villa, blowing a two-goal lead to be held 2-2 at home by Slavia Prague.

PSV Eindhoven clinched its first victory with a 1-0 success at Porto.

The results: Fenerbahce 2 (Aydin 4, Greenwood 11) drew with Slavia Prague 2 (Provod 15, Kacor 90); Sabah 1 (McCarthy 39) lost to Borussia Dortmund 2 (Guirassy 10, 53).

PSG 4 (Doue 38, Hernandez 72, Vitinha 81, Ruiz 86) bt Barcelona 2 (Espart 55, Yamal 79); Liverpool 4 (Mac Allister 36, 65, Araujo 45+2, Wirtz 69) lost to Villarreal 3 (Mikautadze 4, Cardona 29, Oluwaseyi 87).

Manchester City 5 (Anderson 12, Foden 34, 65, 76, Cherki 57) bt AEK Athens 1 (Pilios 52).

Roma 4 (Hermoso 21, Molina 39, Pisilli 52, Malen 58-pen) bt Slovan Bratislava 0.

Porto 0 lost to PSV Eindhoven 1 (Til 57).

Napoli 4 (Politano 1, McTominay 41, 75, Bjortuft 88-og) bt Bodo/Glimt 3 (Hauge 27, Helmersen 62, Brunstad Fet 90+4); Stuttgart 1 (Leweling 36) drew with Atletico Madrid 1 (Alvarez 47).

Pranavi Urs will look to carry her Asian Games confidence into the Indian Open women's golf

GOLF

Uthra Ganesan
GURUGRAM

With five former winners in the fray including the defending champion Shannon Tan, the 2026 Hero Women's Indian Open golf will not only be keen to live up to its reputation as the marquee event for the sport in the country but also be a challenge for Indians hoping to break through over the next four days.

Among those targeting a good showing and a possible title at the DLF Golf and Country Club here would be recently crowned Asian Games champion Pranavi Urs and her team-bronze winning comptriots Diksha Dagar and Aditi Ashok, the latter the only Indian till date to win the event in its 17 iterations way back in 2016. Singapore's Tan, who pulled off a come-from-behind one-stroke win against Alice Hewson in 2025 and finished third in Aichi-Nagoya, will be looking to burnish her reputation on the difficult course for the $500,000 event.



Pranavi. FILE PHOTO

She will have to contend with England's Liz Young (2024 winner), Germany's Olivia Cowan (2022), Camille Chevalier (2017) and Thailand's Pornanong Phatlum, a three-time winner and one of the 10 sponsor invitees.

Also in contention will be former LET Order of Merit winners Switzerland's Chiara Tamburlini and Thailand's Trichat Cheenglab.

Eleanor Givens of England, Thai Aunchisa Utama, Germany's Leonie Harm and Agathe Laisné of France are among the other winners this season.

Among other top Indians in the fray are Avani Prashanth and Vani Kapoor, both having finished among the top-10 last time around in what was one of the strongest overall performance by Indians in recent times.

Pranavi, expectedly in the spotlight after her victory on the final shot of the final day to become the first Indian woman to win the Asian Games, will hope to carry the confidence and the momentum over the weekend for a shot at her maiden title on the Ladies European Tour (LET).

The 23-year-old, who finished fourth last year, is among the four Indians from the LET in competition – besides Aditi, Diksha and Hitaashee Bakshi, who was third last time around after slipping on the final day. She has been paired with Tan and Camille for the first two days.

Athletics gold rush puts India fifth in the table

ASIAN PARA GAMES

Press Trust of India
NAGOYA

India's track-and-field contingent was on a roll, collecting 18 medals, including five gold, as the country climbed to fifth in the overall standings with 14 gold, 22 silver and 26 bronze, at the Asian Para Games on Wednesday.

Sprinter Simran, high-jumper Praveen Kumar and shot-putter Sachin Khilari set new Games records, while Dilip Gavit and Ayush Verma completed athletics' golden haul.

The visually-impaired Simran completed a double winning the women's 100m T12 in a Games record 12.02 seconds. Gavit clocked 10.69 seconds to claim the men's 100m T46/47 combined event.



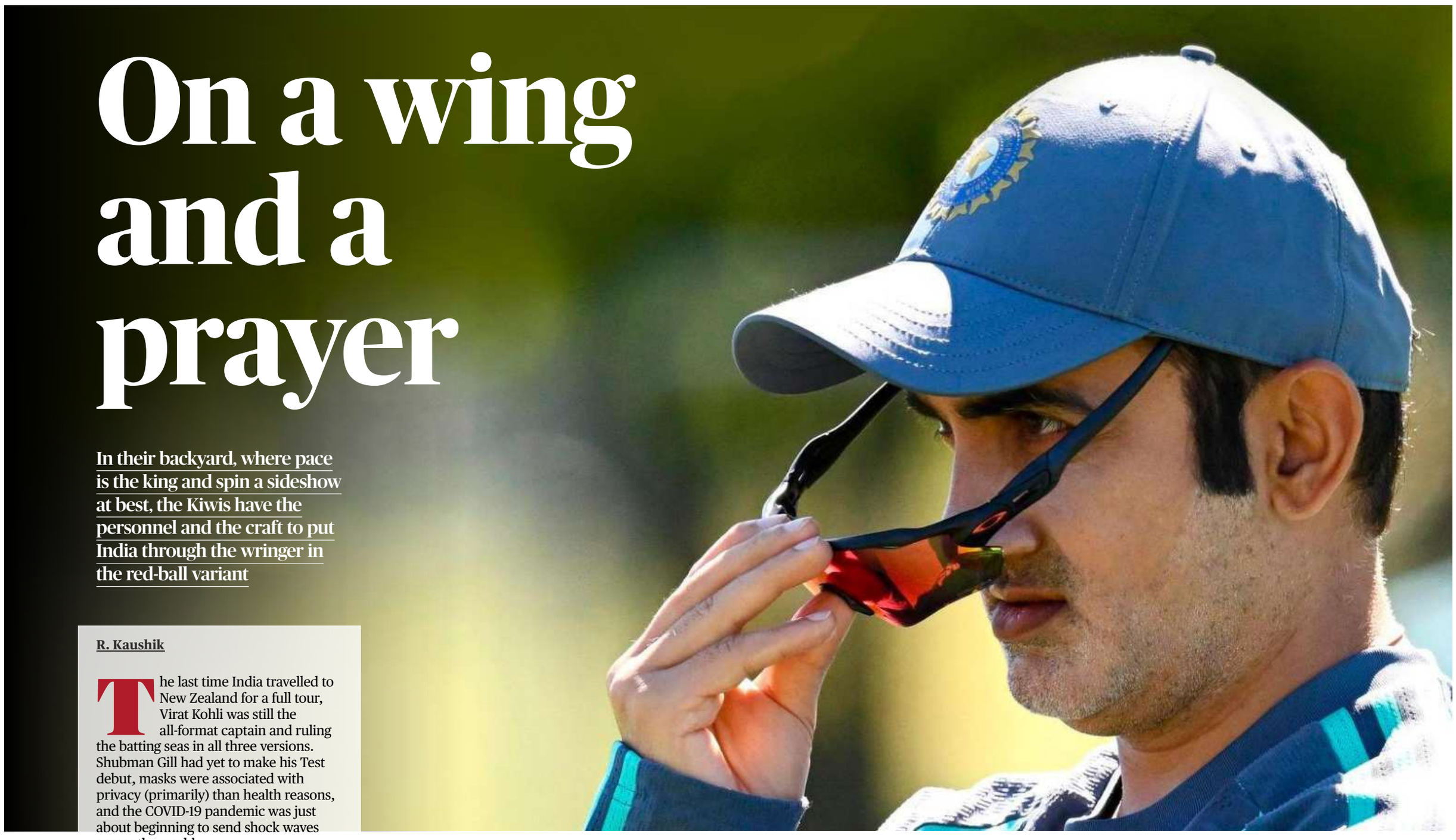
Praveen Kumar won the high jump T64 event. PTI

Praveen topped the men's high jump T44/64 with 2.05m effort and Sachin won the shot put F46 with a record 15.87m while Ayush triumphed in F53 category with 8.16m.

Preeti Pal added a women's 100m T35 silver, Banti finished second behind Praveen, and Bhagyashri Jadhav won silver in women's shot put F34. Manjeet took silver in men's javelin F12/13 while bronze medals came through Anubhav Choudhary (men's 100m T35) and Rakeshbhai Bhatt (men's 100m T37).

Armless archer Sheetal Devi and Payal Nag won silver in compound women's doubles, while swimmers Ravi Kartik Budigina and Himanshu Nandal won silver in men's 100m backstroke S13 and bronze in men's 100m breaststroke S11.

On a wing and a prayer



In their backyard, where pace is the king and spin a sideshow at best, the Kiwis have the personnel and the craft to put India through the wringer in the red-ball variant

R. Kaushik

The last time India travelled to New Zealand for a full tour, Virat Kohli was still the all-format captain and ruling the batting seas in all three versions. Shubman Gill had yet to make his Test debut, masks were associated with privacy (primarily) than health reasons, and the COVID-19 pandemic was just about beginning to send shock waves across the world.

That was in early 2020 – India played five Twenty20 Internationals, three One-Day Internationals and two Tests between January 29 and March 2 – when, as then head coach Ravi Shastri cheekily (?) pointed out, the tour ended in a 5-5 scoreline. Cute as that pronouncement was, there is no denying the fact that having started the journey convincingly with a 5-0 romp in the T20Is (including back-to-back Super Over triumphs), India were brushed aside in the next five matches.

Chastening loss

The most chastening of the defeats came in the Test series; India went down by 10 wickets in the first Test in Wellington and by seven in Christchurch (coincidentally, this year too, the tour winds down with Tests at these two venues in the same sequence), topping 200 just once in four innings. It was a bitter reality check for a team flying high on its 2-1 conquest of Australia in Australia just 14 months previously, a crushing blow that was the start of Kohli's spectacular fall from grace in the longer format.

More than six and a half years later, with vastly changed personnel, India will attempt to secure their first Test win on Kiwi soil since 2009, when Mahendra Singh Dhoni led the team to a much-awaited 1-0 series victory. Since that Test win at Hamilton's Seddon Park in March that year, the Indians have been winless in six matches, losing the last four, and therefore have a mountain to climb in their bid to end a long drought and wend themselves back into World Test Championship contention.

New Zealand in New Zealand are a formidable proposition even for the most experienced of Test sides, and India aren't exactly flash on that commodity following the retirements of Kohli, Rohit Sharma and R. Ashwin after and during the tour of Australia in 2024-25. There is promise aplenty and K.L. Rahul, the vice-captain, and Ravindra Jadeja stand as firm bridges between the glorious past and the potentially bright future, Gill has his work cut out.

India are meandering mid-table following a string of underwhelming performances in the five-day format and must win at least five of their remaining seven Tests to stand any chance of making a pitch for the WTC finals. Considering two of them are in New Zealand and five at home against Australia between January and March, it will be no exaggeration to state that India are facing a second league exit in as many cycles after having made the final on the two previous occasions, in which case one would expect the pressure on head coach Gautam Gambhir to mount, at least in theory. After a roaring start to the Gill era in England when, with a side that had very little first-hand taste of Test cricket overseas, India came away with an honourable 2-2 draw, the road has been rocky and arduous. A 2-0 win against West Indies at home was cancelled out by a similar drubbing, also at home, at the hands of WTC winners South Africa last November. India did win in Sri Lanka in August, but a 1-0 scoreline from two matches hasn't done their cause too many favours, which is why they now find themselves teetering on the brink of early elimination, hanging on to the edge of the precipice with fraying, chipped fingernails.

Sparking interest, debate

But the Test series is a long way away for the time being – just under four weeks to go for the first game at the Basin Reserve, to be more exact. Before that, there is the small matter of five T20Is (starting in Christchurch on Thursday), followed by five ODIs which will generate greater interest simply because of the two stalwarts whose progress and presence has sparked tremendous interest and debate. Let's focus first on the T20Is, and the latest chapter in a book that is becoming unmanageably thick with meaningless words and disjointed sentences. In the middle of a gruelling, demanding run that has seen them play in three different continents in the last five months, Shreyas Iyer's boys face a gun side that came out second best in the T20 World Cup final between the teams in Ahmedabad in March. India have seen a shake-up of sorts that has resulted in them moving past title-winning captain Suryakumar Yadav.

Shreyas has been given the responsibility of steering the ship, possibly till the next World Cup to be jointly hosted by New Zealand and Australia in two years' time. Apart from getting early insights into what to expect at the World Cup, to be held at the same time of the year, there is little to gain from these five matches that, coupled with the five ODIs and the two Tests, make it the longest tour in terms of international matches (12) undertaken by any side to New Zealand.

Having steadfastly proclaimed their desire to excise themselves from the distant past and target the future, India have thrown a curveball by bringing the seasoned Bhuvneshwar Kumar back into the fray after nearly four years. The 36-year-old has 90 T20I wickets in 88 appearances and his economy of 6.96 is little short of outstanding, though his return testifies to a lack of potency in the bowling group in the absence of Jasprit Bumrah, whose workload is being carefully monitored so that he is available and raring to go for the big occasions.

Lacking bite and consistency

India's support pace cast has been found badly wanting, their lack of bite and consistency thoroughly exposed during the white-ball series against West Indies earlier this month. Admittedly, they found little joy from the flat-as-pancake decks and dewy outfields that worked to their detriment, but even so, the cause for concern was so overwhelming that they had to go back to the past to ensure the immediate future isn't shot. Perhaps, some of it has to do with the fact that Ajit Agarkar is no longer the chief selector. Equally, much of it is a quick-fix arrangement; at this point, it isn't clear if Bhuvneshwar figures in the long-term plans or not, but there is no disputing the fact that his presence will lend the cutting edge so conspicuously absent when Bumrah isn't around.

Bhuvneshwar's first bowl in international cricket since November 2022 was delayed after the final T20I against West Indies in Bengaluru was washed out last Saturday, and he will be itching to hit the ground running in the same country where he played his last T20I. He should relish the conditions in New Zealand – an 8.00 p.m. local time start with summer yet to fully set in won't hurt either – and if he and Arshdeep Singh can strike up a useful combine, it should take a lot of pressure off the other bowlers.

The T20Is should serve as the appetiser to the feast that encompasses two main courses, starting with the first of five ODIs in Auckland on November 4

The T20Is should serve as the appetiser to the feast that encompasses two main courses, starting with the first of five ODIs in Auckland on November 4. In some ways, this is the start of the homestretch of preparations for the 50-over World Cup in southern Africa in less than a year's time. Conditions in New Zealand will largely mirror those that can be expected in South Africa and this will be a good run out for Gill's boys, who will again seek to draw inspiration from the gargantuan presence of Rohit and Kohli, inarguably two of the greatest white-ball batters of all time.

The debate over their futures laid to rest for the time being (at least) after a stellar run of scores that have exploded unfounded doubts about their commitment to the cause, Rohit and Kohli will use this opportunity to continue to entertain, enthral and enjoy whatever time they have at the highest level. It's not often that teams play five ODIs in a bilateral series anymore but given that the World Cup is the ultimate goal, it isn't the worst thing that those involved in these discussions have pencilled in five matches. Of course, India have withdrawn several players, including skipper Gill, for the last two ODIs, given their proximity to the Test series to follow. But that will in no way devalue the last two-fifths of the faceoff because of the context as well as the fact that Rohit and Kohli will still be around to guide the team and to encourage and educate stand-in skipper Shreyas as and when the need arises.

Own business to tend to

While much of the focus will be on India, even more so than on the home side, New Zealand have their own business to tend to. They are currently ranked No. 2 in the WTC standings, only behind their great trans-Tasman rivals Australia, and won't be unaware that a good result against the Indians will keep them firmly in the fray as they seek to emulate their heroics of the inaugural cycle when they defeated India in the final in Southampton. The Kiwis are also in the throes of transition, with former captain Kane Williamson no longer available for selection, but even though they tend to fly under the radar, they are always a formidable, competitive and skilful unit that will seek to maximise home advantage. New Zealand aren't the kind to rub into their opponents' faces the fact that they crushed India 3-0 in India in October-November 2024, but then again, they don't need to.

The wounds from that unexpected hammering are still festering, the scars still all too visible. Conditions in Wellington and Christchurch will be vastly different from Pune and Mumbai where left-arm spinners Mitchell Santner and Ajaz Patel made merry. In their backyard, where pace is the king and spin a sideshow at best, the Kiwis have the personnel and the craft to put India through the wringer in the red-ball variant.

Baptism by fire

This Test tour will be a big examination of the techniques and temperaments of young left-handed top-order batters Yashasvi Jaiswal and Devdutt Padikkal. If they can come through this baptism by fire with their reputations intact, if not enhanced, India can derive comfort from the truism that there is reason to look forward to the future with optimism.

By the time the Test series starts on November 19, though, there would have been no shortage of drama, that's for sure.



THE GIST

- India are meandering mid-table following a string of underwhelming performances in the five-day format and must win at least five of their remaining seven Tests to stand any chance of making a pitch for the WTC finals
- New Zealand in New Zealand are a formidable proposition even for the most experienced of Test sides, and India aren't exactly flash on that commodity following the retirements of Kohli, Rohit and Ashwin after and during the tour of Australia in 2024-25
- The Test tour will be a big examination of the techniques and temperaments of young left-handed top-order batters Jaiswal and Padikkal